

Hey There!

It's been a minute. How've you been? Make any dynasty trades that you'll probably regret over the last month and a half?

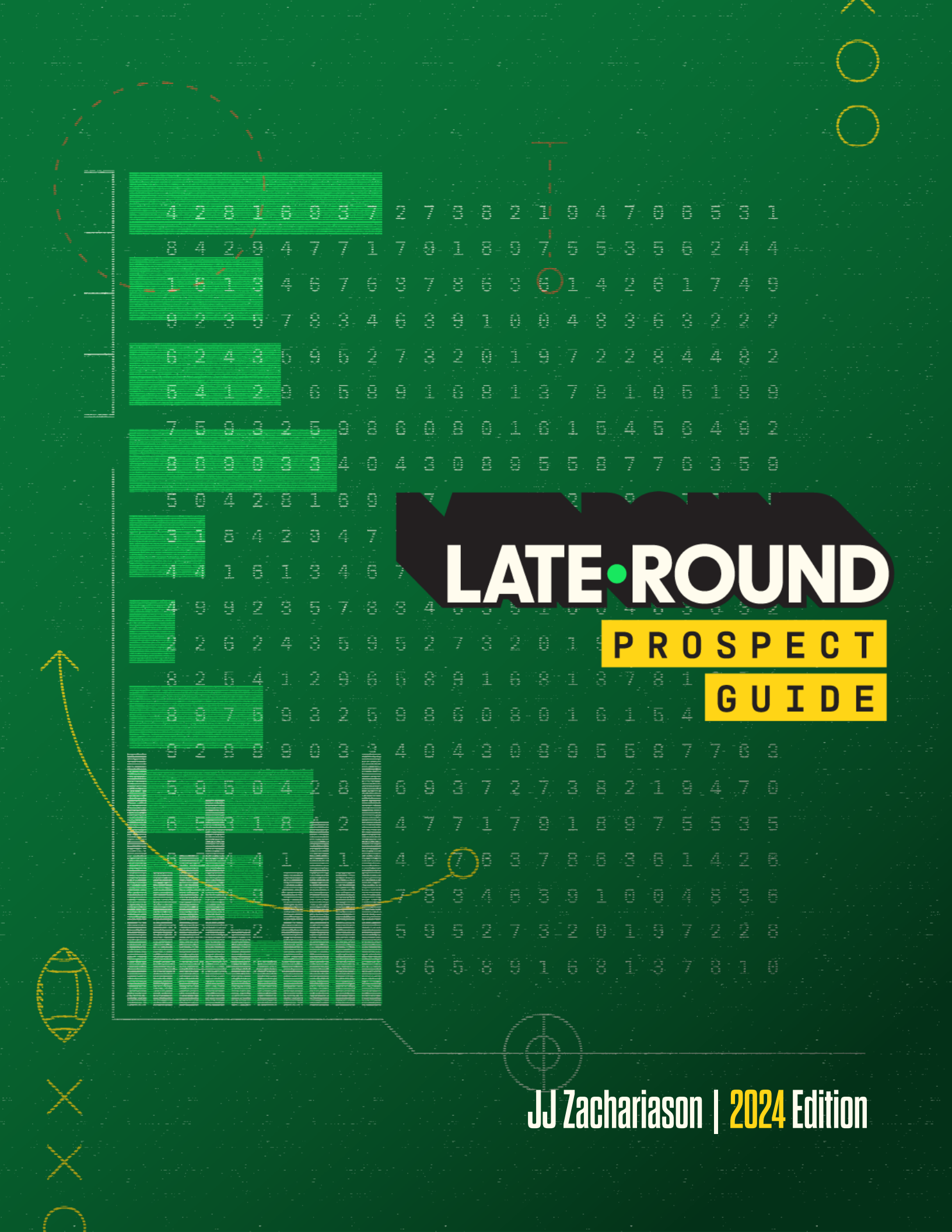
Same.

At least the NFL Draft happened, so now there's more opportunity for us to reshape those rosters.

And speaking of reshaping, this guide got a little post-draft makeover. Portions of it are the same as the pre-draft version — the Year 2 Model section is unchanged, as is the breakdown of what goes into the ZAP Model — but there are important modifications to note:

- All draft profiles now include an **updated ZAP Model score** along with their **Draft Capital Delta** risk profiles. (Only drafted players have Draft Capital Delta risk profiles.)
- Relevant, **higher-end rookies have an updated profile breakdown** that talks about the player's new outlook. On a player's profile page, you'll see the word "update" before their blurb, designating new information about the player.
- **Tight end ZAP scores** are now part of the guide. You can find them in the **Prospect Profiles** section.
- The **rookie rankings cheatsheet** is redone, and the **rookie rankings notes** are updated, too.
- **A new ZAP Model cheatsheet was created** to provide a snapshot of how the model views each player.

Ready to own some rookie drafts?



LATE-ROUND

PROSPECT

GUIDE

JJ Zachariason | 2024 Edition

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Introduction

My daughter's now in kindergarten, and she's learning how to read and write. She'll do what her teacher calls "brave spelling", where she'll sound out a word, say it aloud a few times, and then do her best to correctly write it out. It's easy to have doubts at five years old, so empowering her to go for it — to be brave — is important.

We were hanging out one evening when she enthusiastically told me that the letters "T" and "H" combine to make a "TH" sound, like in the word "the". She had no idea that was a thing before learning it in school that day. Proud, I asked her to spell "that", and, of course, she nailed it.

The next day, I had her spell the word "garage" on the way to the bus stop, just to test her skills out. It was, unsurprisingly, a struggle. "G..." she started. "G...A...R...J?" she continued.

It was a good brave spelling try, but she wasn't quite there.

She will be, though. Someday.

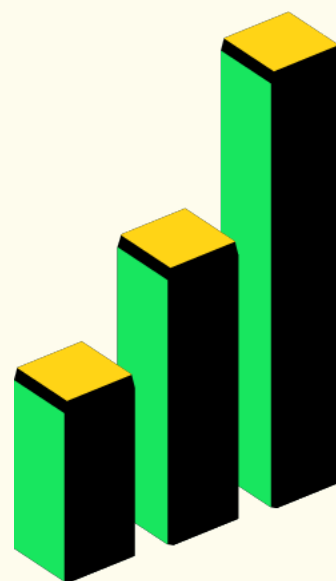
Because she's learning. She's getting better.

More importantly, she's *eager* to get better.

It's really easy to stop this process of obsessive learning as an adult. Most of us aren't going to school. We're not forced to read books. We know how to perform basic functions to survive in the real world, and that's good enough. What's the point in trying to overachieve at our job if the companies we work for aren't going to give us a reasonable pay bump anyway?

In the end, learning involves passion. My daughter doesn't just learn because she's forced to. She learns because she *wants* to.

Fantasy football is my passion. As nerdy as that is to say, I freaking love



this game about football.

And I'm always looking for ways to be better at it.

A handful of years ago, I created a couple of mathematical models that helped me navigate my dynasty fantasy football rookie drafts. (Did I mention that I'm a nerd?) Fantasy football is a game about football, sure, but it's a game about numbers, too. And it only seemed reasonable to think that numbers could help us figure out the best prospects in a given draft class.

The phrase "help us" is key there. Nothing in football analysis is perfect, whether you're talking data or film breakdowns. Your favorite scout doesn't bat a thousand, and neither does your preferred statistics geek.

A mathematical model won't give you all the answers. It'll just get you closer to the answers. And, when you're playing a game like fantasy football against other humans, that edge is usually all you need.

You just need to be a little bit better **than your competition.**

Those initial models I created? Yeah, uh, they were trash. They were flaming piles of garbage.

That's OK. Because I kept learning.

There were multiple fixes made to those first models, culminating with the Z-Prospect Model that a lot of you have read about over the last couple of years. That model helped us figure out the best running back and wide receiver values from the last two draft classes. Through probabilistic thinking, we — readers and myself included — were able to select Isiah Pacheco as a late-round gem. We were higher than the market on Jayden Reed last season. We understood that De'Von Achane's size was somewhat of a concern, but his landing spot and production profile were elite.

The Z-Prospect Model has been helpful. The results have been there.



The first version of the prospect model had some hits, like Aaron Jones and, to a lesser degree, Kenny Golladay. But there wasn't much substance to it all, and repeating success was difficult.

But I did some brave spelling this offseason.

And it led to some very cool, very new, and very worthwhile discoveries.

Introducing the ZAP Model.



The ZAP Model

Overview

The Z-Prospect Model isn't gone. It's just improved.

You can think of the ZAP Model — which stands for Zachariason-Adjusted Prospect Model — as a V2. It's like Charmander turning into Charmeleon. We're not quite to Charizard yet, but we're getting there.

A lot of the same inputs are in this upgraded model, but some fixes were made to make things simpler and, in the end, better.

The goal of the ZAP Model is the same as the Z-Prospect one.

It's trying to predict how well an offensive player will perform in fantasy football across his first three seasons in the league.

The thought process behind this mission is that you're going to have a general idea of how good a player is after his first three years as a pro. Late-career breakouts happen, but not frequently.

You can measure three-year success in a lot of different ways. Should we focus on a player's raw fantasy total during the timeframe? His average points per game across the three seasons?

There's no singular "best" way, in my eyes, but I used the infamous B2S method for the ZAP Model.

Come again?

B2S means “best two seasons”. It looks at a player’s first three years in the NFL, takes his top-two seasons in points per game in point per reception (PPR) leagues, and it averages those seasons out.

Imagine a world where a wide receiver scored 11 points per game as a rookie, 12 points per game as a second-year player, and 15 points per game as a third-year one. With B2S, we’d throw out the rookie-season number, and we’d averaged the 12 and 15 rates together. His B2S, then, would be 13.5.

You can certainly run into issues with season-long points per game averages. If a player only plays two games, but he scores 24 points per game in those contests, are we to assume that he’d maintain that pace across a full 17-game season?

That doesn’t seem logical.

In order to get genuine and reasonable averages, there’s a minimum threshold of eight games that needs to be met by a player for his season to count. Otherwise, the player is taking a zero for that season.

Going back to our example, if that wideout had only played five games during his second year in the league and at least 12 in his other two, then his B2S wouldn’t be 13.5. It’d be 13. Rather than taking his second season as one of the data points to average, we’d toss that and look at his rookie season where he played more than eight games.

This is cool and all (maybe “cool” isn’t the right descriptor), but the question you — I — need to be asking is: How do we actually predict a player’s B2S? How do we get to the point where any of this matters?

I’ve worked with a lot of college football data over the years. With that experience, I’ve been able to put together formulas at running back, wide receiver, and tight end that do effectively tell us who the best prospects are in each class for fantasy purposes.

And I know that because of testing.

With any model, you want to make sure it works. Anyone can throw some



numbers together and claim to have an answer. If those numbers aren't meaningful — if they're not solving anything — then what's the point?

This is where draft capital starts to play a role in this story.

Draft capital is simply where a player was selected in the NFL Draft. Bijan Robinson had top-10 draft capital last year. Puka Nacua was a Day 3 pick, so his draft capital was much lower.

Hypothetically, if NFL teams were brilliant at scouting, then we wouldn't need tools to help us during our rookie drafts.

We could instead just look at an NFL Draft board and select players based on where they were picked. The first running back would be the RB1, the second running back the RB2, and so on.

When testing my models, draft capital is the first thing I test against. It's the first thing I look at to know whether or not the models are worthwhile. If the model is no better at predicting B2S than draft capital itself, then, again...what's the point?

Each prospect model that you'll read about is better at predicting B2S than draft capital itself.

This is probably a good time to point out *who* is being tested, eh? Which players am I looking at here?

The wide receiver and running back models look at all players who were invited to the NFL Combine or who were drafted since 2011. There's typically a ton of overlap there — if a player gets drafted, he usually was a combine participant. But we get one or two guys each season who sort of get drafted out of nowhere.

The tight end model is a bit different, as it looks only at drafted players at the position. More on that later.

Where were we again? Oh, right. Draft capital.

The models themselves are more helpful to look at for B2S purposes than draft capital itself. But what really takes them to the next level is when draft capital becomes an actual input into the models.

Look. My goal isn't to predict where a running back or wide receiver will get drafted. It's not to tell you if a player should get scooped up in Round 2 or Round 5 of the NFL Draft. There are plenty of analysts who are *great* at that.

That's not my game.

My game is to help you win at fantasy football. Period.

The last time I checked, there's no medal awarded for ignoring draft capital when making a selection during your rookie draft. Some rookie drafts do happen before the NFL Draft goes down, sure, but the vast majority of league drafts occur when Roger Goodell's bro hugs are in the rearview.

Why would we *not* use that information?

People may not want to hear this, but draft capital is the single most important factor in the ZAP Model. NFL teams are putting millions and millions of dollars into their draft-day decisions. They have teams of scouts and analytics people helping them optimize those choices. I'm just a dude living in my mom's basement.

Why would I ignore that input?

The ZAP Model works without draft capital, but it's lightyears better with it. And it's what really makes it a powerful tool.

To be clear, though, we're not trying to just beat the NFL during our rookie drafts. Being more predictive than draft capital alone is great and



Most leagues have their rookie drafts after the NFL Draft concludes, but consider joining one where rookie drafts happen beforehand. You can obtain some huge values if you've done enough studying.

all, but it's more helpful to be better than our actual competition — our leaguemates.

Fortunately, the ZAP Model is better at predicting B2S than rookie draft average draft position (ADP) as well. In other words, if you were to blindly follow the ZAP Model instead of some ADP data — which is formulated by the fantasy football masses — then you'd come out on top more often than not.

Cool? Cool.

You ready to learn about what goes into this thing now?

The Wide Receiver Model

Breakout Age is a commonly used metric for wide receivers in the numbers-driven prospecting space. It's based on the idea that a player who produces early in his collegiate career is likely better than a player who only produces late. If a 10-year-old can play *Canon in D* on the piano the same way a 17-year-old can, chances are, when both piano players hit 20, the 10-year-old will be better.

To calculate Breakout Age, most look at the age of a player when he hits a certain threshold in Dominator Rating. To put that another way, they'll look at how old a player was when he matched or exceeded a particular percentage of team receiving production.

Despite Breakout Age being part of my earlier models — it got signal — I've always had issues with it. The main one being that it's too binary. It's too black and white. A wideout could be *this* close to hitting the proper threshold, but, if he didn't, he'd be lumped in with the Joe Shmo who caught three passes all season long.

The ZAP Model at wide receiver doesn't rely on Breakout Age. Instead, I've developed a different methodology called *Breakout Score*.

A player's Breakout Score at wide receiver is determined by his age when hitting multiple adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt thresholds.



Yeah, I'm going to need to explain that.

Receiving yards per team pass attempt is exactly what you think it is. It looks at a player's receiving yards in a given season, and it divides that by the number of pass attempts his team threw. It's one of the cleanest, most-predictive metrics you can find at wide receiver.

The "adjusted" piece is telling you that the player's receiving yards per team pass attempt rate is being fixed — adjusted — for both games played (prorated) and strength of competition.

In order for a season to count towards a wide receiver's Breakout Score, he needed to have played at least six games. Because, remember, we're looking at yards per team pass attempt on a per-game basis here. That at least gives us somewhat of a sample to work off of.

As it pertains to competition — that piece isn't as complicated as you might think. A player hitting high-end marks in receiving yards per team pass attempt at Alabama is much more impressive than a player doing the same thing at South Alabama. No shade to any Jaguars out there — we just know Alabama is a powerhouse program. Understanding where a wide receiver played collegiate ball and where he produced (a lot of players transfer these days) is key, and the model adjusts for that.

Breakout Score has a much stronger correlation to B2S than Breakout Age does. And it makes the ZAP Model a lot more effective.

Another production-based piece to the model is kind of an obvious-yet-untapped one: fantasy points per game.

Generally speaking, when a player has a higher fantasy points per game (PPR) average in college, he'll have a higher one in the NFL, too. When that's adjusted for the school he went to and the number of pass attempts his team had, you get a Fantasy Points Score.

Lastly, when it comes to the production-focused stuff, there's rushing yards. This doesn't get as much weight in the model as receiving yards per team pass attempt (Breakout Score) or fantasy points per game (Fantasy Points Score), but it does help a wide receiver out.

When a player is used in a lot of different ways at the collegiate level, it's likely because his coaches want to put the ball in his hands. In college football, you'll often see some of the best players return punts and kicks. Or you'll see top wide receivers get more work than usual as runners. That's because those are low-risk ways to give playmakers the rock.

This is probably why something as simple as rushing yards helps the model. Because it's not only telling us that a player is versatile. It's telling us that he's talented.

So, on the production end of things, that's really what we're working with at wide receiver. There's Breakout Score, which focuses solely on adjusted and prorated receiving yards per team pass attempt. There's fantasy points per game, which helps create a Fantasy Points Score. And then there's just a little bit of rushing production sprinkled on top.

A couple of other factors formulate a wide receiver's ZAP score.

Early-declare status is one.

There's been a lot of controversy around the predictability of early-declare status. Maybe there's not a lot of chatter about the topic at the dinner table, but it's out there.

The big-brained thinking around early-declare status isn't much different than something like Breakout Age: If a player decides to leave college early — if he declares early for the draft — chances are, that player is better than one who chooses to stick around another year.

Why would a wide receiver want to forgo his Senior season for the NFL? Probably because he's projected to get drafted fairly high, right? And the only way he'd be slotted to go early in the NFL Draft is if he was good at the game.

That's why early-declare status gets a little bit of weight.

Name, image, and likeness (NIL) deals are more than likely going to shift the importance of early-declare status as the years go on. When a player can make millions in college, he may actually want to just hang out there for a minute rather than going pro. So there's a chance early-declare status becomes more and more obsolete with future model fixes.

For now, it's an input. It's not a massive input — not the way many in the analytics world view it — but it's an input.

One last thing: Teammate Score. When a wide receiver plays alongside high-caliber wide receiver teammates in college, it seems to matter. It's not a complex calculation, but know that teammate quality isn't irrelevant within the ZAP Model at wide receiver.

After joining all of these things — age-adjusted production metrics, early-declare status, and Teammate Score — draft capital gets layered on top. Those factors, then, create a wide receiver's ZAP score.

Wait a second. Is that...is that athleticism's music?

Some may be wondering when NFL Combine measurables come into play.

At wide receiver, they don't.

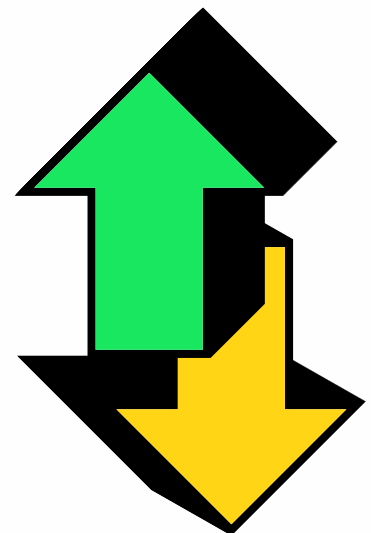
That may sound crazy. Shouldn't a bigger-bodied, physically-gifted wide receiver be highly sought after?

Not necessarily.

Subjectively, you probably would want an enormous and athletic wide receiver on your team over a tiny and slow one.



Over the last two seasons — aligning closely to when college athletes started getting endorsement deals — we have indeed seen the percentage of early-declare wide receivers at the NFL Combine drop.



But it's **very rare** for completely unathletic wide receivers to get drafted early in the first place.

Part of the reason size and athleticism aren't a big deal in the wide receiver model is because those things are likely already captured in draft capital. And draft capital is in the wide receiver model.

Not only that, but wide receivers do different jobs on a football field. Cooper Kupp doesn't win the same way DK Metcalf does. Keenan Allen doesn't do the same things Mike Evans does. Metcalf and Evans are more physically dominant, and even though they're highly productive as pros, Kupp and Allen are, too.

If a player completely bombs the NFL Combine — and I'm talking like, 15th percentile marks across the board — you'd probably want to remove that player from your consideration set. Chances are, though, that same player won't have good draft capital, and he likely wouldn't have had the best college production profile. So, in the end, the lack of athleticism and size doesn't matter much because more important dynamics weren't going his way.

This is why it was difficult to knock Devonta Smith's size when he was entering the league in 2021. Was his low BMI a concern? Slightly, I suppose. But Smith had an absurd production profile while being selected 10th overall. To me, the biggest knock was the fact that he wasn't an early-declare wide receiver, not the fact that he's a skinny dude. He ended up grading out as an elite player in the model as a result.

The Running Back Model

De'Von Achane and Jahmyr Gibbs broke everyone's models in 2023. Or, that's what analytics haters on social media want you to think.

Size matters at running back. The vast majority of high-end running back seasons in fantasy football have come from backs who weighed in around 210 pounds or more.

Achane's Unique
Size



De'Von Achane is the only running back in the ZAP Model database who was drafted in the top-100 of the NFL Draft while weighing under 190 pounds at the combine.

And, yeah, a statistic like that is definitely skewed by sample size. There are more running backs in the NFL who are above, say, 200 pounds than below that mark. And of the sub-200-pounders, most weren't drafted very high. Most weren't looked at as good prospects.

But even when you adjust for all of that, size still comes in as a factor for fantasy backs. And it's a part of the ZAP Model.

This isn't my opinion, either. I actually think plenty of 190-pound running backs could've been fine as fantasy assets through the years. It's just that, in general, they don't see as much work. Volume drives fantasy football, so if coaches have some inherent weight biases, then we need to as well.

This doesn't mean that smaller running backs won't look favorable in the ZAP Model.

Jahmyr Gibbs, in fact, had an *amazing* score in last year's guide, and it looks almost identical within this revamped formula. Achane sat in a great tier, too.

Because there's more to this thing than just size.

Just like at wide receiver, the running back ZAP Model has a Breakout Score. Instead of it being focused on receiving yards per team pass attempt, though, it looks at total yards per team play. It's a similar metric, but total yards per team play considers all yards created by a player on offense before dividing that number by the total pass and rush attempts made by a team in a given year.

A running back's Breakout Score essentially gives us an age-adjusted look at total yards per team play. It doesn't get as much weight in the model as Breakout Score does for wide receivers, but it's a new and important feature to a running back's overall prospect tally.

The only other production metric used in the running back model is an oldie but a goodie: reception share.

If you've noticed, all of the metrics I've talked about thus far are team-focused. They're market share-related statistics. Something like yards per game might work in some models, but, typically, a metric like that isn't all that predictive in college football. Because collegiate offenses differ dramatically from one unit to the next.

The 2023 Liberty Flames, for example, threw the ball 21.6 times per game. The Hawaii Rainbow Warriors had nearly double that amount. Would it really be fair to compare a pass-catcher from one of those teams to the other? Of course not. Players on Hawaii would have an easier time gobbling up receiving numbers.

With reception share, you're analyzing the percentage of receptions a player had within his offense. It gives us much more of an apples to apples comparison from one player to the next.

In the ZAP Model's case, a player's best-season in reception share is what's being counted. And that's on a per-game basis with a minimum of six games played in a season.

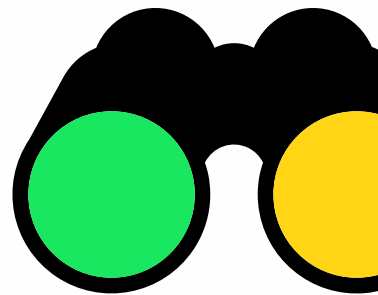
Unlike the wide receiver model, there *is* one NFL Combine measurable that the running back ZAP Model likes: 40-yard dash time.

Don't you roll your eyes at me!

Technically, raw 40 times aren't all that helpful. What *is* helpful is Speed Score, or weight-adjusted 40 time. Back in the day, Bill Barnwell thought of the metric after recognizing that not all 40-yard dashers are alike. It's more impressive when a 240-pound running back runs a 4.4 40 versus a 190-pound one.

And the model mostly agrees.

For reference, a solid Speed Score is typically around 100. When a running back is at or below 92, his ZAP score starts to get dinged. When a back gets over the 112 mark, the opposite happens. So the model really only looks at the extremes with Speed Score — most players are not impacted by it whatsoever.



Before adding draft capital on top, there are two more things that the running back model looks at. The first is draft-day age. We have a Breakout Score for running backs, yes, but if a back is older when he's drafted, that's not a good sign.

We've also got a Teammate Score. Similar to the wide receiver model, if a running back played with a reasonably talented teammate, his score gets boosted a tad — players in those situations may naturally have a tougher time posting strong numbers.

So, to recap, it's size (weight), age-adjusted total yards per team play (Breakout Score), prorated reception share, Speed Score, draft-day age, Teammate Score, and draft capital.

Those are the ingredients that create a running back's ZAP score.

The Tight End Model

My prospecting through numbers efforts, for years, had been channeled towards wide receivers and running backs. Those positions mean the most to fantasy football. Why wouldn't I put a lot of time and energy into figuring them out?

The tight end position was feeling a little lonely.

So, last offseason, I set out to solve *that* equation.

Tight end is just a different beast when compared to wide receiver and running back. Fewer of them are starting each week in fantasy football, so we're working off of different sample sizes. Not only that, but the position has really transformed through the years — that can make samples more difficult to work with.

During the winter and spring months of 2023 — we're talking less than a year ago, depending on when you're reading this thing — I concocted some form of a tight end model. And I shared it with Late-Round Fantasy Football newsletter subscribers.

It, honestly, was a hit.



Any guesses as to which tight end was viewed as the top prospect since 2015 according to the ZAP Model? Yeah. It's Kyle Pitts.

The model loved Sam LaPorta last year. It had Michael Mayer in a clear tier below him, when the market suggested otherwise. Luke Musgrave and Tucker Kraft were looked at favorably, too.

There's some back-patting going on here, yes. You're not mistaken. And I feel weird about it. Anyone else feel weird?

The reason for it, though, is because, without the 2023 season, I'm not sure I'd have the confidence to publish the tight end model here in 2024. One year probably shouldn't make or break that confidence, but here we are. I'm only human.

As I mentioned, there's a different type of sample to work off of with tight ends. Plenty of them end up just being offensive line extensions in the NFL. There aren't many true difference-making pass-catchers at the position. And, in fantasy football, we're starting just one of them in our standard lineup. That means fewer of them are relevant for fantasy purposes.

All of these things — and data limitations — led me to working with a different overall sample compared to running back and wide receiver. Instead of analyzing all tight ends who've been to the NFL Combine since 2011, the tight end model assesses tight ends who've been drafted since 2015.

The tight end model is a little more simplistic than the other two. Because tight ends typically aren't giving us monster rookie-season numbers, measuring off of B2S isn't as useful. The model, instead, measures against a tight end's top season in PPR points per game across his first three in the league.

Draft capital, of course, is part of the tight end process, but it actually gets a little less weight than it does with wide receiver and running back.

Athletic measurables get *more* weight.

Well, one athletic measurable does: Speed Score.

Bigger, faster tight ends **tend to be better at fantasy football** than smaller, slower tight ends.

There's no Breakout Score in the tight end model. Draft-day age is a factor, but age-adjusted production is calculated a little differently. Rather than using a metric like receiving yards per team pass attempt or total yards per team play to come up with a Breakout Score, the model looks at yards per route run numbers. It takes a tight end's average yards per route run (minimum 50 routes run) across all of his collegiate seasons.

That means the tight end model really just consists of draft capital, Speed Score, yards per route run, and draft-day age. There's more to it — there are particular combinations and thresholds a tight end can hit to boost his score. Like, for instance, a tight end being drafted in the top-150 with a favorable Speed Score...he gets a bump in his prospect score for that. Those are the types of things the model is analyzing. But those four inputs make up the model in totality.

Historical Results

One beautiful part about prospecting through data is that you can test and see if your process is working.

Score	Wide Receiver (Best Two-Year Average; Years 1-3)						
	< 10	10+	12+	14+	16+	18+	20+
95-100	24%	76%	60%	44%	20%	12%	4%
90-95	46%	54%	31%	31%	19%	4%	4%
85-90	68%	32%	32%	20%	12%	4%	0%
80-85	73%	27%	23%	8%	0%	0%	0%
75-80	73%	27%	19%	8%	0%	0%	0%
70-75	85%	15%	15%	15%	4%	0%	0%
65-70	83%	17%	4%	4%	0%	0%	0%
60-65	93%	7%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%
55-60	93%	7%	7%	0%	0%	0%	0%
50-55	97%	3%	3%	3%	3%	3%	0%

The table above provides the results of the wide receiver model from 2011 through 2021. The reason 2022 and 2023 aren't part of the

dataset is because those players haven't played three years in the league yet.

The left column shows ZAP scores. As you can probably guess, ZAP scores range from 0 all the way to 100, with 100 being the most impressive. To make things consumable, the scores are bucketed in increments of five.

The middle of the table tells you the percentage of players from that score's group to have averaged a particular points per game mark in B2S.

Pretend a wide receiver scored 10, 12, and 17 PPR points per game across his first three seasons in the league. And assume he played every possible game.

As we know, with B2S, we'd throw out that average of 10 and focus solely on his outputs of 12 and 17. Averaging those out, the player would have a B2S of 14.5, placing him in the "14+" column (and the ones below "14+") but not the "16+" one.

Now that you're a table-reading master, you can see that not everything is butterflies and rainbows with the wide receiver model. We shouldn't expect it to be. It's not going to be perfect.

What's most important is the high-level trends.

As scores get worse, so do the B2S results. The vast majority of elite players — wideouts with B2S rates above 16 PPR points per game — have ZAP scores in the 90s. Meanwhile, it's rare for a wide receiver under the 60 mark to give you good production.

Something that needs to be said: If a lower-ranked bucket appears better than a higher-ranked one, it doesn't mean you would want a wide receiver from the group with the lower scores. There's some variance when arbitrarily grouping players.

The running back visual looks a lot like the wide receiver one...



Score	Running Back (Best Two-Year Average; Years 1-3)						
	< 10	10+	12+	14+	16+	18+	20+
95-100	15%	85%	75%	70%	45%	30%	20%
90-95	35%	65%	40%	20%	15%	10%	0%
85-90	50%	50%	22%	17%	17%	11%	6%
80-85	63%	38%	25%	19%	13%	0%	0%
75-80	65%	35%	18%	6%	6%	0%	0%
70-75	83%	17%	11%	0%	0%	0%	0%
65-70	88%	12%	6%	0%	0%	0%	0%
60-65	85%	15%	8%	8%	8%	8%	0%
55-60	88%	13%	6%	0%	0%	0%	0%
50-55	93%	7%	7%	7%	0%	0%	0%

When we get a running back over a score of 95, good things happen. Only one running back with a score *below* that tally has hit the elusive 20-plus points per game mark in B2S: Alvin Kamara.

Lastly, we've got tight end.

Score	Tight End (Max Year; Years 1-3)						
	<6	6+	8+	10+	12+	14+	16+
90-100	0%	100%	100%	89%	56%	11%	11%
80-90	30%	70%	50%	10%	0%	0%	0%
70-80	86%	14%	14%	0%	0%	0%	0%
60-70	77%	23%	8%	8%	0%	0%	0%
50-60	75%	25%	13%	0%	0%	0%	0%
<50	92%	8%	4%	0%	0%	0%	0%

Not bad!

Remember, we're looking to predict a tight end's top season in PPR points per game over his first three in the league. Since 2015, no tight end under a score of 90 has been able to score 12 or more PPR points per game in a season. That'll definitely change as we accumulate more tight end data, but it gives us a really nice baseline to work with.

These tables are important to keep in mind as you read through the guide. I'll be providing scores for every relevant prospect this season, and you can use those scores to get a rough idea of a player's hit rate.

Draft Capital Delta

I've talked a lot about draft capital and its influence in the models. Since it's a big input, there's a connection between how one of the models sees a player and where that player was drafted.

Not only that, but good players are often beloved in both film evaluation *and* numbers-based analysis. Ja'Marr Chase has one of the best ZAP scores in the database, but traditional scouting saw Chase as an insanely good prospect, too. There's an obvious overlap in the way the model may view a player and the way the NFL — draft capital — does.

What about when there's not?

That's where Draft Capital Delta comes into play.

Draft Capital Delta measures the difference between a player's ZAP score and where he was selected in the NFL Draft. It's essentially showing us how the models view a player when draft capital isn't a factor.

Take, for instance, Aaron Jones, owner of the highest Draft Capital Delta in the running back database. Jones had a ZAP score of 79.5 back in 2017. Well, the ZAP Model wasn't created then, but his score *would have been* 79.5.

His draft capital score, based on going 182nd overall in the NFL Draft, was 54.5. The difference — the delta — between those numbers is +25.

That's Aaron Jones' Draft Capital Delta.

Favorable Draft Capital Deltas tend to lead to better outcomes in expected B2S. In other words, when a running back or wide receiver — tight end doesn't have Draft Capital Delta at the moment — has a good Draft Capital Delta, he ends up exceeding B2S expectation at a higher pace than a player with a bad Draft Capital Delta.

With previous versions of the guide, I've provided that raw Draft Capital Delta number. You saw that Isiah Pacheco's was high, and that Jonathan



Of all running backs selected in the top-100 of the NFL Draft since 2011, the top two in Draft Capital Delta are David Johnson and Kareem Hunt. Neither player went to a Power Five school.

Mingo's wasn't.

What did those numbers even mean, though?

That was a question I asked myself — the creator of these nerdy prospect formulas — this past year. Draft Capital Delta is neat and can be helpful, but what's the difference between a +10 and a -3? Does it matter that much?

It seems pretty random, no?

One of the issues with displaying Draft Capital Delta so prominently over the last couple of seasons was that some viewed it as being just as important as a player's prospect score. That shouldn't be the case. At all.

A prospect with a score of 80 and a Draft Capital Delta of +7 is not better than a prospect with a score of 90 and a Draft Capital Delta of -3. It's just that the player with the 90 score may have a little more risk to his profile, since the model is viewing him less favorably than draft capital itself.

Another key point to make is that Draft Capital Delta sees a larger range with later-round picks than it does with earlier-round ones. That's due to draft capital getting more weight in the models for early-round selections.

Think of it this way: If a running back is drafted 20th overall, no matter what his production profile looks like, he's going to have a high probability of scoring at least some fantasy points in the NFL. That's not the case for a back who's selected in Round 4 or Round 5. We have to lean more on the non-draft-capital aspects to his profile, since teams are largely throwing darts on Day 3.

So, with all that being noted, moving forward, we're throwing out the individual, unique Draft Capital Delta numbers per player. That's not what's important. The ZAP score is.

In its place — and this only goes for drafted players, for the record — you’ll see a more binary risk profile. When a player has an alarming Draft Capital Delta, it’ll be called out as a “high risk” profile. When the Draft Capital Delta is really strong, it’ll be a “low risk” outlook. For someone who’s neither high or low, they’ll get tagged with a “neutral” descriptor. And this is all adjusted for draft capital.

Draft Capital Delta can help us find gems, but it’s not the key metric we should be working off of.

Adding Subjectivity

Dan Campbell chose to keep his offense on the field on fourth-and-three in 49ers territory toward the end of this year’s NFC Championship game. He could’ve attempted a field goal, but, instead, he went for it.

“The analytics” said that the decision was essentially a coin flip. There was no clear-cut, obvious answer.

“Greg from Twitter” said that Dan Campbell is a moron and that you “have to take the points.”

The result of the play was an incomplete pass, but that conclusion isn’t really what’s key. The process is. Campbell made a call based on the information he had. And not all of that information was mathematical in nature. Some of it was feel-based.

And that’s OK.

A fourth-down bot isn’t going to solve all of your problems. It’s merely providing the probability of a particular outcome to go down. If, in the moment, Campbell felt like his kicker wasn’t reliable, then he could — and did — opt to go for it.

The data was there to let him know that either choice was reasonable.

You don’t have to agree with numbers all the time. / don’t agree with numbers all the time.



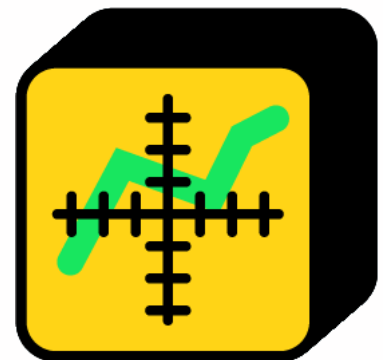
When a running back gets tagged with a high- or low-risk profile, it’s worth noting. Historically, low-risk running backs have been more than twice as good in B2S as high-risk ones.

This is a guide, and the numbers — the prospect scores — are a guide, too.

Seeing how a player looks in a model can be helpful, **but I'll never tell you to stop there.** Looking at a player's journey and — gasp — watching the player play is always a solid idea as well.

You can follow the prospect models and find success.

You can likely be even better with some rational thought piled on top.



2024 Prospect Profiles

Overview

It's rare for a running back or wide receiver to emerge as a star in the league without an NFL Combine invite. It certainly happens — Austin Ekeler and Adam Thielen both became studs after being skipped over.

But just because there are exceptions to the rule doesn't mean the rule is invalid.

Strictly from a probability perspective, for fantasy football purposes, we should care most about the players who were invited to the NFL Combine. Period. That shouldn't be debated.

So that's where the focus is at for these prospect profiles.

There were 39 wide receivers invited to this year's NFL Combine. There were 29 running backs who were awarded the same honor.

I profiled them. **Every single one of them.** I looked at their analytical profiles, and I studied the type of player they may be at the next level.

These outlooks are bound to change post-draft — and when they do, I'll send you an updated version of this guide — but it's never a bad idea to have a good grasp on a class before the draft happens.

Tight end scores will be published post-draft, too. For now, the focus is on running back and wide receiver.

Note: Player profiles are ordered by projected draft capital as of mid-February.

Key Terms

ZAP Score: The score given to an incoming rookie in the ZAP Model. It's based on the factors outlined in the ZAP Model Overview section of this guide. For pre-draft scores, the draft capital input is based on projected draft capital from NFLMockDraftDatabase.com. All scores range from 0 to 100.

Breakout Score: The score given to a player for his age-adjusted production. This is based on yards per team pass attempt for wide receivers and total yards per team play for running backs. All scores range from 0 to 100.

Fantasy Points Score: The score given to a wide receiver for his fantasy point production. This is based on a player's fantasy points per game average adjusted for team pass attempts and program strength. All scores range from 0 to 100.

B2S: The ZAP Model attempts to predict how well a player will do in fantasy football across his first three years in the league. In doing this, it tests against the average of a player's top-two seasons in PPR points per game during his first three years as a pro. This is referred to as B2S (Best Two Seasons).

Draft Capital Delta: The difference between a player's ZAP score versus where he was drafted in the actual NFL Draft. A very low Draft Capital Delta will be displayed as a "high risk" profile. A very high one will be shown as a "low risk" profile. Most players will simply be "neutral". **Draft capital deltas will be published in the post-draft version of the guide.**

Speed Score: A concept developed by Bill Barnwell to help appropriately weight 40-yard dash times based on a player's size. In the ZAP Model, anything under 92 at running back is a red flag. Anything over 112 is a positive indicator.

Statistical Comparables: Players in history who appear to have similar analytical profiles to the player being analyzed. This is based on things like size, age, Breakout Score, and other production metrics.

Running Back

BLAKE CORUM		 79.1 ZAP Score	
RB	Michigan Wolverines (Los Angeles Rams)		Low Risk Neutral High Risk
Height:	5'8"	Weight:	205
Statistical Comps: Clyde Edwards-Helaire ▪ Darrell Henderson ▪ Kendall Hunter			
Update: Well, that's not ideal, is it? Blake Corum was drafted by the Rams, which is kind of funny, because former Ram Darrell Henderson is one of his top comps. What's <i>not</i> funny is the fantasy football mess that this brings. With Kyren Williams coming off the season he had, Corum's unlikely to grab a big share of the team's backfield. The ZAP Model isn't in love with him anyway. He's a little undersized, had a totally ordinary Speed Score, and just had solid-but-not-great marks in reception share and Breakout Score. He's just a clean, versatile back who can be plugged into most offenses. He just likely won't take over the backfields in those offenses. A ZAP score under 80 isn't ideal. Only CJ Anderson, Devonta Freeman, Aaron Jones, Myles Gaskin, James Robinson, and Kyren Williams have been able to score more than 16 PPR points per game in a season during their first three years in the league after failing to reach an 80 ZAP score. That's since 2011. To put that another way, those are the only guys who gave fantasy managers a solid RB1 season within that parameter. That's out of over 350 backs. And players like Jones and Robinson had way better production profiles than Corum has. We can sit here and say that Corum is a better prospect than Kyren Williams was, but Williams proved to be an effective runner – very effective – in 2023. We should judge off of what we've seen in the league, not in college. We know that Williams can work in this Rams' offense. That's why this landing spot isn't very good, and it's hard to paint it differently. He'll need an injury to Williams in order to hit any sort of ceiling, and Williams is still under contract with LA for another two years. It'd be tough to spend a premium pick on Corum now.			

TREY BENSON



84.1

ZAP Score

RB

Florida State Seminoles (Arizona Cardinals)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'0"

Weight:

216

Statistical Comps: Kenyan Drake ▪ Roy Helu ▪ Bernard Pierce

Update: The size-speed combination is there for Trey Benson. He ran a 4.39 40-yard dash at the NFL Combine this year at 216 pounds, giving him the second-best Speed Score in the class. The ZAP Model is into that, but it's not into everything about his profile.

Benson got off to a slow start in college at Oregon after tearing his ACL as a Freshman. He redshirted and then had only six carries during his second season as a Duck. That led to a transfer to Florida State in 2022, where he led the backfield in touches two seasons in a row.

Benson's Breakout Score, partially due to the knee injury, ended up being an average 48.2. His best season in total yards per team play was just 1.38, a number met by 21 of the 29 running backs who were invited to the combine this year. He also failed to reach a double-digit percentage reception share in all of his collegiate campaigns.

Historically, players with production marks that low haven't given us the goods in fantasy. Since 2011 and prior to this season, here's a list of players who were selected between Pick 33 and Pick 100 with a sub-50 Breakout Score and a sub-10% best-season reception share: Alex Green, Stevan Ridley, Matt Jones, Damien Harris, Ty Davis-Price, and Kendre Miller.

Benson, who was selected 66th overall by the Cardinals, is now in that cluster.

If you want to look at this optimistically, Benson's got by far the best athletic profile of that group. And that's what you're really banking on with him. Sometimes good size and speed is enough.

Arizona isn't a bad place for a running back to be, either. Benson's rookie season might not be so hot with James Conner around, but Conner's a free agent in 2025. The backfield takeover could hit then.

It could go in a lot of different directions with Benson. If he falls enough in rookie drafts, he's not a bad potential flex play in Year 1 who could turn into a decent starter in Year 2. I'd say to just be aware that there are some analytical concerns, and those question marks don't exist for all backs in this class.

JONATHON BROOKS



93.8

ZAP Score

RB

Texas Longhorns (Carolina Panthers)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'0"

Weight:

216

Statistical Comps: Kerryon Johnson ▪ Sony Michel ▪ CJ Prosise

Update: There was a chance that we weren't going to see a running back hit a ZAP score of 90 this year for the first time in its history, and then the rebuilding Carolina Panthers took Jonathon Brooks with the 46th pick. That shot him up to 93.8.

Now we're cookin'.

Brooks is the best running back in this class. He tore his ACL in November, ending his season early. He finished 2023 with an impressive 1.99 total yards per team play rate (prorated, of course), and his reception share was 11.0%. Those numbers were the best ones he saw in college because he played behind Bijan Robinson and Roschon Johnson prior to last season. Really, his 73.4 Breakout Score should be higher, but a solid Teammate Score is helping him out.

Getting drafted by the Panthers could've been worse. Chuba Hubbard's been serviceable since his poor rookie season, but he wasn't nearly the type of prospect that Brooks is. And we kind of know what Miles Sanders is about at this point. Hypothetically, Brooks could be a bell-cow right away for the Panthers.

But, of course, there's the ACL. That's the scariest part to Brooks' situation by far. The Panthers are in rebuild mode, so will they really feel a need to rush Brooks back onto the field, even if reports are optimistic? Are they going to want to give him a big workload in Year 1? If not, then you run the risk of losing dynasty value year-over-year.

Post-2024, things should be great for Brooks. Dave Canales, Carolina's new head coach, ran the Buccaneers offense last season and wasn't shy in giving Rachaad White a true bell-cow workload. You just may have to be a little patient if you end up snagging Brooks in your rookie draft.

BUCKY IRVING



51.0

ZAP Score

RB

Oregon Ducks (Tampa Bay Buccaneers)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'9"

Weight:

192

Statistical Comps: Mark Walton ▪ Isaiah Pead ▪ Tyjae Spears

Update: Things haven't been great for Bucky Irving ever since the NFL Combine. We knew he was on the smaller side, and then he confirmed it by weighing in at 192 pounds. He then went out and ran a 4.55 40, giving him a sub-90 Speed Score. And that was on top of a production profile that, to the ZAP Model, wasn't great. His Breakout Score of 49.8 is a below-average one.

The landing spot in Tampa Bay is...interesting? If Irving gets run in the NFL, it's going to be as a receiving back first and foremost. His top-season in prorated reception share is an impressive 14.1%. But that's also something Rachaad White does well. In fact, White has one of the best reception shares in the ZAP Model's history. And he's been a good receiver so far in the NFL.

Irving is probably going to be more of a nuisance to White more than anything else. The only sub-200-pound Day 3 backs to give fantasy managers a usable season since 2011 have been Tarik Cohen, Andre Ellington, and Kyren Williams. Cohen was a more dynamic receiver coming out, Ellington was out of the league in a hurry, and Kyren Williams is just looking like an outlier. His team also took a Day 2 running back the year after his big season.

This is just not the type of profile we want to heavily invest in.

BRAELON ALLEN



72.3

ZAP Score

RB

Wisconsin Badgers (New York Jets)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'11"

Weight:

235

Statistical Comps: James Conner ▪ Royce Freeman ▪ Jeremy Hill

Update: The ZAP Model likes Braelon Allen, but after a draft process where he didn't run the 40, the algorithm cooled on him a bit.

There's nothing landing spot-related in the ZAP Model, but if there was, Allen's score would be even lower. The Jets decided to take him at the end of the fourth round, derailing any sort of early-career production. He's now backing up one of the best running backs in football in Breece Hall.

Allen could step in and perform with an injury, though. He's had a wild football journey. He was originally recruited as a linebacker – potentially a safety – but ended up at running back for Wisconsin. He also skipped his Senior year of high school and reclassified to the 2021 recruiting class, making him a 17-year-old college Freshman.

A lot of Freshman in that scenario would sit for a bit, but Allen produced immediately for the Badgers. He had a 1.64 total yards per team play rate that season, a number that 15 running backs in this year's class failed to reach across their entire collegiate careers. Allen did that before turning 18. That's why he has the highest Breakout Score in the class.

That Breakout Score could be higher. He produced well enough at a young age, but he topped out at a 1.76 total yards per team play rate. That ranked 13th-best among backs who were at the NFL Combine this year.

Another issue with Allen is that, for a running back with such a big frame, he doesn't always seem to use it. His best season (minimum 100 attempts) in forced missed tackles per rush, according to PFF's data, was actually below average when compared to the rest of the draft class. He was pretty mid at generating big plays, too.

So, again, it's a tough destination for fantasy production, but Allen's a capable-enough backup. The biggest issue is the Jets also took Isaiah Davis, so we can't even call Allen the direct handcuff to Hall.

Thanks, New York.

AUDRIC ESTIME



58.7

ZAP Score

RB

Notre Dame Fighting Irish (Denver Broncos)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'11" Weight: 221

Statistical Comps: Isaiah Spiller ▪ David Cobb ▪ Alfred Morris

Update: We saw the right kind of year-over-year progression with Audric Estime's production at Notre Dame. As a Freshman, he only carried the ball seven times and had a 0.17 prorated total yards per team play rate. That jumped up to 1.21 as a Sophomore. He then finished off his collegiate career with a 1.99 tally in 2023.

Estime is the second-youngest running back in this year's class, and that helped him out in the ZAP Model. His Breakout Score of 79.3 is a top-five one among backs who were at the combine, all thanks to a very productive Junior campaign.

The reason the model doesn't like him more is two-fold. First, his best-season reception share was only 8.1%, when we generally see successful backs hitting at least the 10% mark. Second, his NFL Combine performance was weak. He's a big guy at 221 pounds, but his 4.71 40-yard dash still gave him a sub-90 Speed Score.

The ZAP Model now has 44 running backs who ran their 40-yard dash in 4.7 seconds or slower. Of those 44, 38 have had a chance to play three years in the league. And, of those 38, Theo Riddick is the only one to score more than 9 PPR points per game in one of his first three seasons in the NFL.

Estime found himself in a crowded Broncos backfield. Javonte Williams, though, is on the last year of his rookie deal, and Samaje Perine might not be around much longer, either. Jaleel McLaughlin was a surprising rookie in 2023, but he's more of a change-of-pace type. Perhaps the Broncos want to see if Estime can be their early-down guy after this year, which would be an OK pairing with McLaughlin.

The bottom line with Estime is that there are things that need to go his way in order to work out in fantasy. It's possible he gets a bigger gig for the Broncos in 2025, but even if he does, his upside is capped due to his weaker receiving numbers.

The word to describe Estime's profile is "fine".

WILL SHIPLEY



67.8

ZAP Score

RB

Clemson Tigers (Philadelphia Eagles)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'11"

Weight:

206

Statistical Comps: Jeremy Langford ▪ Darrynton Evans ▪ Tevin Coleman

Update: We're probably not going to see much Will Shipley across his first two seasons in the NFL. The Eagles selected him in the fourth round, and, as we all know, Philly signed Saquon Barkley to a lucrative contract over the offseason. Their first potential out with said contract occurs in 2026.

As a player, Shipley is a do-it-all back. He just doesn't "do it all" exceptionally well.

Shipley's Breakout Score of 60.5 is OK, and it's thanks to some decent production at Clemson as a Freshman. During his first season there in 2021, he hit a 1.24 total yards per team play rate, which just got him over the first threshold that Breakout Score looks at. An average that low isn't impressive for a college Junior, but a Freshman at a big program? Not bad.

Unfortunately, Shipley never really gave us a monster season. He was better in 2022, but his final year at Clemson was plagued by injury. He played 12 games and wasn't 100% throughout the season, leading to a career low in total yards per team play.

Shipley's 12.8% best-season reception share is above the class' mean, but so many of his metrics point to him being an average to above-average player in the NFL. Can he play all three downs? Sure. Will he get that chance? In Philadelphia, he's looking more like a very solid depth piece. He's just a handcuff.

JAYLEN WRIGHT



70.7

ZAP Score

RB

Tennessee Volunteers (Miami Dolphins)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'11"

Weight:

210

Statistical Comps: Anthony McFarland ▪ Ty Chandler ▪ DeMarco Murray

Update: Of course. Of course Jaylen Wright, who ran a sub-4.4 40-yard dash and had the highest explosive play rate in this year's running back class...of course he lands with Mike McDaniel in Miami.

Of course.

The fit is clearly there. The Dolphins zone scheme allowed speedster Raheem Mostert to lead the NFL in touchdowns last year, and De'Von Achane is coming off the most efficient per-rush season of any moderately high-volume back in NFL history. Jaylen Wright will do just fine when he gets an opportunity in this offense.

And that opportunity could come sooner than people think. The Dolphins locked up Raheem Mostert through 2025 this offseason, but they have an out with his contract after this year. Mostert's also 32 years old and coming off a season where he handled 200-plus carries for the first time in his career. We can't guarantee health in 2024.

The Dolphins will maintain a split backfield, and there's reason to believe Wright can be part of a committee. That's what we saw from him in college, with him never reaching 150 carries in any season at Tennessee. Last year, he played alongside a solid back in Dylan Sampson. That helped maximize his per-touch efficiency.

Maybe you're upset that Wright's going to a Dolphins team that already has a capable young running back, but, to me, Wright was probably not going to be a high-volume NFL back. His Breakout Score is just average compared to the rest of this subpar class, and his best season in reception share never reached 10%. We've never really seen him be a bell-cow. In turn, we needed a spot for efficiency, and that's exactly what we got.

MARSHAWN LLOYD



74.6

ZAP Score

RB

Southern California Trojans (Green Bay Packers)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'9"

Weight:

220

Statistical Comps: Robert Turbin ▪ Terrance West ▪ Storm Johnson

Update: There are plenty of MarShawn Lloyd truthers out there, so it's a little scary that the ZAP Model is labeling his profile as a "high risk" one. The reason for that is because he's the seventh-oldest back in this year's class – he's a good bit over 23 – his Breakout Score is 31.2, and he never got to a 10% best-season reception share.

Looking back to 2011, Lloyd appears to be the only 23-year-old running back in the ZAP Model who received top-100 draft capital after failing to reach a Breakout Score of 50 and a best-season reception share of 10%. There are 20 drafted running backs in the model who fit that criteria, though, and Andre Ellington's the only one who gave us a PPR point per game season above 10.

Lloyd does have a strong athletic profile that could end up trumping all of these numbers. That's how it goes sometimes at running back. He's explosive and can generate big plays, and that could be enough to score some fantasy points. His age-adjusted production is also lower than expected because of an ACL tear to kick off his college career back in 2020, so we should insert some subjectivity here.

In Green Bay, Lloyd will face an uphill battle. At least in the short term. The Packers recently signed Josh Jacobs, and Jacobs is expected to handle a lot of work here in 2024. The Packers do have an out in 2025 with Jacobs' contract, however, which could present a unique opportunity for Lloyd.

Oddly, Lloyd, despite this higher-variance profile, could still end up on your fantasy squad. The market could end up being bearish on the landing spot, but his value has a chance to increase year-over-year if the Packers end up moving on from Jacobs. And Matt LaFleur is no stranger to split backfields, so Lloyd still has some opportunity to produce in Year 1. If we see him show off his big-play ability, then we'll feel more confident in a backfield takeover in Year 2.

Lloyd's not a slam-dunk prospect. There are concerns here. But in drafts where gamers focus on rookie-season production, he could be OK to snag.

RAY DAVIS



69.8

ZAP Score

RB

Kentucky Wildcats (Buffalo Bills)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'8"

Weight:

211

Statistical Comps: Ke'Shawn Vaughn ▪ Matt Dayes ▪ Baron Batch

Update: Ray Davis has a pretty complete production profile. His top season in reception share is an impressive 15.6%, a number matched by just one other player in this year's class. His best season in total yards per team play is north of 2.0, too. Only five backs in the class got to that level.

Part of the reason Davis was able to get to those numbers was because he played five years of college ball. He kicked things off at Temple and played two years there. Then he went to Vandy for two seasons before finishing things off at Kentucky in 2023. He's now 24-and-a-half years old. And he got the best draft capital any 24-and-a-half-year-old running back received in the ZAP Model's history when he was selected at Pick 128 by the Buffalo Bills.

Buffalo isn't a bad spot for Davis. They've got James Cook, but Cook averaged a 63% running back rush share per game in 2023. There was room for another back in the offense to step up, and that was usually Latavius Murray last season.

That role is probably going to be Davis'. It'll be limited work as long as Cook is there and healthy, but during a year where there weren't *that* many ideal landing spots for running backs, this one for Davis is fine. At a minimum, he's a handcuff.

It's fine to throw a dart Davis' way in rookie drafts, but do be aware that age is what's bringing down his ZAP score. It could be tougher for him to appreciate in dynasty value, and there's a pretty good chance that Davis won't get any sort of lucrative second contract in the NFL. By the time his rookie deal is up, he'll be pushing 29.

As a short-term handcuff-with-flex-appeal type play? Go for it.

JAWHAR JORDAN



5.2

ZAP Score

RB

Louisville Cardinals (Houston Texans)

Low Risk Neutral **High Risk**

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'10" Weight: 193

Statistical Comps: Diocemy Saint Juste ▪ Raymond Calais ▪ Joe Hill

It's really hard to buy into Jawhar Jordan as a fantasy football contributor.

Jordan's the fourth-smallest back in this class by weight, and he's the tiniest by BMI. You can reference De'Von Achane all day, but Achane had an elite production profile.

Jordan does not.

Jordan's Breakout Score of 18.8 ranks in the bottom-six among backs who went to the combine this year. His best-season reception share is at just 8.5%. His best-season in explosive run rate, per Pro Football Focus data, was below-average despite his smaller frame. That's because he doesn't have blazing speed – he had a sub-90 Speed Score thanks to a 4.56 40.

Oh, and did I mention that no running back from this year's class is older?

Perhaps Jordan will be a role-player for some backfield, but it's highly unlikely that he'll be a consistent fantasy producer.

DYLAN LAUBE



63.9

ZAP Score

RB

New Hampshire Wildcats (Las Vegas Raiders)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'10" Weight: 206

Statistical Comps: Eric Gray ▪ James White ▪ Ito Smith

Update: As a reminder, there's only one running back in the ZAP Model's history who was able to hit a best-season reception share above 25%. And it's Las Vegas Raider Dylan Laube.

Laube is at an analytical advantage in that he played for an FCS school. Being the running back for New Hampshire isn't the same as being the running back for Alabama. We have to keep that in mind when we're looking at his production metrics. With that being said, his playing for a smaller program definitely hurt his draft capital. His ZAP score took a hit by going 208th overall in the draft.

Laube's got a super interesting profile, though. His 25.3% best-season reception share is the highest the ZAP Model database has ever seen, and he had a 2.09 total yards per team play rate, too. Since 2011, the only backs to have hit a 20% reception share and a 2.00 total yards per team play rate after being selected after Pick 100 have been Jacquizz Rodgers, James White, Devontae Booker, Aaron Jones, De'Angelo Henderson, and Deuce Vaughn. Jones became a stud, White had plenty of usability throughout his career, and even Rodgers had some, too.

Being past 24 years old is definitely a red flag for Laube. He was playing at New Hampshire all the way back in 2019, and he didn't really get going until 2021. That's why his Breakout Score sits in just the 59th percentile. You'd ideally want a better age-adjusted profile for a guy coming from an FCS school, right?

The Raiders are a good place for him to start his career. Zamir White is looking like the 2024 starter, and he's not the type of player to capture a 15% target share in an NFL offense. Laube can play that pass-catching role while trying to create more of an early-down workload. It's doubtful he ever becomes a 200-carry back, but a 100-carry one? With a double-digit percentage target share? That's in his range of outcomes.

DILLON JOHNSON



14.5

ZAP Score

RB

Washington Huskies (Undrafted)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'0"

Weight:

217

Statistical Comps: Rex Burkhead ▪ Dan Herron ▪ Dare Ogunbowale

Dillon Johnson started his collegiate journey at Mississippi State, where he played three years under the late Mike Leach. There, he wasn't used much as a runner – he failed to reach 500 rushing yards in each season – but, as we've seen before with Leach running backs, Johnson was deployed often as a pass-catcher. He hauled in reception shares of 9.7%, 12.6%, and 13.3% over his three seasons as a Bulldog.

Johnson transferred to Washington for his final season, and that reception share dropped to 6.4%. Considering it was a new system, that's something to note. He did, however, see a nice uptick in rushing usage, resulting in his first and only college campaign with a total yards per team play rate above 1.00.

The prospect model doesn't mind Johnson versus projected draft capital because of his good size and strong best-season reception share. However, you have to question how he accumulated those numbers. The system at Mississippi State undoubtedly boosted his receiving, and, at Washington, he wasn't that great of a runner. In fact, among all backs in this year's class, Johnson ranked second-worst in best-season avoided tackles per rush and yards after contact per attempt, and he had the worst explosive run rate. That showed up at the combine when he ran a 4.68 40, almost dipping below a 90 Speed Score.

Could he come through in fantasy as more of a handcuff type? Probably. He can play all three downs, realistically. He just doesn't appear to be special.

CODY SCHRADER



17.9

ZAP Score

RB

Missouri Tigers (Undrafted)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'9"

Weight:

202

Statistical Comps: Ralph Webb ▪ Chase Edmonds ▪ Sincere McCormick

Cody Schrader got his college football start at Truman State University, a Division II program in *Googles* Missouri. He had one monster year there before becoming a Mizzou walk-on in 2022.

Schrader's a unique prospect for the model because his numbers are a little inflated after playing D2 ball. Without accounting for his huge 2021 season at Truman State, he's a fairly ordinary prospect. When you consider it, he looks a good bit better, with his Breakout Score going from 19 to about 65.

The ZAP Model is considering his production at The Tru (they definitely don't call it that), but it's still not making Schrader an exceptional prospect. He did hit a total yards per team play rate of 2.08 at Mizzou this past year, giving him one of the higher marks in the class. Thanks to his Truman State numbers, his best-season in reception share is strong, too, at 13.1%.

But Schrader is well over 24 years old right now, folks. He's the oldest running back in this year's class. That's a problem. Because, of the six running backs in the ZAP Model who entered the league at Schrader's age or older – yes, there have only been six of them – none scored even two PPR points per game during their first three years in the league.

The NFL Combine also wasn't particularly kind to Schrader. He ended up running a 4.61, joining a few other backs with an 89-something Speed Score. That's under the threshold that the ZAP Model wants to see, so that hurts Schrader's outlook.

Schrader's production marks really aren't bad, but he's going to be a short-term investment for your dynasty squads. You really need him to fall to a spot that gives him a shot at immediate production, or his NFL career – given his age – could be short-lived.

ISAIAH DAVIS



70.0

ZAP Score

RB

South Dakota State Jackrabbits (New York Jets)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'1" Weight: 218

Statistical Comps: James Robinson ▪ Tyler Allgeier ▪ Chris Polk

Update: It's almost like the Jets were using the ZAP Model to draft this year.

After taking Braelon Allen on Day 3, New York followed it up and, for whatever reason, took Isaiah Davis in Round 5. Davis could potentially beat out Allen for the RB2 spot on the team, but there's no chance either guy is jumping over Breece Hall.

Davis is an underrated prospect. He played four seasons at South Dakota State, with one of those campaigns being a COVID-stricken one. He finished his collegiate career with a best-season total yards per team play rate of 2.01, and he snagged a reception share of 10.1%. He's one of four running backs in this year's class to have hit a 2.0 total yards per team play and a 10% reception share, but he's by far the youngest among those four.

Sure, Davis played at South Dakota State, so it's a little easier for him to post good numbers. But do keep in mind that he split a backfield with NFLer Pierre Strong in two of those four seasons. And Davis, who was the underclassman, was able to dig into Strong's workload.

Things didn't really pop for Davis until Strong was gone. In 2022, Davis rushed for 1,451 yards and 15 scores. He followed that up with a 1,578-yard campaign last year.

Davis broke tackles at an above-average clip compared to the rest of the class, and his ability to generate 10-plus yard runs was third-best. Among all running backs in college football, Davis had the third-best offensive grade last season according to Pro Football Focus.

The comps were strong for Davis if he fell to a destination where he could see Year 1 work. Without an injury to Breece Hall, that's not happening. Even *with* an injury, we may not see things come to fruition.

It's painful, but this is how it goes sometimes.

FRANK GORE JR.



49.8

ZAP Score

RB

Southern Mississippi Golden Eagles (Undrafted)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'8"

Weight:

201

Statistical Comps: Tyler Badie ▪ Michael Carter ▪ Trayveon Williams

We watched Frank Gore destroy defenses for years, and now it's his son's turn.

Man, I feel old.

Gore doesn't have the same frame as his dad, but he still has pretty good tackle-breaking ability. He forced missed tackles in his best season at a 36.6% rate, per PFF, which was a top-10 number in the class.

There's a chance we see Gore deployed as a pass-catcher in the NFL, which would be good news for his fantasy value. His top-season in reception share was a healthy 14.6%, and he hit a solid 1.30 yards per route run last season. According to Pro Football Focus, his pass blocking skills appear to be favorable when compared to the rest of this class, too.

Gore is a little undersized, though, which is why we're seeing the statistical comparables we're seeing. For him to *really* hit as a fantasy asset, he'll need to find an open-minded coaching staff that's willing to give him a healthy workload, similar to what we saw with Kyren Williams in 2023. It's possible, but we're likely looking at a high-end outcome of an RB2 at best in PPR formats. There's nothing wrong with that as a later-round rookie pick, of course.

The ZAP Model likes Gore compared to where most have him thanks to the potential pass-catching production.

DAIJUN EDWARDS



22.2

ZAP Score

RB

Georgia Bulldogs (Undrafted)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'10"

Weight:

207

Statistical Comps: Cierre Wood ▪ Kelvin Taylor ▪ Andre Ellington

On paper, Daijun Edwards' profile isn't very good. He never reached an 8% reception share, giving him the third-lowest mark in the class. He's also a little undersized and failed to break out until late into his collegiate career.

From 2011 to 2021, we had 67 running backs get drafted after Pick 100 who weighed in under 210 pounds. Just 13 of those 67 had sub-8% receptions shares. And just 1 of those 13 smaller, low-reception-share backs had a max season across their first three in the league where they scored more than 2.7 PPR points per game. That lone back was Andre Ellington, one of Edwards' top statistical comps.

Edwards, though, is a Georgia back. They've been a tougher group to prospect analytically through the years because of how the team tends to divvy up the backfield. And, in Edwards' case, he played with some strong talent. He got to Georgia in 2020 and played behind Zamir White, Kenny McIntosh, and James Cook. They're all pros. It was the same deal in 2021, and then he had to deal with McIntosh in 2022. All the while, there was fellow 2024 draft classmate Kendall Milton stealing some work.

So we can look at Edwards' body of work with a grain of salt. His circumstance doesn't totally dismiss everything, but if he gets higher-than-anticipated draft capital, or if he goes to a team without much competition, he may be OK. And he's on the younger side compared to the rest of the class, which is a plus.

JASE MCCLELLAN



58.2

ZAP Score

RB

Alabama Crimson Tide (Atlanta Falcons)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'10"

Weight:

221

Statistical Comps: DeeJay Dallas ▪ Jonathan Williams ▪ Corey Clement

Yes, we've seen plenty of W's at running back out of Alabama in recent history. Jahmyr Gibbs is a monster. Najee Harris has been serviceable. Brian Robinson had a great 2023 season. Josh Jacobs. Damien Harris. Each of the last five running backs to go to the NFL Combine from Bama have been good to elite.

Is Jase McClellan really going to make it six in a row?

Well, he's got the right size for the next level. Or, at least, size that typically comes with a big workload. He's still not 22 years old, either, so age is working in his favor, too.

Beyond that? Meh.

McClellan's best-season total yards per team play rate was just 1.25. That's better than recent Alabama backs Damien Harris and Josh Jacobs, but Harris and Jacobs were also splitting a backfield together, and they both had pretty decent draft capital. Jacobs was a first-rounder, while Harris was a Day 2 guy. That's not looking like it'll be the case for McClellan.

McClellan also graded out as a really poor pass blocker, and his best campaign in receiving yards per route run was lowest among recent Alabama backs to come out.

To put this all another way, it doesn't look like McClellan is going to keep things going for Alabama backs. At best, he seems like an early-down NFL back like Damien Harris. And he's not as good of a prospect as Harris was.

KENDALL MILTON



12.9

ZAP Score

RB

Georgia Bulldogs (Undrafted)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'2"

Weight:

220

Statistical Comps: Alfred Blue ▪ Matthew Tucker ▪ Bryce Brown

Kendall Milton was never a workhorse back at Georgia. To reiterate some of the things that were said about his teammate, Daijuan Edwards, yes, Georgia does usually split up their backfields. And, yes, Milton played alongside some pretty legit competition in college.

But at least Edwards had some semblance of a production profile.

Milton's the bigger of the two backs who shared the Georgia backfield this past year, coming in at 220 pounds. Even with that size, though, Milton forced missed tackles at a below-average rate compared to others in the class. He was out-attempted by Edwards in 2023, too.

The receiving portion looks even worse. Milton caught 12 balls across his four seasons at Georgia, giving him a top-season reception share of just 1.6%. That's the lowest mark in the class.

You can come up with reasons as to why a player like Milton doesn't have a better production profile, but he's not the first running back to have ever played with strong competition in college. His sub-2% reception share is a massive red flag. Just 17 running backs in the ZAP Model's history have had a number that low, and none of them gave fantasy managers a double-digit PPR point per game season during one of their first three years in the league. The only one over three PPR points per game was Andre Williams.

Anything is always possible, but probabilistically, Milton is not someone you should be targeting.

KIMANI VIDAL



59.8

ZAP Score

RB

Troy Trojans (Los Angeles Chargers)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'8" Weight: 213

Statistical Comps: Michael Warren ▪ Mike Davis ▪ Ben LeMay

Update: Just two running backs in the ZAP Model database measured under 5'9'' at the NFL Combine while hitting an above-average Breakout Score and a 105 Speed Score. One of them is D'Andre Swift. The other is Troy's Kimani Vidal.

Vidal had the eighth-highest offensive grade among running backs across college football last year according to PFF, and he has above-average marks versus this year's class in Breakout Score, forced missed tackles per attempt, and receiving yards per route run.

Of course, Vidal did all of this at Troy, so NFL teams didn't credit him for those marks the same way they would someone who went to Georgia. That's the reason he went in Round 6 and not, say, Round 3.

But Vidal was selected on Day 3, and the landing spot couldn't have been better. The Chargers are going to run the football with Greg Roman as offensive coordinator, and they entered the draft with JK Dobbins and Gus Edwards as their top-two backs. Dobbins is coming off an Achilles tear – an injury that's extremely tough to come back from at running back – while Edwards is a 29-year-old bruiser. LA desperately needed some speed to the offense, and they got that with Vidal.

Vidal is a powerful runner for his size whose long-speed concerns were squashed a bit with a 4.46 40-yard dash at the combine. He can very easily carve out a role in the Chargers offense immediately, and it shouldn't surprise anyone if he's their best back by the end of the season.

At the moment, there's no telling where he'll go in rookie drafts. Strictly look at him as a player, and strictly looking at this fit, Vidal looks like a really good target.

RASHEEN ALI



62.5

ZAP Score

RB

Marshall Thundering Herd (Baltimore Ravens)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'11"

Weight:

206

Statistical Comps: Joshua Kelley ▪ Jeff Wilson ▪ Joseph Randle

Update: We didn't see much production from Rasheen Ali when he was a Freshman at Marshall, but that changed dramatically as a Sophomore in 2021. He rushed for over 1,400 yards during his second year, catching 45 passes in the process. His 13.9% reception share that season ended up being a career high, and it also ended up being sixth-best in this year's class. Meanwhile, his 68.9 Breakout Score was eighth-best.

Outside of the model, Ali's forced missed tackles per attempt rate in his top season ranks well below the 2024 class average. His explosive run rate was south of the average as well, and he didn't run a 40 at the NFL Combine, so the big-play ability could be an issue. Overall, though, the ZAP Model sees him as a really solid prospect who almost had a "low risk" Draft Capital Delta.

Baltimore isn't the best team for Year 1 rookie running back production, but you could do worse for a Day 3 landing spot. Derrick Henry is Baltimore's starter now, and he's a 30-years-old back who doesn't catch a ton of passes. He also may only be on the team for a year. Keaton Mitchell is coming off a serious knee injury, and he's not a high-volume back. And are we really afraid of Justice Hill at this point?

Ali could serve as Baltimore's RB2 at the start of the 2024 season given Mitchell's recovery. If Henry's not catching a ton of balls, then Ali could immediately get some run doing that, too. At worst in this hypothetical scenario, Ali's a decent handcuff, unless you're still a Justice Hill believer.

When you combine that kind of role with a good ZAP Model situation, you get someone to target deep in your rookie drafts.

MICHAEL WILEY



33.1

ZAP Score

RB

Arizona Wildcats (Undrafted)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'11"

Weight:

210

Statistical Comps: Wendell Smallwood ▪ Rakeem Boyd ▪ James Williams

Michael Wiley has the pass-catching profile we look for in a fantasy back. His top season in reception share was nearly 14% (top-10 in the class), and he's one of two running backs in this year's draft group to have hit a best-season yards per route run greater than 2.0.

Unfortunately, Wiley's Breakout Score was lacking after never having a ton of success on the ground at Arizona. He saw more than 100 carries in just one of five seasons, maxing out his single-season rushing yards at 771. His receiving numbers were strong nearly every single year, but the ground-game ones needed some work.

There are worse darts to throw at the end of your rookie draft, but, at 23-and-a-half years old, Wiley's probably not going to be gaining a ton of value in dynasty.

As a depth piece with interesting PPR potential? Sure, why not?

EMANI BAILEY



3.4

ZAP Score

RB

Texas Christian Horned Frogs (Undrafted)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'7"

Weight:

202

Statistical Comps: Darwin Thompson ▪ Dee Hart ▪ Devonta Freeman

At face value, Emani Bailey looks like a very obvious player to avoid. He's undersized. His top year in reception share is well below 10%. He didn't have a special Breakout Score. His Speed Score was just below 90.

None of the ZAP Model inputs look especially good for Bailey.

Bailey's comparables, though, make you wonder.

One of them is Devonta Freeman. Like Bailey, Freeman was an undersized runner with mediocre production who ran a pretty slow 40 before he got to the league. And, in the league, he gave us some very good fantasy production.

Jaylen Warren's another one. Warren just missed the comps list, but he, too, was an undersized incoming rookie who's doing way more in the NFL than many expected.

Could we be looking at that kind of thing happening for Bailey?

It's wise to not bet on outliers. Both Freeman and Warren had better athleticism marks than Bailey, and Freeman in particular saw better draft capital than Bailey is likely to see. Both guys had better receiving marks in college, too.

Bailey had a strong Senior season, but it's hard to envision an NFL team giving a player his size a reasonable workload. Maybe he'll break the mold like Freeman and Warren did, but we shouldn't bank on that happening.

MIYAN WILLIAMS



15.8

ZAP Score

RB

Ohio State Buckeyes (Undrafted)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'9"

Weight:

229

Statistical Comps: CJ Anderson ▪ Michael Dyer ▪ Allen Bradford

Miyan Williams backed up TreVeyon Henderson at Ohio State, leading to a poorer production profile. He's one of five backs in this year's class to have failed to register a Breakout Score. Among the players in that group, he was second-worst in reception share.

Receiving probably won't be at the forefront for Williams at the next level, but he may become a reasonable early-down rusher. He's got a ridiculously thick frame, standing at just 5'9'' and weighing in at 229 pounds at the combine. His 33.8 BMI is the fourth-highest the ZAP Model database has ever seen, trailing only CJ Anderson, Eddie Lacy, and Zac Stacy.

That translated when Williams actually got the rock at Ohio State. He ranked well above the class average in both forced missed tackles per attempt and yards after contact per attempt.

Perhaps Williams would've found more success – at least in the model – had he played elsewhere throughout college. We have to recognize that he competed in a backfield with a very good running back. Even still, he's probably not going to be much of a pass-catcher in the NFL, which will cap his fantasy upside tremendously.

JADEN SHIRDEN



41.4

ZAP Score

RB

Monmouth Hawks (Undrafted)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'8"

Weight:

187

Statistical Comps: Javian Hawkins ▪ Keaton Mitchell ▪ Jaret Patterson

The ZAP Model database says that there've been 22 running backs who weighed in under 190 pounds at the NFL Combine since 2011. Of those 22, only Tarik Cohen, De'Von Achane, and Keaton Mitchell have given fantasy managers any sort of material output.

Those aren't great odds, but get this: Cohen, Achane, and Mitchell had Breakout Scores that ranked in the top-six within that group of 22 backs.

Jaden Shirden's 87.5 Breakout Score puts him right there with those guys.

Counting on a sub-190-pound running back in fantasy is usually pretty foolish, but there are some progressive teams out there who are willing to give smaller backs an OK-enough workload. We saw that last year with Achane and Mitchell.

To be clear, Shirden doesn't look like he'll be as good of a prospect as even Mitchell once the draft concludes. They have a nearly identical Breakout Score and reception share in the model, and Mitchell was slightly better in Speed Score. But some of the deeper numbers show that Shirden wasn't great at shaking off defenders, and his top-season yards per route run was one of the worst in the class.

It's just that, with these later-round dart throws, we've got to find *something* to get excited about. Sometimes there's nothing there, but, with Shirden, we at least have examples of this archetype getting some action. If he can find an open-minded offense during or after the draft, then he could be someone you want to have on your dynasty roster's bench.

GEORGE HOLANI



39.6

ZAP Score

RB

Boise State Broncos (Undrafted)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'10"

Weight:

208

Statistical Comps: Rodney Smith ▪ Johnathan Franklin ▪ Chase Brown

For a player who may go undrafted, George Holani has a pretty strong production profile. His 56.4 Breakout Score is above average within the class, and his 13.8% reception share is eighth-best. He also had above-average marks in total yards per team play, missed tackles forced per attempt, and yards per route run.

There just may not be anything special about Holani, which is the problem. He's certainly not an explosive back, having generated a 10-plus yard run on just 13.5% of his totes during his best season within the metric. That's a bottom-four number in the class. His size is pretty average, and he's going to be almost 24-and-a-half years old by the time the draft gets here.

Had he run a faster 40, maybe we could call him this year's Chase Brown. While Brown's a comp, Holani doesn't have the same big-play ability.

KEILAN ROBINSON



54.4

ZAP Score

RB

Texas Longhorns (Jacksonville Jaguars)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'8"

Weight:

191

Statistical Comps: TJ Logan ▪ Raymond Calais ▪ Henry Josey

Update: The best part about Keilan Robinson's ZAP Model profile is that he played with Bijan Robinson, Roschon Johnson, and Jonathon Brooks. That's his excuse for having a Breakout Score of zero.

From a running back perspective, Keilan Robinson isn't likely to be asked to do much in the NFL. At 5'8'', 191 pounds, he's a change-of-pace guy who could help a team out – the Jaguars – dramatically on special teams.

Robinson's receiving numbers aren't too shabby, though, especially when you consider his competition at Texas. He secured an 8.1% reception share in 2022 with Bijan Robinson and Roschon Johnson on the roster, and his yards per route run (in limited action) was an impressive 3.22.

Maybe the Jags will find creative ways to get Robinson the ball and use him as a gadget player offensively. He'll likely play a special teams role for them at the very least.

ISAAC GUERENDO



66.4

ZAP Score

RB

Louisville Cardinals (San Francisco 49ers)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'0" Weight: 221

Statistical Comps: Isiah Pacheco ▪ Da'Rel Scott ▪ Knile Davis

Update: Isaac Guerendo weighed in at 221 pounds at the combine, making him the fourth-heaviest back in this year's class. He then went out and ran a 4.33 40, giving him the best Speed Score – by far – in the group. It was actually the third-best Speed Score the ZAP Model database has seen from a back.

How much does that *really* matter? Well, Guerendo's production profile was pretty mediocre. He failed to register a Breakout Score after playing four years at Wisconsin and one at Louisville. He did catch 39 passes over his last two seasons, but he maxed out with a best-season reception share that was just south of 10%. Not great.

We'd ideally want to see a more well-rounded profile from a back, even when that back had a massively high Speed Score. Put it this way: Six backs in the ZAP Model database have hit a Speed Score of 115 or above while getting drafted after Pick 100. Three of them registered Breakout Scores, with those three being Latavius Murray, Da'Rel Scott, and Isiah Pacheco. Two of those three hit, at least compared to where they were drafted. The other three backs were Keith Marshall, Kalen Ballage, and Kene Nwangwu. They were farts.

That should make us a little nervous about Guerendo. He does compare very, very favorably to Isiah Pacheco. They're similarly sized. They had supremely high Speed Scores. They had nearly identical best-season reception shares. Their top campaign in total yards per team play was just 0.1 yards from one another.

But Pacheco's was high enough to register that Breakout Score, while Guerendo's wasn't. And Guerendo is also almost 24 years old. Those are the things we can't push aside when evaluating just because he absolutely slayed the 40.

Guerendo landed in San Francisco, where, without Christian McCaffrey, it would be an awesome fit. The Shanahan scheme favors these types of speedy backs, so, if given an opportunity, Guerendo could be an intriguing fantasy asset.

That chance won't come without a McCaffrey injury, though. Guerendo's merely a handcuff, albeit a very fun one.

TYRONE TRACY



51.7

ZAP Score

RB

Purdue Boilermakers (New York Giants)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'11"

Weight:

209

Statistical Comps: Chris Evans ▪ SaRodorick Thompson ▪ Tony Pollard

Update: When the pre-draft version of this guide was released in early March, there was very little chatter around Purdue's Tyrone Tracy. He started picking up some social media steam over the last month or so, and it all culminated with him getting selected in the fifth round by the New York Giants.

There's not much happening on that Giants running back depth chart. They signed Devin Singletary this offseason, and while Singletary's had success under Brian Daboll in the past, that's not a lot to overcome if you're Tyrone Tracy.

Tracy's not your ordinary running back prospect. He played college ball for six years, starting all the way back in 2018 with Iowa. Tracy was a wide receiver there for four seasons, and then he transferred to Purdue where he played more running back. Last season was the only one where he carried the ball more than 17 times.

The ZAP Model compared Tracy to Tony Pollard, and that's what we should be excited about. The similarities are definitely there. Both players were under a 1.00 best-season total yards per team play while hitting a nearly identical top-season reception share. Pollard's Speed Score was 100.6, while Tracy's was 103.8. They've got nearly identical size as well.

The main difference is that Tracy is almost 24-and-a-half years old, when Pollard was 22 when he heard his name called in 2019. And we can't overstate the age factor, with Andre Ellington being the only 24-plus-year-old back (when drafted) in the ZAP Model database to give us any sort of fantasy production since 2011.

There's still intrigue here. Tracy has pass-catching chops, and because the Giants lack rushing weapons, he could carve out a role on the ground, too. Don't go too far in targeting him – there are some truthers who will push his cost up – but he's a good player to have rostered.

Wide Receiver

MARVIN HARRISON JR.

WR

Ohio State Buckeyes (Arizona Cardinals)

Height: 6'3"

Weight: 209

99.3
ZAP Score

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Statistical Comps: AJ Green ▪ CeeDee Lamb ▪ Julio Jones

Update: To no one's surprise, the Arizona Cardinals took Marvin Harrison Jr. with the fourth overall pick in the draft. And his pre- to post-draft ZAP score is unchanged.

Harrison brings an element to the Arizona offense that they simply don't have. Trey McBride can operate the middle of the field and gobble up some easy looks, while Harrison will be winning on the outside, as he did at Ohio State.

And, trust me: He'll win.

Prior to this draft and since 2011, we had only seen 14 wideouts get selected in the top-10. Of those 14, just 2 were early-declare receivers with Breakout Scores of 90 or greater while having multiple seasons with at least a 3.0 yards per team pass attempt. Those two were AJ Green and Amari Cooper.

Marvin Harrison makes three.

Harrison pretty much checks every box. He produced as a Sophomore, where he broke out in a big way. He did that at a school with NFL-caliber competition. And he posted numbers with multiple quarterbacks under center.

You could argue that Harrison's got some issues generating yards after the catch, with his best-season in YAC per reception sitting as the third-worst in this year's class. That's just not enough to call him a non-elite wide receiver. He's a cornerstone dynasty piece, and you could argue for him at the top spot in all rookie draft formats. Even superflex ones.

MALIK NABERS



99.5

ZAP Score

WR

Louisiana State Tigers (New York Giants)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'0"

Weight:

201

Statistical Comps: Odell Beckham ▪ DJ Moore ▪ Ja'Marr Chase

Update: The ZAP Model, as you pre-draft readers know, loves Malik Nabers. Not only is he slightly – *slightly* – ahead of Marvin Harrison Jr. in ZAP score, but he was tagged with a low-risk Draft Capital Delta. That means, despite his sixth overall draft capital, the model still sees him as an underrated player.

That's bonkers.

The reason for that is about eight-fold. Nabers' 2023 saw him with a 3.82 receiving yards per team pass attempt, the highest max-season number from any Power Five wideout in this year's class. His 97.8 Breakout Score is the best among combine invites this year. That score is so high because Nabers still isn't 21 years old. He's about a year younger than Marvin Harrison Jr.

Nabers' non-ZAP Model metrics are great, too. His top collegiate yards per route run season is second-best in the class. His PFF grade in 2023 was number one in the nation. He ranked top-10 in the class in best-season yards after the catch per reception. And he did all of that while playing alongside Brian Thomas, who went 23rd overall in the draft.

The ZAP Model prefers Nabers to Harrison, yes, but there are reasons to go with Harrison over Nabers in your rookie drafts. Landing spot is one. The Cardinals are a more advantageous team for immediate fantasy success than the Giants are. The quarterback situation is more stable. Gamers may overstate the Giants destination for Nabers, though, so don't take that *too* far.

The main reason to prefer Harrison to Nabers is simply safety. We've seen Harrison Jr. produce in multiple situations with more than one quarterback. As epic as Nabers looks, he wasn't able to do what Harrison did across multiple seasons.

Nevertheless, Nabers, like Harrison, is a foundational piece to your dynasty rosters. And because there's a chance fantasy managers inevitably overstate what looks like a poor landing spot, you may be able to get him at a better value than Harrison.

ROME ODUNZE



96.0

ZAP Score

WR

Washington Huskies (Chicago Bears)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'3"

Weight:

212

Statistical Comps: DeAndre Hopkins ▪ Michael Floyd ▪ Drake London

Update: Rome Odunze's ZAP score is a little lower than the other wideouts who were picked in the top-10 because, quite simply, his age-adjusted collegiate production profile wasn't as good. His top year yards per team pass attempt rate came in at 2.86, and that hit during his Senior season.

Fortunately, even though he's not an early-declare receiver, Odunze's still got age on his side. He's just a tad older than Marvin Harrison Jr., and that allowed his Breakout Score to sit at a respectable 86.2.

Early-declare status matters, but not nearly as much as some in the analytics world believe. We've seen a lot of non-early-declare busts out of the first round since 2011, yes, but many of those busts had poor Breakout Scores.

For some context, from 2011 to 2021 (we'll limit things to that timeframe to give players three years of NFL experience), we watched 12 non-early-declares get drafted in Round 1. Five of those 12 players had Breakout Scores below 60. Four of those five failed to reach 10 or more PPR points per game in one of their first three seasons, while just one of the players *above* the 60 mark was unable to get to that average.

In the end, non-early-declare first-round picks with strong Breakout Scores have performed far better than early-declare first-round picks with *poor* Breakout Scores through the years. That's good news for someone like Odunze.

Odunze also has a nice Teammate Score. Washington teammate Ja'Lynn Polk went 37 overall, while Jalen McMillan fell to 92. That helps his ZAP score out, too.

Things aren't poor for Odunze analytically. He's just not as well off as Harrison Jr. and Nabers. He may also have a little more difficult of a time gobbling up a huge target share in Year 1 while competing alongside DJ Moore, Keenan Allen, and Cole Kmet. Long-term, playing for the Bears should be excellent. Short-term, we may not see as high of a ceiling as we'd want to see out of a top-10 pick.

You should still feel great about getting Odunze in your rookie drafts, though. In most other classes, he'd be the clear-cut WR1. This one is just different.

BRIAN THOMAS



94.5

ZAP Score

WR

Louisiana State Tigers (Jacksonville Jaguars)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'3"

Weight:

209

Statistical Comps: Quentin Johnston ▪ Torrey Smith ▪ Terrace Marshall

Update: The Jacksonville Jaguars desperately needed some wide receiver help, so they went out and selected Brian Thomas with the 23rd overall pick in the draft.

The ZAP Model loves it.

Thomas' Draft Capital Delta profile pegs him as a "low risk" bet, but there's definitely more iffiness to his profile than the model is seeing. Thomas was below a 1.0 yards per team pass attempt rate across his first two seasons of college ball before breaking out as a Junior. That breakout was pretty massive – he hit a 2.86 yards per team pass attempt while playing with sixth-overall pick Malik Nabers – but he really only has one season of production under his belt, hence the volatility.

There also aren't many good comparables for Thomas. You'll see Quentin Johnston as his top comp, but the match isn't actually all that strong. We haven't seen many players like Thomas come out over the last 15 years or so, making him, again, a higher-variance selection for rookie draft purposes.

Enough with the bad, though. Thomas is a great prospect. He still isn't 22 years old, and because his 2023 season was so good, his Breakout Score is a more-than-respectable 86.8. He can immediately play a field-stretching, Martavis Bryant-like role for the Jags by using his insane size and athleticism, and there's a real chance for him to develop that further and become a true X receiver. As Matt Harmon of Reception Perception put it, "...he is the much more actualized version of prospects within this archetype that have come out recently in Quentin Johnston and Christian Watson."

A 94.7 score in the ZAP Model tells us that Thomas has a pretty good shot to be a productive fantasy asset. The fact that Jacksonville has such an opening at the position means that he could be fairly productive right away, too. There weren't many better spots for a wide receiver to go to for fantasy purposes.

KEON COLEMAN



86.4

ZAP Score

WR

Florida State Seminoles (Buffalo Bills)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'3"

Weight:

213

Statistical Comps: Breshad Perriman ▪ Kevin White ▪ Courtland Sutton

Update: Buffalo was probably the best landing spot for a wide receiver in this year's draft, and Keon Coleman was the Bills' selection at the top of the second round. That, naturally, will raise his rookie draft cost.

The ZAP Model doesn't see Coleman as an unbelievable prospect. He couldn't get to a max-season yards per team pass attempt of 2.0 in college, something 74.4% of the class accomplished. That led to a Breakout Score that was barely above average at 55.5. We've had some hits in the top portion of the second round from players with a mediocre Breakout Score, but we'd ideally want that number to be higher.

Looking at this more optimistically, Coleman played at Michigan State before his final collegiate season at Florida State, and, there, he was able to perform better – statistically – than teammate Jayden Reed. It's good to have a data point showing that he can compete with a legit NFLer. He's also an early-declare who's only 21 year old – Coleman's the second-youngest wideout who was invited to the combine this year, with Malik Nabers being the only one younger.

Let's go back to that landing spot, though. Per Matt Harmon's Reception Perception, Coleman struggled a bit against press and man defenses. He was strong against zone. He's got a prototypical X receiver build, but he may, according to Harmon, be better off working as a big slot to start his NFL career.

That may be an issue in Buffalo. The Bills signed Curtis Samuel this offseason, who largely played the slot in Washington. He, however, can probably move to the outside. But Khalil Shakir is there as well, and he's played the majority of his NFL snaps from the slot. They also have capable pass-catching tight ends taking up space and targets in that area of the field.

Keon Coleman is likely going to play the X role for Buffalo, and that presents more risk when you select him in your rookie drafts.

There were worse wide receiver picks to make – Courtland Sutton is one of Coleman's comps, after all – but Coleman was close to having a high-risk Draft Capital Delta. He's not a guaranteed bust, it's just important to be realistic and not let the landing spot overshadow the talent profile. Because the talent profile is far from flawless, and the situation he's now in may be a little more difficult than it seems at face value.

TROY FRANKLIN



77.7

ZAP Score

WR

Oregon Ducks (Denver Broncos)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'3"

Weight:

176

Statistical Comps: Jameson Williams ▪ Paul Richardson ▪ Jalin Hyatt

Update: Troy Franklin's projected draft capital in the pre-draft version of this guide was in the early second round. He ended up getting selected in the early *fourth* round.

The reason for the slip is probably related to his size. Franklin's under 180 pounds, and according to Matt Harmon's Reception Perception, he struggled against press coverage. That's not going to get any easier in the NFL, and it could lead him to going down the path as some of his top comparables in the ZAP Model. Jalin Hyatt makes a ton of sense as a comp.

Franklin's still an attractive Day 3 receiver. He's one of three wideouts from this class to have an 85 Breakout Score, an 85 Fantasy Points Score, and a max-season yards per route run rate above 3.0. The other two are Marvin Harrison Jr. and Malik Nabers.

His age-adjusted production is strong.

The fit in Denver is a nice one. The Broncos drafted Marvin Mims last year, and he struggled at times as a rookie. Courtland Sutton is older and could be on his way out soon. More importantly, the Broncos selected Bo Nix in Round 1, and Nix was Franklin's quarterback at Oregon. The two lit it up in 2023, leading to Franklin's prorated 2.90 yards per team pass attempt rate, the 11th-best mark in the class.

Now that Franklin's rookie draft cost shouldn't be as high as it was pre-draft, he's someone to eye.

ADONAI MITCHELL



84.0

ZAP Score

WR

Texas Longhorns (Indianapolis Colts)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'2"

Weight:

205

Statistical Comps: Alec Pierce ▪ Van Jefferson ▪ Chris Conley

Update: Just a couple of years ago, the Colts took an athletic wide receiver who had poor collegiate production with the 53rd overall pick in the draft. Here in 2024, Indy selected an athletic wide receiver who had poor collegiate production with the 52nd overall pick in the draft.

It appears they have a type.

Adonai Mitchell's top comparable in the ZAP Model is Alec Pierce. That's who Indianapolis selected two drafts ago. And, as we know, Pierce hasn't exactly worked out.

The ZAP Model does like Mitchell more than Pierce. Their Breakout Scores are comparable – Pierce's is slightly worse – but Mitchell's an early-declare who played at Georgia and Texas, accumulating a strong Teammate Score. Pierce was at Cincinnati.

There are definitely massive red flags here, though. Mitchell's got a sub-50 Breakout Score, and only 18% of second-rounders since 2011 with Breakout Scores below 50 have provided any sort of sustained fantasy relevancy. What's worse – not for the model, but just in general – is that Mitchell was horrific on a per-route-run basis in college. Only two wide receivers in this year's class had a best-season yards per route run rate below 2.0. One of them is Mitchell. And Mitchell's is worst.

The Colts, at least, are getting someone who has a good shot to be an upgrade over Pierce. That should get Mitchell onto the field quickly in two-wide receiver sets.

But we shouldn't sell this as a good landing spot. Michael Pittman is there, and he recently signed an extension. Josh Downs, an underrated slot receiver, is going to be in Indy for three more seasons on his rookie deal. And the offense with Anthony Richardson is bound to be fairly run-heavy. There's plenty of data that shows mobile quarterbacks are bad for their pass-catchers in fantasy.

The way AD Mitchell ends up being a fantasy football stud is if he's undeniably good. There are just too many analytical issues for me to think that's a likely outcome.

LADD MCCONKEY



87.5

ZAP Score

WR

Georgia Bulldogs (Los Angeles Chargers)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'11"

Weight:

209

Statistical Comps: Sterling Shepard ▪ Marvin Mims ▪ TJ Graham

Update: When it comes to the production metrics that go into the ZAP Model, Ladd McConkey's not looking so hot. His top year in receiving yards per team pass attempt is only 1.63, the third-lowest mark in the class. After getting selected in the second round by the Chargers, McConkey joins three other Round 2 wideouts since 2011 who had a best-season yards per team pass attempt rate under 1.70. Those three guys? Aaron Dobson, Mecole Hardman, and Van Jefferson.

There's a key difference between McConkey and those three pass-catchers, though, and that's in the yards per route run department. Dobson was drafted before yards per route run data became accessible, but Hardman had a top-season yards per route run rate of 2.75, per PFF, while Jefferson's was 2.00. McConkey's sits at 3.26.

Yards per team pass attempt correlates strongly to yards per route run when analyzing best-season numbers. Every once in a while, we'll see situations like this where they just don't match up. And it makes my brain hurt.

McConkey's yards per route run rate in his top season is sixth-highest in this draft class. Of the players who come in higher, each one had a receiving yards per team pass attempt rate above 3.30. McConkey's, as I said above, was 1.63!

How is this even possible, you ask? Well, turns out, McConkey just didn't run enough routes at Georgia. Whether that was due to game script or injury, he wasn't out there enough. He was *great* when he was on the field, but he ranked fifth in routes run for the Bulldogs last year.

Yards per team pass attempt gets signal, and not being on the field isn't ideal. We can still subjectively boost McConkey up a tad, though, and think of his Breakout Score as being better than 42.9.

McConkey wins in other areas of the model. His Teammate Score is top-notch, and he was able to amass rushing yards at Georgia as well. The Chargers got him because of that versatility – they really needed a player who can win everywhere in that offense, even if it's a more run-heavy one than we'd like.

McConkey's in a good spot to see a high target share immediately on a team that lacks receiving weapons. He's a relatively safe option, even with the production worries.

XAVIER WORTHY



95.6

ZAP Score

WR

Texas Longhorns (Kansas City Chiefs)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'11"

Weight:

165

Statistical Comps: Marquise Brown ▪ Jordan Addison ▪ Jahan Dotson

Update: Xavier Worthy is small, and that frame gave him some issues at Texas. According to Matt Harmon's Reception Perception, Worthy ranked below-average against press coverage, coming in well behind last year's small wide receiver king, Tank Dell.

The ZAP Model doesn't factor in size, probably because it's captured in draft capital. And Worthy got draft capital. He was selected 28th overall to Kansas City, making him just the fourth sub-170-pound wideout to get picked in the top-100 since 2011. The other four wide receivers? Devonta Smith, Marquise Brown, Tank Dell, and Tutu Atwell. It's a tiny sample, but that's not a bad group.

What makes Worthy look so special in the model is his age-adjusted production. As a Freshman, he posted a yards per team pass attempt rate of 2.88, leading to the third-best Breakout Score in the class behind only Malik Nabers and Marvin Harrison Jr. Yes, Worthy has blazing speed, and that's something the Chiefs undoubtedly fell in love with. But we generally don't see these types of players enter the league with such strong age-adjusted profiles.

The fact that Worthy's yards per team pass attempt rate didn't improve after his Freshman year is a concern, and perhaps the model isn't fully comprehending that side of things. With that being said, our small-sample history of Freshman peakers doesn't look so bad. Only seven players in the ZAP Model had their top season in prorated yards per team pass attempt as Freshman while getting top-150 capital. Of those seven, you get hits like TY Hilton, Stefon Diggs, Christian Kirk, and Amon-Ra St. Brown.

There are certainly some non-model red flags here, and we should be cognizant of them. The landing spot in Kansas City, however, should be able to mitigate some of that risk. The Chiefs are great at creating space for their wide receivers, and Worthy will be placed in situations where he's not having to beat press coverage the same way he would in other schemes. That's a plus from a fantasy perspective.

Will he become a super high-volume pass-catcher in the league? Probably not. That's why it's easy to disagree with the model's assessment of Worthy being a "low risk" option. But can he still be a strong fantasy asset in this situation via efficiency? 100 percent.

Don't let his size fool you. Worthy can play.

XAVIER LEGETTE



86.2

ZAP Score

WR

South Carolina Gamecocks (Carolina Panthers)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'1"

Weight:

221

Statistical Comps: JJ Arcega-Whiteside ▪ Jonathan Mingo ▪ Hakeem Butler

Update: Xavier Legette has the strangest production profile you'll find from a wide receiver prospect. We got mostly nothing from him during his first four years at South Carolina, with his single-season receiving yards total topping out at 167.

And then the 2023 season happened. Legette went from a yards per team pass attempt of just 0.59 in 2022 to a rate of 3.05 last year. He's one of just eight wideouts in the class with a best-season number north of 3.0. Since that figure was so strong, his Breakout Score came out to be a respectable 78.0.

Legette's an older prospect, but that may not be that big of a deal when you combine his age with his Breakout Score. Dating back to 2011, the ZAP Model database has only seen two other 23-year-old wide receivers get drafted in the 20 to 40 range with Breakout Scores above 75. Those two pass-catchers were Calvin Ridley and Deebo Samuel. Loosening those parameters to players chosen between Pick 1 and Pick 60, and you add Sterling Shepard and Jayden Reed to the mix. Those receivers all scored better versus draft capital than Legette did – Legette's the only "high risk" profile of the group – but things could be looking worse.

In Charlotte, Legette will attempt to fill a perimeter role that was really lacking last season. Jonathan Mingo – who's hilariously one of Legette's comps – ended last year with a 0.78 yards per route run rate while running two-thirds of his routes from the outside. Even for a rookie, that yards per route run rate was horrendous. Mingo's a more natural "big slot" type, and the Panthers new coaching staff likely sees that. They needed a body – in this case, an uber-athletic body – to allow Mingo some flexibility. In turn, Legette has a chance to find the field right away opposite of newcomer Diontae Johnson.

Whether you target Legette or not really comes down to cost. It's easy to imagine him falling in rookie drafts that have data nerds as managers. You can swing at the profile's volatility in those environments. It just wouldn't seem reasonable to aggressively target Legette, because the model definitely sees him as a risky gamble.

JA'LYNN POLK



86.5

ZAP Score

WR

Washington Huskies (New England Patriots)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'1"

Weight:

203

Statistical Comps: DaeSean Hamilton ▪ Dez Fitzpatrick ▪ Parris Campbell

Update: Thank goodness for Teammate Score, because it's making Ja'Lynn Polk's ZAP Model profile look much more relevant. As many of you know, he played alongside Rome Odunze and Jalen McMillan in college, and that naturally impacted his overall numbers.

But his overall numbers still weren't fantastic.

Polk's Breakout Score – again, we're all on the same page here that teammate context is important – is just 38.5. He's now the seventh wide receiver in the ZAP Model database to go in Round 2 with a sub-40 Breakout Score, and none of the other six were able to reach double-digit PPR points per game in one of their first three NFL seasons.

There's a legit chance Polk can break that streak. He fell to New England, and the Patriots have no real presence on the perimeter, which is where Polk spent most of his time at Washington. He should be able to start with rookie Drake Maye immediately, giving him a nice target share ceiling as a rookie. He could end up being a nice value over on Underdog.

Not only that, but the reason Teammate Score exists is so that we don't overstate particular production metrics. Polk's Breakout Score is bad, yes, but among those second-round wide receivers with similar numbers, Polk's Teammate Score is *by far* the highest.

When looking at his overall ZAP score – you know, the thing that matters most with all these calculations – you've got a player who more or less fits his draft cost. Chances are, you won't see anything Late-Round Fantasy Football-related that'll be overly high or overly low on Polk.

And, remember, this is a different New England Patriots regime. The fact that they've been bad at picking wide receivers in the past doesn't mean we should worry about Polk being a bust.

DEVONTEZ WALKER



65.3

ZAP Score

WR

North Carolina Tar Heels (Baltimore Ravens)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'2"

Weight:

193

Statistical Comps: Jalen Tolbert ▪ Dante Pettis ▪ Devin Street

Update: Devontez Walker going to Baltimore in Round 4 is a great real football fit, but it may not turn into a great fantasy football one.

Walker began playing college football at North Carolina Central in 2020, but he actually didn't get run because the season was cancelled due to COVID. He then transferred to Kent State in 2021, where caught just 5 passes for 124 yards and a score.

We didn't get sincere production from Walker until 2022. He finished that season with a yards per team pass attempt rate of 2.64, his highest of his collegiate career, but that number gets brought down a bit in the ZAP Model because it was snagged at Kent State. That's not exactly a powerhouse football program.

Walker then moved back to North Carolina and played for the Tar Heels in 2023. He was initially denied eligibility, but he was able to play eight games. His prorated yards per team pass attempt finished off at 2.47. In the end, Walker completed college with just a 54.9 Breakout Score and a 51.6 Fantasy Points Score. He was completely ordinary within those metrics.

The Ravens are always looking for deep threats with Lamar Jackson under center, and they got that with Walker. He had a ridiculous 22.3 average depth of target at Kent State in 2022, and he followed that up with an 18.2 aDOT in 2023. He was 21st among qualified wide receivers last year in percentage of targets that traveled 20 or more yards. He was sixth in college football in deep ball yards per game, too.

Will there be much more for him? Considering his ZAP score and comparables, we shouldn't bank on that. It doesn't make him a bad draft selection for the Ravens, but it makes him a later-round pick only in rookie drafts.

ROMAN WILSON



75.7

ZAP Score

WR

Michigan Wolverines (Pittsburgh Steelers)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'11"

Weight:

185

Statistical Comps: Randall Cobb ▪ Phillip Dorsett ▪ John Metchie

Update: With Arthur Smith in town, the Steelers are going to lean more on the run. The Falcons were bottom-five in the league in pass rate during two of his three seasons there as head coach. As offensive coordinator in Tennessee during the two years prior, the Titans were 29th and 30th in pass rate.

Pittsburgh beefing up their offensive line in the draft isn't a surprise, but, even with this run-heavy offense, they also had a huge void at wide receiver that needed to be filled after they traded away Diontae Johnson this offseason. And they started to fix that problem with Roman Wilson.

Wilson profiles as a slot guy. He only had one season above a 1.10 yards per team pass attempt rate, and it came last year when he ran about 69% of his routes out of the slot. His Breakout Score is below the median as a result.

Wilson's ZAP score looks OK enough for the draft capital that he received because he was a pretty versatile player at Michigan. He was able to compile some production on the ground – that's a plus for the model – and he's got enough speed to potentially beat guys deep as well.

It's tough to imagine a world where Wilson is lighting it up in fantasy football. He's walking into a conservative offense, and he could be limited to the slot in the NFL. But he'll have a role right away, which isn't something we can say about all Day 2 wideouts.

MALACHI CORLEY



71.8

ZAP Score

WR

Western Kentucky Hilltoppers (New York Jets)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'11"

Weight:

215

Statistical Comps: Amari Rodgers ▪ Deebo Samuel ▪ Kealoha Pilares

Update: Since 2011, the ZAP Model has seen 11 wide receivers get selected in the top-100 of the NFL Draft after failing to register a Breakout Score. Among that group, only Terry McLaurin was able to do anything of substance in fantasy football during his first three years in the league.

Malachi Corley has a Breakout Score of zero.

Corley's top season in yards per team pass attempt ended up being only 2.08, a number that's not all that impressive considering the competition he faced at Western Kentucky. That's why his Breakout Score didn't show up.

A key reason for that poor production profile was deployment. Over 38% of Corley's targets last season came behind the line of scrimmage. Per PFF, 44.3% of his targets were screens, one of the highest marks in college football last year.

This explains Corley's sub-8.0-yard average depth of target rates throughout college. When aDOTs are that low, it's going to be a little more difficult to capture a huge yards per team pass attempt number.

Corley did generate a ton of yards after the catch in that role as a Hilltopper, and that's why you've likely seen and read Deebo Samuel comps for him. Samuel is a physical comparison for sure – the ZAP Model thought so, too – but Corley's profile matches Amari Rodgers much better. That's because Samuel's production profile was far, far better.

There are worse landing spots than the Jets. They've got their stud WR1 in Garrett Wilson, and New York signed Mike Williams to a one-year deal this off-season, too. Corley, at a minimum, could play a little slot in Year 1 while getting gadgety touches in the offense.

Could Corley end up doing more down the line? Sure. All evidence just points to "we don't know", since we haven't seen him in a standard wide receiver role. He's a work in progress, and because of that, combined with his ZAP score, he's probably not someone you should put a premium on in rookie drafts.

RICKY PEARSALL



89.7

ZAP Score

WR

Florida Gators (San Francisco 49ers)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'1"

Weight:

190

Statistical Comps: Jayden Reed ▪ Markus Wheaton ▪ Denarius Moore

Update: When Ricky Pearsall's write-up was published back in early March, he was projected to *maybe* be a second-round pick. Maybe. Back then, it was easy to call him a rookie draft target. Now, he's going to rise up boards thanks to his relatively surprising Round 1 draft capital.

That presents more of a problem.

History doesn't favor Pearsall. Specifically, his Breakout Score of 57.7 is a pretty big concern. Since 2011, there hasn't been a single first-round wide receiver hit who had a Breakout Score below 60. That list includes Cordarrelle Patterson, Tavon Austin, Kelvin Benjamin, Kevin White, Phillip Dorsett, Josh Doctson, Henry Ruggs, Jalen Reagor, and Kadarius Toney. Bring that number up to 70, and you add Nelson Agholor and John Ross to the mix.

Even if you look strictly at players drafted between Pick 20 and 40 since 2011 – Pearsall's range – the results aren't great. The only two players in that group who ended up being productive in fantasy were Michael Pittman and Christian Watson. And the jury's still out with Watson. That's out of 11 wideouts, too.

Pearsall still isn't tagged with a "high risk" Draft Capital Delta because he was such a versatile receiver at Florida, which is helping his score. He ran for 175 yards over his final two seasons, with a 113-yard campaign in 2022. The Gators lined him up everywhere, and some would consider him the best route runner in this entire draft class.

The ZAP score is what matters most. Being around 90, Pearsall doesn't have a dramatically different tally than non-early-declare Zay Flowers had last year (91.2). Pearsall just may have a tougher time finding action in Year 1 while competing with Brandon Aiyuk, Deebo Samuel, George Kittle, and Christian McCaffrey.

Aiyuk is a free agent next year, and there's always a chance we see a trade, which would open things up for Pearsall. But without a trade, you run the risk of Pearsall not holding value from Year 1 to Year 2. The fit is awesome – Kyle Shanahan will have no problem maximizing Pearsall's skill-set – but the fantasy side could end up being bumpy. Let's hope Pearsall gets a shot, because he's good.

JOHNNY WILSON



46.2

ZAP Score

WR

Florida State Seminoles (Philadelphia Eagles)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'6"

Weight:

231

Statistical Comps: Dorial Green-Beckham ▪ Collin Johnson ▪ Mike Strachan

Update: Very-large-human-being Johnny Wilson ended up going later in the draft than most expected. The Eagles snagged him in Round 6, and they got a player who could, hypothetically, back up their studly perimeter wideouts in the offense.

Wilson's production marks weren't all that bad in college. After failing to post much production at Arizona State, he transferred to Florida State in 2022. There, he immediately put up a 2.27 yards per team pass attempt rate, giving us a Breakout Score of 37.7.

Those third-year numbers took a slight hit in Year 4, unfortunately, and it's partially because of Keon Coleman joining the squad. On the plus side, though, Wilson actually finished 2023 with a better receiving yards per team pass attempt compared to Coleman. And Coleman was selected in the early second round.

Don't expect Wilson to be a producer without injuries going down in the Eagles offense. Unlike Ainias Smith, Wilson doesn't really fit a role that's open in the offense. He's more of a depth piece and red-zone threat for Jalen Hurts.

BRENDEN RICE



42.4

ZAP Score

WR

Southern California Trojans (Los Angeles Chargers)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'2"

Weight:

208

Statistical Comps: Michael Wilson ▪ Aaron Dobson ▪ Jaleel Scott

When it comes to the things the ZAP Model looks at, Brenden Rice doesn't grade out all that well. He never got anything going when he started his college career at Colorado, and while his production increased at Southern Cal in 2022 and 2023, his numbers still weren't special. His best-season in yards per team pass attempt was only 1.86, and his other relevant season was at 1.19.

That all led to a Breakout Score of zero. Since 2011, of the wide receivers selected after the first round and through Pick 150 who had a Breakout Score of zero, only three scored 10 or more PPR points per game in one of their first three seasons in the league: Cecil Shorts, Hunter Renfrow, and Terry McLaurin.

Many will likely point to Rice's big touchdown number in 2023 as reason to like him, but his 32.4% touchdown share last year was barely above the average max-season touchdown share in this year's class. The raw number looks good – he scored 12 times – but USC was also top-five in the country in passing touchdowns. That waters things down.

Rice, per the model, has a very strong match to Michael Wilson, who came out of last year's class. Wilson's someone who's fine, but he's unlikely to have a massive ceiling in the NFL. If Rice can find himself on a team that lacks alternatives – as Wilson did last year – then, sure, he might be able to give you WR3 or WR4 seasons over the next few years.

We just can't bet on that right now. Even if it is someone with Jerry Rice's genes.

JALEN MCMILLAN



74.6

ZAP Score

WR

Washington Huskies (Tampa Bay Buccaneers)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'1"

Weight:

197

Statistical Comps: Kenny Stills ▪ Tandon Doss ▪ Amon-Ra St. Brown

Update: The ZAP Model is into Jalen McMillan. Sure, his 74.6 score isn't anything to write home about, but, compared to draft capital, the model's looking at him favorably.

McMillan landed with Tampa Bay in the third round. He ran roughly 90% of his routes from the slot in 2022 and 2023 – his only productive seasons at Washington – so we should probably expect that kind of role with the Buccaneers. Trey Palmer occupied that area of the field on 57% of his routes last season, which led the trio of receivers (Mike Evans and Chris Godwin included) in Tampa Bay. Palmer, however, finished the year with a pitiful 0.84 yards per route run – a number that's not strong regardless of competition – so maybe the Buccaneers simply see McMillan as an upgrade.

Don't sleep on McMillan, either. He was banged up in 2023, which really allowed Ja'Lynn Polk, an early second-round pick, to break out. In 2022, though, McMillan had over 400 more yards than Polk, and he led Washington – a team that had Rome Odunze on it, too – in receiving touchdowns.

Things look messy in Tampa Bay right now because they have two very good veteran wide receivers to go along with a second-year wideout who appeared to be good enough in 2023. How, you might wonder, will McMillan find the field?

He may not. It may take a little time. But we should always bet on talent, and McMillan seems to have it.

JERMAINE BURTON



76.9

ZAP Score

WR

Alabama Crimson Tide (Cincinnati Bengals)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'0"

Weight:

196

Statistical Comps: Malcolm Mitchell ▪ Trey Palmer ▪ Robert Woods

Update: There've been some off-the-field questions surrounding Jermaine Burton, and that could be the reason he was drafted in Round 3 this year instead of Round 2. But he got decent draft capital when he landed with the Bengals at 80th overall.

And he got Joe Burrow, too.

Burton's been a relatively underrated player throughout the draft process. He started off at Georgia, and, in 2021, he was second on the team in receiving yards. As a Sophomore. On a team that had Brock Bowers, Ladd McConkey, Adonai Mitchell, Darnell Washington, and, for four games, George Pickens.

Compared to the rest of the class, Burton's numbers are really solid. His Breakout Score is 10th-best among combine invites, and his Fantasy Points Score ranks 7th. He's being brought down just a little bit – or at least not enhanced – by a lack of rushing production that others in the class have.

Cincinnati's a solid place for him to be. Tee Higgins is franchise-tagged for 2024, but he's a free agent in 2025. Tyler Boyd's gone, leaving Ja'Marr Chase as the only long-term reliable option for the Bengals offense.

Burton can, in Year 1, get vertical for Cincinnati. He can create some splash plays for the offense. Per PFF data, he ranked in the 96th percentile last season in percentage of targets that traveled 20 or more air yards. We know he can play that role.

Just don't think it'll stop there. If everything comes together, Burton could be a very, very reliable fantasy option on a Tee Higgins-less Cincinnati team.

JAMARI THRASH



49.3

ZAP Score

WR

Louisville Cardinals (Cleveland Browns)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'0"

Weight:

188

Statistical Comps: Vincent Brown ▪ Dax Milne ▪ Dillon Mitchell

Update: Jamari Thrash has the third-best max-season receiving yards per team pass attempt rate in this year's class. The reason he's got a "high risk" Draft Capital Delta is because it took him a while to get to that number. He was at Georgia State for four years, and he needed all four seasons to just get over 500 receiving yards in a single campaign. That was the year where he dominated and had a 3.77 yards per team pass attempt, over two yards higher than his number from the previous season.

Thrash then transferred to Louisville for his final collegiate season in 2023. As a Cardinal, his yards per team pass attempt was a pretty ordinary 2.45.

Despite his size, Thrash, per Pro Football Focus, played very little slot receiver at both Georgia State and Louisville. That makes it tougher to forecast how he'll be used in the NFL. Chances are, he'll still end up as a slot guy.

In Cleveland, he may have a hard time finding the field right away. Amari Cooper, Jerry Jeudy, and Elijah Moore look pretty good on paper, even if Jeudy and Moore haven't lived up to expectation in the NFL. With only a disappointing perimeter receiver in Cedric Tillman behind them on the depth chart, the Browns probably saw Thrash as a good depth piece who doesn't fit the same archetype.

You should view him that same way on your dynasty roster. He's just a deep stash at the moment.

JACOB COWING



65.5

ZAP Score

WR

Arizona Wildcats (San Francisco 49ers)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'8"

Weight:

168

Statistical Comps: Jaelon Darden ▪ Tank Dell ▪ Scott Miller

Update: Jacob Cowing is a Day 3 favorite of the ZAP Model. His Draft Capital Delta is neutral, but his Breakout Score of 74.3 is 12th-best in the class after he tallied some monster seasons at UTEP. He played three years there – two of them had elite receiving yards per team pass attempt rates – before transferring to Arizona. His production was still OK at Arizona, where he hit prorated yards per team pass attempt rates of 1.82 and 2.25 during his two campaigns there.

Size is a concern for Cowing, but we've seen smaller wideouts thrive in today's NFL. Just last season, Tank Dell – a top comp for Cowing – looked the part in Houston's offense.

It should be noted that the majority of Cowing's snaps came from the slot, likely due to his smaller frame. And he ranked in the top-10 in targets behind the line of scrimmage over the last two seasons – his two played with Arizona – which could point to him not being able to win targets more naturally.

Fortunately, he went to San Francisco, a place where we should feel more confident that he can be schemed open. The 49ers have a lot up in the air at wide receiver, so we know that selecting Cowing in our rookie drafts could go south, but Shanahan and company probably saw a good route runner with speed and got excited. San Francisco is clearly trying to add that speed element in this draft after taking Ricky Pearsall (4.41 40), Isaac Guerendo (4.33), and Cowing (4.38).

Since the offense has so many weapons, you're unlikely going to have to spend up to get Cowing in rookie drafts. Don't be opposed to taking him, though. Situations can change fast, and with Brandon Aiyuk on the last year of his deal and Deebo Samuel the subject of trade rumors, things could open up in a hurry.

Cowing's got an analytical profile that indicates he's talented. You should be spending lower-end draft picks on that.

MALIK WASHINGTON



51.5

ZAP Score

WR

Virginia Cavaliers (Miami Dolphins)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'9"

Weight:

191

Statistical Comps: Devin Duvernay ▪ Michael Campanaro ▪ D'Wayne Eskridge

Update: The best Day 3 wide receiver pairing might be Malik Washington going to Miami. Yeah, yeah, I know – the Dolphins have two target hogs on the roster already in Tyreek Hill and Jaylen Waddle. What they don't have is a reliable slot receiver, and that's exactly what Washington is.

After a tough time producing at Northwestern for four years, Washington transferred to Virginia for one final season of college ball. There, he caught 110 passes for 1,426 yards and 9 scores, skyrocketing his best-season yards per team pass attempt rate to 3.60, a top-five number in the class.

Pro Football Focus graded Washington as the second-best Power Five wide receiver in college football last year, behind only Malik Nabers. His yards per route run in 2023 was comfortably in the top-10 within the class, and he has a Fantasy Points Score of 83.6, one of the better scores in the group.

Washington's production at Northwestern is really the issue here. He was a monster in 2023 with some of the best numbers among these incoming rookies, but his four years at Northwestern were troubling, which is why he doesn't look better in the ZAP Model.

Sometimes, though, players just go to the wrong school for production maximization. And Northwestern didn't exactly have the best passing distributors while Washington was there. Mike McDaniel's offense with two insane vertical threats on the outside is totally different. Washington plays with a lot of toughness, and he'll be able to generate plenty of yards after the catch in this system. He's just got to win that slot job, which is certainly in his rookie-season range of outcomes.

AINIAS SMITH



64.1

ZAP Score

WR

Texas A&M Aggies (Philadelphia Eagles)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'9"

Weight:

190

Statistical Comps: Curtis Samuel ▪ Marcus Green ▪ Randall Cobb

Update: Ainias Smith's game is easy to like. He played running back as a Sophomore at Texas A&M (or was listed as one), where he ran the ball 40 times and caught 43 passes. He then was a more traditional wide receiver as a Junior, and, as a Senior, he hurt his leg and missed the majority of the season. He went back for another year in 2023, where he put together the best receiving season of his career.

There's so much versatility with Smith, so he's just easy to fall in love with. And that's what the Eagles likely saw, too. Philly doesn't have a locked-in slot guy on the team, and Smith can be that dude. He was a low-average-depth-of-target receiver who generated yards after the catch through explosiveness in college. Letting AJ Brown and Devonta Smith do their thing vertically on the outside while Ainias Smith creates on shorter throws is a chef's kiss match.

Will that turn into fantasy football goodness? It may take a minute. With Dallas Geodert at tight end and Saquon Barkley out of the backfield, a full-time slot guy in Philadelphia still may max out at a 13% or 14% target share. That doesn't mean there won't be some spiked weeks, though. And there's definitely some contingent injury upside.

Smith's a fair late-round rookie pick, and he's even someone you might want to consider at the end of Underdog best-ball drafts this summer within your Eagles stacks. He's very close to having a "low risk" Draft Capital Delta.

JAVON BAKER



67.6

ZAP Score

WR

Central Florida Knights (New England Patriots)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'1"

Weight:

202

Statistical Comps: Allen Hurns ▪ Rishard Matthews ▪ Michael Gallup

Update: That Patriots are getting weapons for Drake Maye. And unlike the last regime, they selected a couple of solid prospects in the first four rounds of the draft.

Ja'Lynn Polk was their early-second-round selection, and Javon Baker was their fourth-round one. Baker started his collegiate journey at Alabama, where he caught just nine passes in two seasons. He then transferred to Central Florida where he immediately produced as a Junior, catching 56 balls for almost 800 yards. That resulted in a yards per team pass attempt rate of 1.76.

Things really got going in 2023, Baker's Senior season. He actually caught fewer passes (52) compared to his Junior year, but his yardage total increased by 43%. A 17.1 average depth of target helped with that. Baker, in the end, hit an impressive 3.11 yards per team pass attempt rate last year, helping him get to an 82.4 Breakout Score. That's a top-10 number in the class.

It was a late breakout for Baker, but we can at least understand why. Playing for Alabama in 2020 and 2021 meant that he was competing for touches with players like Devonta Smith, John Metchie, and Jameson Williams. It would've been nice to see a little more production from Baker, no doubt, but we at least saw it all come together in 2023 for him.

The Patriots depth chart, as you read with Polk, is pretty bleak. They're truly building from the ground up. You can throw Polk and Baker on the perimeter, let Demario Douglas work in the slot, and get away with it. It's a young group, but it's a promising group.

Because there's so much opportunity there, Baker will have a chance to show out and become a key target in that offense. We shouldn't bet on him being better than Polk – or seeing the field before Polk – but we should be open-minded to that possibility. He's a good Day 3 prospect.

LUKE MCCAFFREY



69.5

ZAP Score

WR

Rice Owls (Washington Commanders)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'2"

Weight:

198

Statistical Comps: Jordan Payton ▪ Damion Ratley ▪ Antoine Green

Update: Luke McCaffrey – who, yes, is Christian's brother – started out his college career at Nebraska in 2019. As a quarterback. He was a mobile passer who didn't get a ton of playing time, and he eventually ended up at Rice, where he gave quarterback one last try. In 2022, he officially moved to wide receiver.

McCaffrey's lower production totals aren't surprising when you consider his journey. He only played wide receiver for two seasons, and it's kind of impressive that he still posted yards per team pass attempt totals of 2.12 and 2.30 in his only two seasons as a wideout.

During those two campaigns, McCaffrey played out of the slot on about 71% of his snaps. Considering his frame, inexperience, and speed, he's probably going to be a slot guy in the NFL. And that works for where he was drafted, since Washington lost their slot man, Curtis Samuel, over the offseason. McCaffrey should be considered the favorite at this point to take on that role.

Now, if we're being honest, with a mobile Jayden Daniels under center, that type of job in the Commanders' offense isn't going to generate a ton of fantasy points. Samuel had an underrated season for Washington last year, but this is a different coaching staff with a different quarterback under center. McCaffrey will have a tough time overtaking Terry McLaurin and Jahan Dotson in the offense.

In deeper formats, though, McCaffrey's a fine enough late-round rookie dart throw. There could still be some untapped potential with him considering he's only played wide receiver for a couple of years, and he's an athlete. He comes from an athletic family, and he posted passing, rushing, *and* receiving yards throughout college. There's nothing wrong with buying into that a little bit.

MARCUS ROSEMY-JACKSAINT



17.9

ZAP Score

WR

Georgia Bulldogs (Undrafted)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'1"

Weight:

195

Statistical Comps: Jalen Brooks ▪ James Wright ▪ Russell Gage

Georgia has one of the most competitive programs in the country, but that doesn't totally excuse Marcus Rosemy-Jacksaint's production profile. Or lack thereof.

Rosemy-Jacksaint does well in the model's hyphenated last name metric – he matches players like JuJu Smith-Schuster and Marquez Valdes-Scantling – but the rest of his numbers are really lacking. He failed to register a Breakout Score after hitting a max-season yards per team pass attempt of just 1.26. We've only seen two wide receivers in the ZAP Model get even close to fantasy relevancy with Breakout Scores of zero and yards per team pass attempt rates below 1.30: Russell Gage and Hunter Renfrow. Gage is actually one of Rosemy-Jacksaint's comps.

But are you really getting excited about drafting Russell Gage? And that's probably a 95th percentile outcome for Rosemy-Jacksaint.

Again, competition certainly played a role here. Rosemy-Jacksaint played with legit NFL-caliber receivers at Georgia. If he couldn't do more on the field there, though, why should we expect anything more when he's competing with actual NFL receivers?

JORDAN WHITTINGTON



45.7

ZAP Score

WR

Texas Longhorns (Los Angeles Rams)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'1"

Weight:

205

Statistical Comps: Jehu Chesson ▪ Cornell Powell ▪ Jacob Copeland

Another wideout who competed with NFL-quality talent in college is Jordan Whittington.

You've already seen the scores for Whittington's teammates Adonai Mitchell and Xavier Worthy, and there's no reason to necessarily prefer Whittington over those two players. He does have a couple of noteworthy items to his scouting report, though.

Whittington was actually listed as a running back during a Freshman season that was cut short after one game due to injury. He was officially a wide receiver starting in 2020, and he hit his peak yards per team pass attempt rate of 1.87 in 2021.

That type of number isn't going to cut it – most high-end fantasy assets see higher yards per team pass attempt figures than that – but the fact that Whittington got there in 2021 allowed him to have some semblance of a Breakout Score. It was 36.2.

A huge red flag to Whittington's profile is that he'll be over 24 years of age at the draft. Only one wideout in the ZAP Model's history has gotten above eight PPR points per game in one of his first three years in the league after being older than 24 when he entered the league. That was John Brown, and he didn't come from a big program like Texas.

Whittington took a back seat to Worthy and Mitchell as primarily a slot player for Texas during his final two seasons. He could be a bigger slot guy in the NFL if things break his way, but if he couldn't beat out Worthy and Mitchell, you have to wonder if he can beat out other pro players.

There's some versatility with Whittington, but it's doubtful he ends up beating the odds.

JHA'QUAN JACKSON



53.4

ZAP Score

WR

Tulane Green Wave (Tennessee Titans)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'9"

Weight:

188

Statistical Comps: Devon Wylie ▪ Kaelin Clay ▪ Chris Finke

Update: Jha'Quan Jackson has a smaller frame, and he played the majority of his snaps out of the slot during his five years at Tulane. We should expect him to be limited to that kind of role at the start of his NFL career.

Considering the team that drafted him – the Titans – that's totally fine. They'll have veteran wideouts DeAndre Hopkins and Calvin Ridley getting a lot of reps on the perimeter, while Treylon Burks, Kyle Philips, and, now, Jha'Quan Jackson battle for slot work.

Jackson's numbers don't give me a ton of confidence. He's 24, and he, per the model, was never able to break out at Tulane. His Dominator Rating got him a breakout, but the ZAP Model doesn't care much for touchdowns.

Jackson does come with a rushing profile, and that's really helping his ZAP score out. There's also a nice speed element to his game – it just didn't show up in production throughout college.

Considering his age and his comparables, it'd be a surprise if Jackson ended up being a reliable fantasy contributor. Can he win the slot role for the Titans? That's an entirely different discussion.

TAHJ WASHINGTON



40.8

ZAP Score

WR

Southern California Trojans (Miami Dolphins)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'10" Weight: 174

Statistical Comps: Jalen Cropper ▪ Charlie Jones ▪ John Brown

Tahj Washington, compared to the players ranked this low in this year's class, does have some more favorable marks in his profile. His best season in yards per route run is 10th-best in the class, and it was better than USC teammate Brenden Rice. Washington actually averaged more yards and receptions per game than Rice in each of the last two seasons.

The difference is that Washington doesn't have the standard NFL wide receiver build, and he ran 88% of his routes out of the slot during this two-year timeframe. Odds are, that's how an NFL team is going to want to use him.

Just 7 of the 34 sub-180-pound wide receivers in the ZAP Model's database who've played three years in the league ended up scoring 10-plus PPR points in one of their first three seasons as a pro. Five of those seven were top-100 picks, and the remaining two, Darnell Mooney and Dede Westbrook, played far more out of the slot during their productive collegiate seasons. Each had a better Breakout Score than Washington, too.

Maybe Washington will get drafted higher than expected, but the chance that he becomes a high-ceiling player in fantasy seems pretty small.

JALEN COKER



18.3

ZAP Score

WR

Holy Cross Crusaders (Undrafted)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'1"

Weight:

208

Statistical Comps: Justin Watson ▪ Tyler Johnson ▪ Jordan Lasley

Jalen Coker is the first Holy Cross wide receiver in the ZAP Model's database. Needless to say, the Crusaders don't have a standout program.

Coker's still a pretty interesting prospect. His numbers are naturally inflated because he went to a small school, but it's not like every small-school wideout is able to get to the 4.11 yards per team pass attempt level that Coker got to as a Senior. He's just the 22nd player since 2011 to have a best-season yards per team pass attempt rate above 4.0.

Breakout Score is adjusted for both games played and program size, so Coker's score takes a hit because he played at Holy Cross. Even still, his Breakout Score of 84.5 is seventh-best in the class.

Coker's got the size to play the perimeter, as he did throughout college. He was lined up out wide on 90% of his routes run across his four years at Holy Cross, per Pro Football Focus. He can get deep, too – his average depth of targets were well above average in three of his four seasons. It's just always tough to know how that'll translate against much more difficult competition.

We can't say that we haven't seen a Jalen Coker type in the past. His comparables list players who were once beloved as deep dynasty stashes and who didn't really come to fruition. That's Coker's most likely outcome, too.

But there haven't been *that* many Jalen Cokers through the years. He did what he had to do against subpar competition, and he's got good enough size. If you want to throw a final-round dart at the guy, be my guest.

ANTHONY GOULD



49.2

ZAP Score

WR

Oregon State Beavers (Indianapolis Colts)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'8"

Weight:

174

Statistical Comps: Jarrod West ▪ Tre Nixon ▪ Jameon Lewis

Update: The Colts took Anthony Gould in Round 5, and, not to be rude, but you can essentially ignore the pick for fantasy purposes.

OK, OK. We should be open to anything being possible. And Gould's a little interesting, I suppose, because, at his smaller size, he actually played a lot on the perimeter in college. Per Pro Football Focus, he ran more than 200 routes in just one of his four collegiate seasons, which came last year. And, last season, he had a slot rate of just 7.4%. The year prior, it was 37.3%. The year before that? That's when he played primarily out of the slot – his rate was 90.5%.

Gould, however, has a sub-40 Breakout Score, and he's got a bottom-five Fantasy Points Score, too. It's hard to see this kind of profile beating out Michael Pittman, Josh Downs, and Adonai Mitchell over the next few years.

BUB MEANS



43.3

ZAP Score

WR

Pittsburgh Panthers (New Orleans Saints)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'1"

Weight:

213

Statistical Comps: Javon McKinley ▪ Devin Lucien ▪ Cayleb Jones

Update: Bub Means got to college in 2019, playing defensive back for Tennessee. He then transferred to Louisiana Tech and sat out 2020 before playing a season of wide receiver for them in 2021. After that, Means transferred to Pitt (#Hail2Pitt), where he'd play his final two collegiate seasons, tallying a best-season yards per team pass attempt rate of just 2.00.

Means has good size, and he can definitely get down the field. His average depth of target last season was 17.7. He also ranked fifth in college football in percentage of targets that traveled 20 or more air yards.

Means can play a deep-ball role for New Orleans, but it'd be shocking if he became something more. He has a "high risk" Draft Capital Delta, and, among the 50-plus wide receivers drafted after Pick 150 in the ZAP Model with a high-risk tag, only Darius Slayton and Darnell Mooney were able to reach double-digit PPR points per game in one of their first three seasons. Both players gained dynasty value, sure, but neither of them had a year of 13 PPR points per game.

Means is a long shot to be a reliable starter in fantasy.

RYAN FLOURNOY



35.0

ZAP Score

WR

Southeast Missouri Redhawks (Dallas Cowboys)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'1"

Weight:

202

Statistical Comps: Isaiah Weston ▪ Amba Etta-Tawo ▪ Byron Pringle

Ryan Flournoy's another small-program wideout who could get drafted on Day 3, but his numbers aren't as strong as someone like, say, Jalen Coker.

Aside from not playing at a Power Five school, one of the biggest red flags to Flournoy's statistical profile is his age. He'll be 24-and-a-half years old during this year's draft, making him the second-oldest wide receiver in the class. Since 2011, the best wide receiver in the ZAP Model database who was that old coming out is probably Byron Pringle, one of Flournoy's comps.

Google tells me that Flournoy got to college in 2018 and redshirted. At the time, he was playing for Central Missouri. He caught just 17 balls in 2019 while playing through injury, and it appears as though the team didn't play in 2020 due to COVID.

After that 2020 season, Flournoy transferred to Iowa Western Community College, where he posted a 32-545-5 line. He finally got to his final destination, Southeast Missouri State, in 2022, where he played two seasons.

A player going through that type of trip en route to the NFL isn't one you generally want to side with. It's a cool story, and we should hope he flourishes (Flournoyishes?), but the odds that happening are pretty small.

Flournoy's max-season yards per team pass attempt of 3.00 got him a Breakout Score, but, given his age, that score is just 25.0. There's a reasonable chance he doesn't get drafted in April, so you can wait and see if he beats probability, snagging him off waivers.

CORNELIUS JOHNSON



39.0

ZAP Score

WR

Michigan Wolverines (Los Angeles Chargers)

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'3"

Weight:

212

Statistical Comps: Tyrie Cleveland ▪ Brice Butler ▪ Mack Hollins

Cornelius Johnson was at Michigan for five seasons, and while he wasn't terrible, he wasn't elite, either. His best year in yards per team pass attempt was 1.67 (he had a higher prorated one during the COVID year, but he only played four games), and his top season in yards per route run ranks fifth-worst in the class.

On the positive side, Johnson did finish second on Michigan this past season in receptions, trailing Roman Wilson – a favorite of many in this class – by one. He has great size and caught 9 of 11 contested targets last season, per Pro Football Focus, which was the fourth-highest mark in college football among 50-plus target receivers. That may not translate against tougher opponents in the NFL, but he did test well at the combine, so perhaps there's something there.

Unless Johnson gets drafted higher than anticipated, you likely won't have to spend a rookie pick on him. But there are definitely worse bottom-of-the-barrel wide receivers in this class. Johnson at least has some data points that look good.

LIDEATRICK GRIFFIN



10.9

ZAP Score

WR

Mississippi State Bulldogs (Undrafted)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'10"

Weight:

181

Statistical Comps: Marquis Maze ▪ James Quick ▪ Tyler Vaughns

Lideatrack Griffin is on the smaller side for a wide receiver, so his 90.6% slot rate in 2023 isn't very surprising. What is kind of surprising is that he barely played in the slot at all during his three other seasons at Mississippi State. In 2022, for example, PFF has Griffin with a 2.0% slot rate.

Griffin's numbers were best – by far – during his 2023 campaign when he manned the slot. His season high in yards per team pass attempt from 2020 to 2022 was just 0.79. Last year? 1.89.

That's still not a very high number, and no one should be selling Griffin as a can't-miss prospect. It's just evidence to show us that he's almost definitely going to play the slot in the NFL, if he's able to carve something out on a team.

As I've said, slot guys sometimes don't show out in the ZAP Model, but it would still be a shock if Griffin ends up as a roster-worthy dynasty asset. Players with scores this low just don't give us fantasy production.

ISAIAH WILLIAMS



28.1

ZAP Score

WR

Illinois Fighting Illini (Undrafted)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'9"

Weight:

182

Statistical Comps: Demario Douglas ▪ Richie James ▪ Jameon Lewis

There are plenty of smaller, late-round slot players in this class.

Isaiah Williams is one of the most intriguing.

Williams kicked off his collegiate career at Illinois as a quarterback. He got some playing time and had 63 pass attempts in a shortened 2020 COVID season, but he eventually switched to wide receiver in 2021. So, really, he hasn't been at this very long.

Williams immediately produced. He tallied 525 receiving yards and a 1.63 receiving yards per team pass attempt rate in 2021. In 2022, that rate grew to 1.81. Then, this past year, he got it all the way up to 2.54. That production gave Williams a respectable Breakout Score of 48.0, and his 76.5 Fantasy Points Score is seventh-best in the class.

When looking at ZAP Model wide receivers who were drafted after Pick 150 and got to a Breakout Score of 40 and a Fantasy Points Score of 70, a little over 8% gave fantasy managers a 10-plus PPR point per game season during one of their first three seasons as a pro. With the alternative group – players with scores below those marks – that rate drops to a little over 2%. So Williams has a slight advantage there.

Clearly an athlete, Williams has one of the best after-the-catch profiles in this class. His top season in yards after the catch per reception is fifth-best among draft-hopeful wideouts, and he ranked in the 90th percentile last season in tackles avoided per reception.

It's not easy finding attractive profiles from wide receivers who may not even get drafted. Williams, though, has some worthwhile marks. He's someone to watch during the draft process. And his statistical comps agree.

TAYVION ROBINSON



25.6

ZAP Score

WR

Kentucky Wildcats (Undrafted)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

5'11"

Weight:

191

Statistical Comps: Chris Owusu ▪ Reggie Roberson ▪ Johnny Johnson

Tayvion Robinson, like so many NFL-hopeful wide receivers these days, transferred during his time at college. He started things off at Virginia Tech where he played for three seasons, and his final two came at the University of Kentucky.

All in all, for a player expected to go undrafted – or, at least, that's what it's looking like now – Robinson's numbers aren't that bad. He never had a crazy high yards per team pass attempt rate, but his Breakout Score is 51.6 after getting worthwhile production in 2021. He had *some* production all five seasons in college.

But, yeah, this profile doesn't scream success. Robinson never had a huge average depth of target in any college season, but that lower aDOT did allow for some higher yards after the catch totals. It just seems unlikely that a player Robinson's size will be able to maintain strong after-the-catch numbers. That's especially true when you consider he ranked in the 26th percentile last year in forced missed tackles per reception.

Never say never, but you can at least avoid Robinson in your rookie drafts this year.

XAVIER WEAVER



11.7

ZAP Score

WR

Colorado Buffaloes (Undrafted)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'0"

Weight:

169

Statistical Comps: Tevin Reese ▪ JJ Nelson ▪ Scott Miller

For someone with such a poor draft capital projection, Xavier Weaver's profile isn't all that bad. His Breakout Score is 59.6 and his Fantasy Points Score is 46.9. Only 13 wide receivers in the 2024 class were able to get to those levels.

Weaver played at South Florida for four years before transferring to Coach Prime's Colorado Buffaloes in 2023. He gave us yards per team pass attempt rates above 2.0 in each of his final three seasons, including a 2022 campaign with USF that saw him reach a 2.94 rate.

There's not a ton of size to Weaver, but he's fast. He was often used as a down-field threat in college, especially in 2021 when he ended the year with a high 18.2 average depth of target.

Mock drafts don't seem to favor or care about Weaver, and it's highly unlikely we see significant draft capital attached to him in April. But the depth of this wide receiver class is sort of on display here – Weaver is an afterthought despite having some totally fine data points.

DEVAUGHN VELE



33.8

ZAP Score

WR

Utah Utes (Denver Broncos)

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height:

6'4"

Weight:

203

Statistical Comps: Binjimen Victor ▪ Stephen Guidry ▪ Jake Wieneke

The ZAP Model database includes over 660 wide receivers. The average wide receiver age on draft day, since 2011, has been 22.4. Meaning the ordinary wideout has been just shy of 22-and-a-half years old prior to his particular NFL Draft.

No wide receiver in the database has come out of college football older than Devaughn Vele.

My man is going to be almost 26-and-a-half years old when this year's draft starts. That's a year-and-a-half older than Justin Jefferson. As in, Justin Jefferson *today*, not when Jefferson entered the league.

It's also a year older than any other wide receiver in the model's history.

Vele evidently went on a religious mission trip before college, which pushed football aside for some time. But Vele's age is a huge reason why his ZAP score is one of the worst we've ever seen. He failed to register a Breakout Score, unsurprisingly, though his top-season in yards per team pass attempt at Utah was a respectable 2.35. He also has an above-average Fantasy Points Score, which is kind of crazy.

Vele's age makes him an obvious avoid. We've never had a 25-year-old come out and give us more than a single fantasy point per game at wide receiver since 2011. Expecting goodness from a 26-year-old is a low-probability thought.

Tight End

Player	College	Team	ZAP	Notes
Brock Bowers	Georgia	Raiders	99.3	Elite prospect; Weird spot with Mayer in the mix
Ben Sinnott	Kansas State	Commanders	83.9	Decent destination; Would've liked slightly better production and athleticism
Tip Reiman	Illinois	Cardinals	81.8	Epic athletic profile; Horrific landing spot
Theo Johnson	Penn State	Giants	73.4	Elite athlete; poor production profile; Interesting landing spot
Jaheim Bell	Florida State	Patriots	68.5	Model loves him; Small size for a productive tight end
Ja'Tavion Sanders	Texas	Panthers	67.8	Pretty good production; Pretty good landing spot; Above-average prospect
Erick All	Iowa	Bengals	63.6	Arguably second-best production profile behind Bowers; Strong landing spot
Cade Stover	Ohio State	Texans	51.7	Reunited with CJ Stroud; Relatively ordinary profile
AJ Barner	Michigan	Seahawks	50.3	Average athleticism with below-average production
Jared Wiley	Texas Christian	Chiefs	44.1	Below-average production with decent athleticism; Older
Tanner McLachlan	Arizona	Bengals	20.3	Oldest tight end drafted; Good size and decent speed
Devin Culp	Washington	Buccaneers	6.3	Great athlete; Poor draft capital; Not young

The Year 2 Model

Overview

We learn more about players with time. A rookie entering the NFL is a whole lot more unpredictable than a six-year veteran. You're looking at a player who's never stepped foot on an NFL field versus one who's potentially played close to 100 games in the league.

Naturally, after a player gets through his rookie season, we understand more about his game. Puka Nacua got to Rams camp last summer as an unknown to many, and he ended up having one of the greatest rookie wide receiver seasons we've ever seen. And now we can adjust accordingly.

But how, exactly, should we adjust?

That's where the Year 2 Model comes into play.

The goal of the Year 2 Model is to be much better at predicting a player's second- and third-year production than a player's rookie-season points per game average.

The Year 2 Model — both at running back and wide receiver — incorporates a player's prospect score, some rookie-season production inputs, and his rookie-season points per game average to get a Year 2 score. That's the gist of it.

Everything in the Year 2 Model ties back to a player's max-season PPR points per game during his second or third season. So if a player scored

16 and 19 points per game during his second and third season in the NFL, respectively, the model only cares about that 19 points per game mark.

As you'd guess, the Year 2 Model is much better at predicting a player's best points per game season in Year 2 or Year 3 than his rookie-season points per game average alone.

To me, this all is logical.

If a player came from nowhere — if a guy wasn't supposed to be good, but he balled out during his rookie year — then there's more risk with that player than if an early-round pick did the exact same thing.

There's more risk with, say, Dontayvion Wicks going into 2024 than there is with Josh Downs. It doesn't mean Wicks can't or won't outscore Downs over the next two seasons. It's that Downs has more substance to his baseline, which puts us — *should* put us — more at ease.

The Year 2 Model can help us out when higher draft selections underperform, too. Is Jaxon Smith-Njigba, last year's consensus top wide receiver, doomed? What about Quentin Johnston?

Similar to the ZAP Model, there are easy-to-understand probability charts for the Year 2 Model.

	Wide Receiver (Max Season; Years 2-3)						
Score	< 10	10+	12+	14+	16+	18+	20+
95-100	4%	96%	96%	84%	60%	40%	20%
90-95	25%	75%	67%	50%	29%	17%	8%
85-90	33%	67%	41%	22%	11%	4%	0%
80-85	65%	35%	19%	19%	4%	0%	0%
75-80	77%	23%	4%	0%	0%	0%	0%
70-75	82%	18%	4%	4%	0%	0%	0%
65-70	95%	5%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%
60-65	100%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%
55-60	92%	8%	4%	0%	0%	0%	0%
50-55	100%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%

Of the wide receivers drafted since 2011 with three-plus seasons in the league who had a Year 2 score between 95 and 100, nearly every single one gave us a PPR points per game season of 12 or more in either Year 2 or Year 3. A solid 60% of them hit 16 or more PPR points.

As you move from group to group, the hit rates predictably change. Wide receivers with scores in the 75 to 80 range almost always fail to give you a super usable season in Year 2 or Year 3. Below the 70 mark? Good luck.

So people are aware, the wide receiver Year 2 Model changed a bit from last year. New inputs were inserted, and the model became even more predictive.

The model looks pretty good at running back, too, but the visual isn't as clean.

	Running Back (Max Season; Years 2-3)						
Score	< 10	10+	12+	14+	16+	18+	20+
95-100	16%	84%	68%	63%	58%	42%	37%
90-95	6%	94%	81%	63%	38%	25%	13%
85-90	56%	44%	22%	17%	6%	0%	0%
80-85	79%	21%	5%	0%	0%	0%	0%
75-80	59%	41%	35%	29%	6%	6%	0%
70-75	37%	63%	42%	21%	21%	11%	11%
65-70	72%	28%	22%	11%	0%	0%	0%
60-65	94%	6%	6%	0%	0%	0%	0%
55-60	93%	7%	7%	7%	7%	0%	0%
50-55	100%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%

Running back is a tougher position to project than wide receiver. If a coach decides to split his backfield, then that's going to ruin the fantasy upside for a running back. You don't really run into that issue at wide receiver since so many are on the field at once.

With all that being said, it's pretty clear that a high-end score at running back yields amazing results. If a running back gets a score over 90, he's looking like a good bet to at least be an RB2 in fantasy football during the second or third year of his career.

You may notice that, after the 90 range, things start to drop off. And, given the probability charts, there doesn't appear to be *that* big of a difference between a player in the 70 to 75 range versus one in the 85 to 90 one. The 70 to 75 range actually looks better than the 85 to 90 one!

This has to do with a few things. One is variance. These buckets are arbitrary and only exist as general guidelines. It's not surprising that we'd see some funky results when you consider the sample size within each group.

Second, it's important to keep in mind that we're dealing with single-season output here. With the prospect models, we're looking at a player's top-two seasons in PPR points per game across his first three in the league. With this, it's just one "max" season. Results can fluctuate more.

The final reason — the most important one, in my eyes — is replaceability.

Nerds have been writing about it for years, but
non-elite running backs are sort of
interchangeable in fantasy football.

That's exactly what this table is showing.

The Year 2 Model looks at the running back landscape and says we should prefer a score of 80 over one of 70. But, at the end of the day, players with those types of scores are just similar. They're relatively replaceable guys who could go either way, depending on how their coaching staffs want to treat them. They're not obvious, Tier 1 running backs.

The running back Year 2 Model really comes down to three high-level groups. You've got the elite difference-makers who typically score above a 90. There's a cluster of "maybes" between 70 and 90. And once you get below 70, the running backs start becoming a lot more questionable.

Journey Comparables

Skyy Moore had a really disappointing rookie season.

There was hope that he'd be a legitimate weapon for Patrick Mahomes' Chiefs at a time when they desperately needed one, but he was buried on Kansas City's depth chart. He didn't do much contributing as a receiver for that offense, despite the unit's success in 2022.

According to the ZAP Model, Moore entered the league with a score of 85.8. After a poor rookie season, that score fell by about eight points in the Year 2 Model.

You can see, using the tables above, that a score of 77 gave Moore not-great odds of finishing as anything more than a WR3 — at best — during his second and third seasons in the league.

But had we seen anyone else overcome this sort of drop in year-over-year score?

Enter Journey Comparables.

You've probably already read about statistical comparables with the ZAP Model profiles earlier. Journey Comparables are a little different. Rather than looking at a player's attributes as he enters the league, Journey Comparables inspect a player's ZAP Model score alongside his Year 2

Model score. It then looks at players in history who have gone through a similar path — a similar journey — from before Year 1 to before Year 2.

Journey Comparables don't deal with play style, height, weight, or any other qualities. It's simply a look at players in history who entered the league as similarly graded prospects, and then who went into their second season with a comparable Year 2 Model score as well.

Moore's top Journey Comparables last season were Andy Isabella, DJ Chark, and Terrace Marshall. Things were not looking good. So his score, alongside those comps, made him an easy player to avoid in dynasty.

History often repeats itself. In fantasy football, too.



2024 Year 2 Model Profiles

Overview

Were you a fortunate soul who lucked into one of the greatest rookie wide receivers of all time in the fourth round of your rookie draft last year?

Sure, sure. Drafting Puka Nacua wasn't *only* some lucky break. Maybe you read last year's prospect guide and fell in love with his elite collegiate yards per route run rate. Maybe you did your homework and saw the hype he was receiving in camp over last summer. Maybe you watched him make some ridiculous plays at BYU.

You still didn't expect *this*.

Now that you've got Nacua...what's next?

I got you.

Over the final section of this guide, you'll read about all relevant wide receivers and running backs from last year's draft class.

You'll see where the Year 2 Model has them ranked, and you'll get insight on how to manage each player moving forward.

Let's refine those dynasty rosters.

Key Terms

ZAP Score: The score given to an incoming rookie in the ZAP Model. It's based on the factors outlined in the ZAP Model Overview section of this guide. For pre-draft scores, the draft capital input is based on projected draft capital from NFLMockDraftDatabase.com. All scores range from 0 to 100.

Y2 Score: The score given to a running back or wide receiver in the Year 2 Model. This is based on rookie-season numbers along with a player's ZAP score. All scores range from 0 to 100.

Expected Max PPR PPG Season: The estimated outcome in best-season PPR points per game in Year 2 or Year 3 for a particular player. This is simply a median, so the number is likely smaller than expected.

Journey Comparables: Players in history who have had similar ZAP and Year 2 Model scores.

Running Back

BIJAN ROBINSON		99.3
		Y2 Score
RB	Atlanta Falcons	 99.7
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:		17.4
		ZAP Score
Journey Comps: Todd Gurley ▪ Ezekiel Elliott ▪ Leonard Fournette		
Some would consider Bijan Robinson's first year in the NFL as a disappointment, but that's likely due to his acquisition cost. Robinson gave us the 22nd-best rookie running back season by PPR points per game since 2011. His average was better than, as an example, Christian McCaffrey's. A key reason Robinson didn't see a ton of movement with his ZAP score to his Year 2 one is because he was heavily involved as a receiver as a rookie. When looking at first-year backs since 2011, Robinsons' per-game target share rate trailed only Christian McCaffrey, Saquon Barkley, and Alvin Kamara. That translated into a pretty elite total yards per team play rate. The receiving side of the equation is very predictive at running back, so that helped Robinson maintain an elite score in the model. In the end, Arthur Smith really ruined Robinson's rookie year. The Falcons only gave their first-year back 47.6% of the team's running back rushes, when everyone knows he's capable of handling a much bigger workload. Smith also failed to use Robinson as the team's primary goal-line back for half of the season. Once that piece to Robinson's workload shifted, his PPR points per game average rose by four. He became an RB1. We've seen two players with a similar-ish Year 2 score bust since 2011. One was Doug Martin, who didn't enter the league with the same type of prospect score as Robinson. Martin just had a monster rookie campaign that boosted his tally. His Year 2 score wasn't as high as Robinson's, either. The other is Trent Richardson. There were some signs – especially when it came to efficiency – that Richardson had at least some chance to fail after we caught a glimpse of him in the NFL. It'd be shocking if Robinson went down that path. With a new coaching staff, we should feel good about his prospects.		

JAHMYR GIBBS

98.1

Y2 Score

RB

Detroit Lions



98.4

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

16.7

Journey Comps: Christian McCaffrey ▪ Jonathan Taylor ▪ Leonard Fournette

When you watch Jahmyr Gibbs and Bijan Robinson, you'll see two totally different running back styles. Throughout their careers, they're going to score fantasy points in different ways.

But as it relates to the models, they're really not all that different.

Robinson entered the league with a ZAP score of 99, while Gibbs' score was just a point below that. And, today, we're looking at a similar situation with the Year 2 Model.

It's no problem if someone prefers Gibbs to Robinson in dynasty, because his rookie-season performance was just as good, if not better. Gibbs was flashier, and his ability to create gigantic plays was obvious. He ended up with a 5.5% 20-plus-yard run rate, marking just the 10th time a running back has hit that high of a percentage on 150 or more carries since 2011.

We also saw Gibbs' workload get better and better as the year went on. Teammate David Montgomery was sidelined for a period of time in the middle of the season, returning to action in Week 10. From Week 10 onward, Montgomery had a 54% running back rush share and about a 5% target share per game rate in Detroit's offense. Gibbs was at roughly 46% and 12%, respectively, which were numbers far higher than what he'd been seeing earlier in the year.

What might be most important about that "Week 10 onward" split is that, despite Montgomery being Detroit's goal-line back, the two runners saw the same number of carries within their opponent's 10-yard line. Montgomery had just one more rush attempt within the five, too.

Montgomery is going to be around for at least 2024, and that'll limit Gibbs' upside. Even still, the Lions look like they'll be strong offensively in the short term, and they don't seem to be afraid of leaning on their duo. The situation and skill-set should lead to a lot of fantasy points for Gibbs.

Those Journey Comparables are looking pret-tay nice, aren't they?

DE'VON ACHANE

94.4

Y2 Score

RB

Miami Dolphins



85.0

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

14.9

Journey Comps: Alvin Kamara ▪ Miles Sanders ▪ DeMarco Murray

One of the things that last year's prospect guide (hopefully) drove into your noggin was that De'Von Achane's landing spot with Miami was absolutely perfect. Pairing his speed with Mike McDaniel's zone scheme was brilliant.

We saw why in 2023.

Achane is unlike any player we've ever seen before. At least in recent history. Sure, there've been guys who've gone from an 85 ZAP Model score to a 94 to 95 Year 2 one. That's nothing new. But Achane's size, speed, and efficiency combination this past year was totally unique.

Yards per carry isn't the most useful metric in the world, but it's hard to just blow past Achane's 7.8 yards per attempt rate last season. We've now seen 27 running back seasons in NFL history where the back carried the rock 100 or more times while hitting a 6.0 yards per carry rate. We've now seen one running back season in NFL history where the back carried the rock 100 or more times while hitting a 7.0 yards per carry rate.

And he hit a freaking 7.8 average.

Size remains a question mark for Achane. We know he can be a beast on limited touches, and that'll keep him in the mix for a while. The issue is on the ceiling front. He had trouble staying healthy as a rookie, and he hit a 60% running back rush share in just one game. It's not to say that he *needs* that rushing work, but it would sure make him a better fantasy asset if he had it.

Nevertheless, Alvin Kamara being his top Journey Comparable says a lot. And it should make you feel good about Achane. Kamara has a lot more size, but the way he scores fantasy points – that archetype – is what we're hoping for with Achane. A 14% to 15% target share to go along with 40% to 50% of his team's running back rushes is in Achane's range of outcomes over the next handful of seasons. And if he gets there, thanks to his offensive fit and skill-set, he could, hypothetically, give us spiked RB1 seasons. At the very least, we know he's capable of some monster performances week to week.

I'd have a hard time trading Achane away after what we saw in Year 1.

TYJAE SPEARS

90.5

Y2 Score

RB

Tennessee Titans



78.6

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

13.2

Journey Comps: Michael Carter ▪ Antonio Gibson ▪ Devin Singletary

One of the hottest names in dynasty this offseason is – will be – Tyjae Spears. With Derrick Henry likely out of Tennessee (this is being written before the start of free agency), Spears is looking like the starter. For now, at least.

Spears' rookie season was impressive given the limited role he played. His 14.8% target share was one of the higher ones you'll find among first-year running backs since 2011, and he stayed close to teammate Derrick Henry in expected points added per carry and success rate on the ground.

One issue you're going to run into with Spears is that some are undeniably going to price him at a premium over the next handful of months. There's no one ahead of him on the depth chart. He looked so explosive at times during his rookie season. Imagine a world where he's toting the rock 200 to 250 times with a 15% target share instead of the 100 carries he had in 2023.

It's hard to ignore the upside. Spears has a Year 2 score north of 90, and he was able to get there as a part-time rookie. Of the running backs who've played three NFL seasons since 2011 who had a Year 2 score between 87 and 93, 18% scored 17 or more PPR points per game in either their second or third season. Roughly 32% of them got to 14 or more PPR points per game, which is an RB2 campaign.

That may seem low, but considering how few running backs are able to actually hit those marks, it's actually a pretty strong group for Spears to be part of.

The top question with Spears is what'll happen if he is indeed the 1A in the Tennessee backfield. Like the aforementioned De'Von Achane, Spears is a little undersized. Could the Titans bring in a bigger-bodied back to help him out? To perhaps be the goal-line guy? Those are real concerns.

And the difference between Spears and someone like Achane is that the latter is not only a better player, but he's playing in a much more advantageous situation. Can Spears get by on a non-bell-cow workload in an up-in-the-air offense?

There are a lot of things pointing to Spears being a legit fantasy option. He's got the athleticism to take him places. But there are still some worries. Considering his current dynasty price tag, he's someone to probably not target in a trade or trade away this offseason.

ZACH CHARBONNET

90.3

Y2 Score

RB

Seattle Seahawks



92.0

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

13.1

Journey Comps: JK Dobbins ▪ Bishop Sankey ▪ Ameer Abdullah

As you know, the ZAP Model doesn't factor in landing spot. If a player ends up getting drafted by a really favorable team – like we saw with the aforementioned De'Von Achane – he's not getting some sort of score boost. We're just grading the players themselves here.

That's all important for Zach Charbonnet because, last offseason, the Seahawks decided to draft him despite having Kenneth Walker on their roster. Charbonnet was a good prospect – he looked pretty good objectively – but it was hard to rank him with all the uncertainty in that Seattle backfield.

We got some answers during the 2023 season. Charbs, as the team's RB2, ended up seeing about a 65/35 or 70/30 split with Walker. He then matched Walker in the receiving game. He wasn't overly effective as a pass-catcher, but his pass blocking was superior to Walker's, per Pro Football Focus.

Surprisingly, Charbonnet wasn't tremendously worse as a runner compared to Walker. In fact, you could argue the opposite. Charbonnet had a better rushing yards over expected per carry. His expected points added per carry was almost identical. His success rate was about a percentage and a half point better than Walker's.

Walker, known for his big-play ability, actually had worse 10-plus- and 20-plus-yard run rates than Charbonnet last year. And Charbs gained positive yards at a much better clip, too.

This isn't a total apples to apples comparison because the backs played different roles, but it's nice to know that Charbonnet competed well as a rookie.

That's what makes this so difficult. There's a new coaching staff in Seattle, and that coaching staff may favor one of the backs more than the other. We don't know yet. What we do know is that Charbonnet does indeed look like he could be a James Conner-type player, someone he compared closely to entering the league last season. It's just that James Conner with backfield competition isn't someone you're eagerly trying to draft or trade for in fantasy football.

Charbonnet's Journey Comparables are pretty iffy. Even though he's *just* above the 90 mark in the Year 2 Model, I still probably wouldn't be aggressive in targeting him this offseason. He's more of a hold.

ROSCHON JOHNSON

82.5

Y2 Score

RB

Chicago Bears



68.7

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

10.1

Journey Comps: Jamaal Williams ▪ Javorious Allen ▪ Brian Robinson

Roschon Johnson had a lower ZAP score than he should have had after playing behind one of the best running back prospects of the decade throughout college. Situations like that don't happen often, but, when they do, we can just toss in a little bit of subjectivity into our analysis. There's nothing wrong with that.

Johnson's rookie season was solid. Despite sharing a backfield with two capable runners in Khalil Herbert and D'Onta Foreman, he ended the year with a 25.5% running back rush share per game rate, and, more importantly, a 9.5% target share per game rate.

Johnson's just the eighth running back in the Year 2 Model to have had a sub-70 ZAP score before hitting a 9% target share per game average as a rookie. Four of those eight running backs gave fantasy managers a double-digit PPR point per game season in either their second or third year in the league. Three were over the 12-point threshold, and another was almost at 15.

That doesn't scream "league-winner", no, but it's not a bad outcome for a player with a low ZAP score. Remember, these scores are predictive. Expecting the world from a player like Johnson would just be unfair.

Johnson does have some things working in his favor entering 2024. D'Onta Foreman is currently a free agent, and Khalil Herbert is entering the final year of his rookie deal. With a potential upgrade at quarterback – and one that would be less mobile than Justin Fields – Johnson could be in store for a solid backfield share as soon as this upcoming season.

The receiving profile is intriguing here. And Johnson's Journey Comparables really aren't that bad. He's a pretty good trade target this offseason, and he's looking like a nice early value in Underdog drafts, too. If you'd rather wait to pounce after the free agency period, that makes plenty of sense, because the Bears *have* been tied to some of the available running backs out there.

KENDRE MILLER

75.7

Y2 Score

RB

New Orleans Saints



79.8

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

7.8

Journey Comps: Jay Ajayi ▪ Bernard Pierce ▪ Robert Turbin

There's a fine line in fantasy football between projecting an increased workload for a player and actually buying into that increased workload.

New Orleans has a potential out with Alvin Kamara's contract this offseason, so we can and should feel excited about Kendre Miller maybe seeing more work in the Saints backfield. He entered the NFL last season as the second-youngest back in his draft class, and he has the size to handle a lot of touches in the league.

Should we buy into that possible projection?

History can help us balance upside with reality. Miller's 5.4 PPR points per game average in 2023 puts him in a spot where he'll need to be somewhat of an outlier to be a difference-maker in fantasy football over the next two years. Since 2011, the ZAP Model database has seen a little over 300 running backs score fewer than 6.0 PPR points per game as rookies after getting a ZAP score below 85. Miller, with a ZAP score of 78.7, is part of that group.

Just four of those running backs had a Year 2 or Year 3 season with 16 or more PPR points per game scored. Only seven hit 14 or more PPR points per game.

Now, that sample is filled with running backs who weren't nearly as good as Miller when they were entering the league. You could limit this to ZAP scores between 75 and 85, though, and find that not a single one of the 23 hit 15 or more PPR points in either Year 2 or Year 3 of their careers.

When running backs show us little as rookies, they tend to not perform exceptionally well in subsequent seasons. You'll get a Kyren Williams or Devonta Freeman type every once in a while, but that's the exception, not the rule.

It's fine to be excited about Miller's potential jump in workload in 2024, because he *is* a young player. He *did* play behind a good running back in Year 1. He *was* banged up throughout the season.

Just remember to level out that enthusiasm with a little rationality.

KEATON MITCHELL

71.4

Y2 Score

RB

Baltimore Ravens



34.0

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

6.8

Journey Comps: Isiah Pacheco ▪ Jeff Wilson ▪ Thomas Rawls

It's rare to see undrafted players do what Keaton Mitchell did as a rookie. In the ZAP Model database, the only undrafted rookie backs to hit 8.0 or more PPR points per game – something Mitchell accomplished – were Thomas Rawls and James Robinson. That alone makes Mitchell unlike most backs.

When you layer his size on top, things get even wilder. Mitchell weighed in at 179 pounds at the NFL Combine, making him, among all combine-invited players, the second sub-180-pound running back since 2011 to score more than 2.0 fantasy points per game in one of his first three years in the league. The only other back this small to even sniff a fantasy lineup was Tarik Cohen.

Keaton Mitchell is an outlier, and we need to treat him as such.

Now, Mitchell suffered a pretty gruesome ACL injury in Week 15, so his beginning-of-the-season status is in question. Let's push that aside to keep this less complex.

Mitchell's top Journey Comparable – remember, these are not stylistic comps – is Isiah Pacheco. Pacheco was looked at more favorably as a prospect within the model, but he grew his Year 2 score into something that was manageable, similar to Mitchell.

The fact that Pacheco's continued onward with his growth isn't normal. We usually see a Thomas Rawlsian path to irrelevancy. So, theoretically, we should feel the same for someone like Mitchell.

Not so fast.

Remember: Mitchell is an outlier. He was not like rookie Jeff Wilson. Or rookie Thomas Rawls. Or even rookie Isiah Pacheco. He was better.

In 2023, Mitchell was second behind only De'Von Achane in running back success rate. He was first in yards per carry over expected per rush. He was *fantastic*.

We're not likely to see Mitchell take on 200-plus carries in the NFL. But in a fantasy football world where mid-range running backs are seeing their volume shrink, Mitchell can see just enough work to give you a potential RB2 season.

CHASE BROWN

64.1

Y2 Score

RB

Cincinnati Bengals



60.9

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

5.2

Journey Comps: Justice Hill ▪ DeeJay Dallas ▪ La'Mical Perine

Chase Brown's future dynasty potential depends a whole lot on Joe Mixon. The veteran is a free agent in 2025, but the Bengals could get rid of him this offseason. If they opt to nix him, then Brown could be elevated to starter in the offense. Even if Cincinnati chooses to keep Mixon around, Brown could still help your fantasy rosters. Because he brings an element that Mixon doesn't: explosion.

In 2023, Brown carried the ball 44 times. He gained 20 or more yards on 2 of those rushes, giving him a 20-plus-yard run rate of 4.6%. Mixon's been above 2.5% within that statistic just once in his entire career.

It's a small sample size, sure, but it plays into what we knew about Brown as he entered the league. He ran a 4.43 40 at the combine last year, giving him a 90th percentile Speed Score. He's capable of making splash plays.

We saw that ability in 2023. Not only did he break off just one fewer 20-plus-yard run than Mixon on 213 fewer carries, but 2 of his 14 receptions went that distance, too. His big-play receiving rate was higher than Mixon's as well.

It's very possible that Brown ends up digging more into Mixon's workload in 2024. If Mixon is a Bengal, of course. We witnessed that happening down the stretch this past season, where Brown had a 30% running back rush share across his final six games. Is it that crazy to think he could improve on that?

With all that being noted, we have to ground ourselves a little here. Brown was a fine prospect within the context of where he was drafted, but Day 3 running backs who did little in Year 1 typically don't become fantasy starters.

From 2011 to 2021, there were 110 running backs drafted after Pick 100 who scored fewer than 5.0 PPR points per game as rookies. Brown was at 4.5. Of those 110, only James Conner and Myles Gaskin scored 16 or more PPR points in either Year 2 or Year 3. Kyren Williams got there this past year, too, but we're looking at backs who've played three years in the league.

If someone is making the assumption that Brown would be a bell-cow without Mixon around, then you may actually be able to sell Brown high right now. Players with a Year 2 score of 64 don't work out very often at all.

TANK BIGSBY

63.4

Y2 Score

RB

Jacksonville Jaguars



82.9

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

5.1

Journey Comps: Christine Michael ▪ Ke'Shawn Vaughn ▪ Benny Snell

We've seen Tank Bigsby seasons before. Christine Michael, after getting selected 62nd overall in 2013, had a ZAP score of 82.7. (Props to the ZAP Model for giving him a horrible Draft Capital Delta, by the way.) After a whole lot of nothing as a rookie, Michael's Year 2 score sat at 66.8.

Look familiar?

How about Ke'Shawn Vaughn? Vaughn was a Day 2 pick who had a ZAP Model score of 83.2. After failing to produce as a first-year NFLer, Vaughn's Year 2 score fell below 70.

Seems a little Bigsbian, doesn't it?

Bigsby deserves to have this poor of a Year 2 Model score. On limited touches last year, his rate of gaining 10-plus yards on the ground sat at 2.0%. That was the fifth-worst figure among 50-plus attempt running backs since 2011. He showed absolutely no burst.

The only player to overcome a drop this significant in ZAP score to Year 2 score since 2011 has been, ironically, Travis Etienne. But the only reason Etienne's score dropped was because he missed his entire rookie campaign.

It's really, really tough to paint this favorably for Bigsby. He was just...bad. It's looking like a minor miss from the ZAP Model, and it's looking like you're going to need some luck – and probably an injury – to see Bigsby in your starting lineup.

Wide Receiver

PUKA NACUA

WR

Los Angeles Rams

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

17.9

99.5

Y2 Score



56.7

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Terry McLaurin ▪ Amon-Ra St. Brown ▪ Tyreek Hill

Maybe this isn't good for business, but you can throw Puka Nacua's Journey Comparables straight into the trash. There has not been a player like him since at least 2011. There really hasn't been a player like him in NFL history.

Nacua looks better in the ZAP Model than last year's Z-Prospect one, but his 56.7 ZAP score isn't anything special. What should we have expected from a fifth-rounder who couldn't produce at Washington for two years before having average production at BYU? Certainly not a 99.5 Year 2 score, that's for sure.

The Journey Comparables listed for Nacua are players who had iffier prospect profiles – whether due to lack of production or poorer draft capital – before tearing things up as rookies. None of them saw this kind of jump, though. Not even close.

Nacua's Year 2 score places him with superstar talent. The wideouts with scores above 99 in the Year 2 Model include AJ Green, Mike Evans, Odell Beckham, AJ Brown, Justin Jefferson, and Ja'Marr Chase. Five of those six wideouts had at least one season in either Year 2 or Year 3 with 19-plus PPR points per game. The only one who didn't get there was AJ Brown, and he scored 17.2.

The difference between Nacua and all of those pass-catchers is that their ZAP Model scores were much better. None, in fact, were below 94.

Puka Nacua, my friends, is the most unique young wide receiver we've ever seen.

It's understandable if you feel a little apprehensive to buy into Nacua given that poorer prospect score. But, as we know, the Year 2 Model is more predictive. How a player performs as a rookie can really tell us how he'll do as a veteran. And Nacua was unreal in 2023. His 28.7% target share per game rate ranked third-best among rookie wideouts since 2011. His 2.59 yards per route run was fourth. His 0.28 targets per route run ranked second. And he did it while playing a healthy mix of perimeter receiver and slot receiver.

Puka Nacua is a cornerstone player in dynasty.

Late-Round Fantasy Football: 2024 Prospect Guide
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ZAY FLOWERS

96.8

Y2 Score

WR

Baltimore Ravens



90.4

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

16.1

Journey Comps: Calvin Ridley ▪ JuJu Smith-Schuster ▪ Keenan Allen

Some may think Zay Flowers just did what he was supposed to do as a first-rounder in the NFL Draft, but he exceeded expectation. Flowers hit an impressive 24.1% target share per game rate as a rookie, his yards per route run was an above-average 1.64, and he played all over the field. He showed us – and the NFL – that his smaller frame really didn't matter.

Flowers is, at the moment, a pretty safe dynasty investment. His top Journey Comparables range from OK to studly, but other players who were close to being listed include Deebo Samuel, Brandon Aiyuk, and Tee Higgins. They're guys who ranked in the low 90s as prospects, and they were able to get over the 94 to 95 mark in the Year 2 Model.

Some may be turned off by Flowers' lower average depth of target in 2023, since it ranked in just the 17th percentile among 50-plus target wide receivers this past season. I'm not. Flowers was still getting plenty of down-the-field looks – his rate of seeing a 15-plus air yard throw fell into the 46th percentile among the same group. Baltimore just threw to Flowers a decent bit behind the line of scrimmage, lowering his aDOT. That tells me – us – that they were just trying to get their playmaker the ball more.

If you've got Flowers in dynasty, you should feel great about it. If you don't, he's not someone you *need* to buy, but players in his Year 2 range tend to do quite well during their second and third years in the league.

RASHEE RICE

95.7

Y2 Score

WR

Kansas City Chiefs



77.9

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

14.9

Journey Comps: Chase Claypool ▪ DK Metcalf ▪ TY Hilton

A lot of fantasy managers are super high on Rashee Rice, and it's easy to see why. His Year 1 yards per route run rate was seventh-best among qualified rookie wide receivers since 2011. As the season went on, his production only got better – he finished the year with an 18.2% target share per game, but that number was 27.3% over his final six regular-season games. That's...incredible.

Making a “buy” case for Rice isn't terribly difficult. Six wide receivers between 2011 and 2021 (so they've played three years in the NFL) in the Year 2 Model hit 10-plus PPR points per game as rookies while getting to a 2.20 yards per route run rate. Five of those six are considered some of the best wide receivers of the decade – Odell Beckham, Tyreek Hill, AJ Brown, Justin Jefferson, and Ja'Marr Chase. We've added more to that list over the last couple of seasons, and Rice is one of them.

Sweet. So we're all good then, yeah?

Not quite.

The way Rice scored points as a rookie was different than the way, say, AJ Brown scored points. Among 50-plus target rookie wideouts since 2011, Rice's average depth of target ranked ahead of only Jarvis Landry and Rondale Moore. That's because, according to PFF's data, among all receivers with 50 or more targets this past year, Rice ranked second in percentage of targets that came from screens. In other words, the Chiefs were doing what they could do to manufacture touches for Rice.

That's not necessarily a bad thing! Forcing the ball into Rice's hands tells us that he's at least got some talent. And Rice does. His yards after the catch ability is fantastic.

What this does tell us is that we just don't fully know yet. Rice is capable of developing more as a wide receiver and becoming something special. He's attached to Patrick Mahomes, too, which doesn't hurt. But his Journey Comparables tell us a more complicated story than his numbers indicate.

I wouldn't trade Rice away this offseason, but I wouldn't be aggressively trading for him, either, thanks to the market understandably loving on him.

JORDAN ADDISON

95.0

Y2 Score

WR

Minnesota Vikings



94.5

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

14.9

Journey Comps: Marquise Brown ▪ DJ Moore ▪ Jordan Matthews

Some of the things we look for in a rookie wide receiver weren't perfect for Jordan Addison in 2023. Among 50-plus target rookie wideouts since 2011, his yards per route run finished in the 40th percentile. His targets per route run was even worse, ranking in the 33rd percentile.

Those numbers will take somewhat of a hit when you're playing alongside Justin Jefferson. It also doesn't help when your team doesn't always throw you out onto the field in two-wide receiver sets. When playing mostly in 11 personnel, there are more options for the quarterback, lowering those numbers.

Even still, those types of figures *are* predictive. And that's a reason why Addison isn't looked at as favorably – despite a better ZAP score – as someone like Zay Flowers and Rashee Rice.

He's still a dynasty asset you want, though. He had about an 18% target share per game rate, and he had a PPR points per game average that aligned with Chris Olave during *his* rookie campaign. That's largely due to touchdowns – and he's due for some regression there – but it's good to see that his smaller frame didn't exclude him from finding the end zone in Year 1.

Having Marquise Brown and DJ Moore as Journey Comparables is solid. Jordan Matthews is there, too, and that may seem like a red flag, but Matthews actually held dynasty value pretty well prior to his demise.

It's unclear if Addison has top-12 ability at the position, but he's someone you can slot into your WR2 spot and feel pretty good about it.

JAYDEN REED

94.2

Y2 Score

WR

Green Bay Packers



82.6

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

14.4

Journey Comps: Stefon Diggs ▪ Torrey Smith ▪ Diontae Johnson

One of the bigger hits in last year's prospect guide was Jayden Reed. His prospect score wasn't unbelievable, but there were a lot of things to like about his profile. In college, he lined up all over the formation, he was used in the run game, and one of his top statistical comparables was Stefon Diggs.

Wait a minute. Stefon Diggs is his top Journey Comparable, too?

Whew.

Reed came through with a top-20 yards per route run rate among qualified rookie wide receivers since 2011. We saw his versatility on display throughout the season, too, as he rushed 11 times for 119 yards and a pair of scores.

There's a nice ceiling for Reed in the league – did I mentioned Stefon Diggs is one of his top comps? – but there's some room for pessimism. We saw Reed's usage and production dip when competition was added to the offense. For instance, during last year's regular season, when Christian Watson was sidelined, Reed averaged a target share per game of 21.6%. When Watson was active, that number fell to just 14.6%. His PPR points per game average went from 16.5 without Watson to 11.3 with him.

Reed was a rookie, so we've got to cut him some slack, sure, but we'd ideally like to see more reliability in and out of a split like that.

The Packers also did an amazing job adding weapons in the draft last year. Both of their rookie tight ends from 2023 look legit, and Dontayvion Wicks, who you'll read about in a second, had a surprisingly great season as well. If Reed isn't a top wide receiver – and, like Rashee Rice, we just don't have that answer yet – then he's unlikely to be in a position where he can produce elite numbers for fantasy given the competition on his team. If he was in a spot without such promise at pass-catcher, he'd be an easier player to buy over the next few months.

For now, we can hold onto the fact that a Year 2 score of 94.2 is very, very good. The chance that he completely fades is extremely low, with most players in his range giving us a WR2 or WR3 season in Year 2 or Year 3.

TANK DELL

93.6

Y2 Score

WR

Houston Texans



73.1

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

13.9

Journey Comps: Amon-Ra St. Brown ▪ Cooper Kupp ▪ Terry McLaurin

Tank Dell entered the league as a slightly worse prospect – according to the ZAP Model – than Jayden Reed and Rashee Rice. But you could very easily argue that he's the most intriguing of the three moving forward.

Dell's season was cut short thanks to a fluke injury, but he was balling out before that happened. Like Rice and Reed, his yards per route run ended up being one of the better ones we've seen from a rookie wide receiver since 2011. Only 10 wide receivers were better within the metric. And Dell didn't get there on screens – his 14.4 average depth of target was 24th-highest among 50-plus target rookie wideouts over the last 12 years.

One of the question marks with Dell last offseason was how his size might translate to the NFL. Would he be typecasted as a slot-only guy?

Nope.

Dell ran fewer than 30% of his routes from the slot. Rashee Rice, for comparison, was at nearly a 50% slot rate.

As you know, the Year 2 Model uses prospect scores. Dell's 73.1 ZAP score is embedded into his 93.6 Year 2 score. That's the reason we're not seeing his result into the upper 90s. The only way for him to have gotten there would've been for a Puka Nacua-level campaign.

This is where Journey Comparables can help. As you can see, Dell probably has the best Journey comps in this wide receiver class. He's grouped up with late Day 2, early Day 3 picks who had killer rookie seasons. People questioned the validity to those seasons, but each one of them kept it going and became great pieces in fantasy football.

That's a big reason to lean into Dell this offseason. Go ahead and trade for him. Go ahead and tell yourself, "Dude, you're getting a Dell." (Zoomers may not understand that reference.)

Tank Dell is here to stay.

JAXON SMITH-NJIGBA

92.8

Y2 Score

WR

Seattle Seahawks



98.1

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

13.5

Journey Comps: Brandin Cooks ▪ Treylon Burks ▪ Tyler Boyd

There's no getting around it: Jaxon Smith-Njigba's rookie season was a disappointment.

Say what you want about the competition in Seattle. Say what you want about the way the Seahawks used JSN. Say what you want about how bad the landing spot was. The fact still remains: It was a disappointing year for Jaxon Smith-Njigba.

There's not a lot that we can feel great about statistically. He ended the year with a respectable 17.0% target share per game rate, a number that should get a little extra love given the competition he played alongside. Ironically, that was the same share Doug Baldwin saw in Seattle years ago as a rookie slot player.

Baldwin, however, was a much more efficient wideout for the Seahawks back in 2011. While he finished his rookie year with an impressive 2.22 yards per route run rate, JSN ended his at 1.32. That's a 28th percentile rate.

A key issue for Smith-Njigba in 2023 – aside from having to compete for targets with Tyler Lockett and DK Metcalf – was how the Seahawks used him. He had an average depth of target of just 6.4, one of the lowest in the league, and he actually led all 30-plus target players in percentage of targets that came behind the line of scrimmage, per PFF. When a dude is getting a 15-plus-air-yard target on just 12.8% of his looks, you can't have sky-high expectations.

If you want a small ounce of good news for JSN, it's that DK Metcalf and Tyler Lockett combined to only miss one game this past year. It was a Week 7 contest against Arizona. Metcalf was out. In that game, Smith-Njigba posted his highest target share, receiving yard total, and fantasy point total of his rookie season. He also played in the slot at the lowest rate of his season.

It's fair to say that Smith-Njigba's situation is pretty uncommon – much more uncommon than any Journey Comparable will show. That's why this is a tough case. On one end, you've got the ingredients of an overvalued dynasty asset. On the other, nothing we saw in 2023 told us that JSN was exceptionally bad. He made some really nice plays. He showed off his route-running ability. And, when he finally got an opportunity, he had a solid outing.

I'd sell JSN now if I was getting a discount on another higher-end second-year wideout in return. His drop in score is troublesome.

JOSH DOWNS

92.0

Y2 Score

WR

Indianapolis Colts



81.7

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

13.1

Journey Comps: Tyler Lockett ▪ Jarvis Landry ▪ Courtland Sutton

Josh Downs was beloved by the Z-Prospect Model last season, and the ZAP Model doesn't mind him, either. At least compared to where he was drafted.

He came through as a rookie, securing an 18% target share and an above-average 1.60 yards per route run rate.

Downs entered the NFL, per the model, with Tyler Lockett as one of his top comps. He and Lockett had very similar peripherals as rookies, too. Lockett's target share per game rate was just a couple of percentage points lower. His yards per route run was 1.57. Downs had a receiving yards per team pass attempt rate of 1.34, while Lockett's was 1.36.

The difference between the two is that Downs was handcuffed to the slot as a first-year player. He ran 81% of his routes from that area of the field. Lockett, as a rookie, was at 33%. Lockett is often looked at as a slot guy – likely because of his size – but he generally has been around the 45% to 50% slot rate mark throughout his career. Downs didn't show us he could be that in Year 1.

He did display an ability to be a really productive slot player, though. That's a baseline for Downs. At worst, he stays locked into that role and gives us WR3-like production, with spikes when the Colts are forced to pass more. But there's always a chance he develops into more of a premier slot player in the league, similar to his number-two Journey Comparable, Jarvis Landry.

There are a lot of cool and interesting outs for Downs, which is why he's someone you might want to consider targeting before the season begins. If you'd rather not make the investment in dynasty, his ADP on Underdog is more than reasonable. You could buy into him there.

MICHAEL WILSON

86.4

Y2 Score

WR

Arizona Cardinals



66.1

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

10.1

Journey Comps: Romeo Doubs ▪ Antonio Callaway ▪ John Brown

Michael Wilson didn't have the strongest prospect profile. His top-100 draft capital helped out his score, but he had a Breakout Score of 0 because his adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt *just* missed the lowest threshold needed for a score.

Wilson battled injury throughout college, and he battled injury a bit in 2023. Injury proneness is likely not as real as some make it out to be, but that's something to monitor with Wilson.

The peripherals for Wilson in Year 1 were...fine. His Year 2 score is relatively high because the Cardinals used Wilson as a starter for most of the year, so he was able to accumulate some numbers on volume alone. A 14% target share per game rate and a 1.36 yards per route run isn't going to get you up in the morning, though. That doesn't scream "league-winner".

A fantasy football role player? Sure. Arizona's in a spot where they've got a good quarterback but lack weapons, so Wilson has a shot to continue being a starter in 2024. Just don't bet on him being an outlier. Wideouts in the 80 to 90 range in the Year 2 Model give us a 16-plus PPR point per game season in Year 2 or Year 3 at about a 7% rate. A 14-plus PPR point per game season – more WR2 territory – happens at an 18% clip. That's a more reasonable higher-end outcome for Wilson.

DONTAYVION WICKS

86.2

Y2 Score

WR

Green Bay Packers



44.1

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

10.0

Journey Comps: Darnell Mooney ▪ Donovan Peoples-Jones ▪ Tyreek Hill

Dontayvion Wicks became just the fifth wide receiver in the ZAP Model to have a prospect score below 60 prior to hitting a 2.00 yards per route run rate as a rookie. The other four were Robert Foster, who had a horrifically bad ZAP score, Donovan Peoples-Jones, Hunter Renfrow, and Tyreek Hill.

Considering the poor prospect score, that's not a bad group to be in.

Wicks didn't have as strong of a PPR points per game average in Year 1 as Renfrow and Hill had, and that could lead to disappointment. The vast majority of ZAP Model receivers with a score south of 60 failed to register a double-digit PPR point per game season as a rookie. Among that group – Wicks is part of it – only eight were able to get to 10 or more points per game in Year 2 or Year 3. Just one had a Year 2 and Year 3 season max above 14 PPR points per game, and that was Allen Hurns, who didn't produce very long.

Anything can happen, and a Year 2 score of 86.2 isn't something to totally ignore. Wicks' strong per-route-run numbers put him in a rare category, too. But, chances are, Wicks won't be someone you're plugging into your lineup every week no matter what. The competition in Green Bay could cause some unpredictable performances on a weekly basis.

Wicks is still someone I'd love to have on my dynasty rosters, especially if it's a best-ball league. Even in redraft, his early 2024 ADP via Underdog is quite reasonable. He could be considered a target there.

DEMARIO DOUGLAS

84.6

Y2 Score

WR

New England Patriots



49.5

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

9.2

Journey Comps: Hunter Renfrow ▪ Darnell Mooney ▪ Trent Taylor

Demario Douglas was a pleasant surprise out of last year's draft class. We sometimes see this with slot players, but his prospect profile wasn't all that impressive. Since he was a smaller-school player, he got dinged a bit in Breakout Score. He did have an OK receiving yards per team pass attempt year in 2022 – his final collegiate season – but it was also his fourth year out of high school. He wasn't spectacular, either.

We saw a similar thing happen with Hunter Renfrow. People remember Renfrow's career in college because he made some important catches for Clemson, but his age-adjusted numbers were pretty ordinary.

Renfrow is Douglas' top comp, which seems fitting. Both entered the NFL as undersized slot players with mediocre college production. Douglas had a 17.5% target share per game rate as a rookie, while Renfrow was at 17.7%. Douglas' average depth of target was 8.0, Renfrow's 7.2 – they were both fairly low. Douglas ran 68% of his routes from the slot, Renfrow 72%. Douglas had a worse yards per route run rate at 1.70, but that's still an above-average number for a high-volume rookie wide receiver.

To put that all another way, Demario Douglas, like Hunter Renfrow, had a pretty great rookie season as a slot guy.

Renfrow had a strong few seasons in the league before dropping off, and Douglas is in a spot to do the same thing. New England lacks alternatives in their offense, and Douglas is a more explosive player than Renfrow ever was. That could allow him to have a longer peak in the NFL.

Douglas is the type of player who's more valuable in dynasty formats with deeper starting rosters. He has a real shot to be somewhat of a target hog in the short term within that offense, and sometimes that's enough to crack your starting lineup, even if those touches aren't overly valuable. It'd be totally reasonable to try to trade for him this offseason if you need a high-floor WR3 or WR4 type.

QUENTIN JOHNSTON

81.6

Y2 Score

WR

Los Angeles Chargers



89.7

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

8.0

Journey Comps: Stephen Hill ▪ Jonathan Baldwin ▪ Nelson Agholor

Quentin Johnston had a wide range of outcomes entering the league, and it's looking like he's hitting the lower-end of that range.

Johnston's list of Journey Comparables are Dexter-series-finale levels of bad. We're looking at a lumberjack ending. Stephen Hill played two years in the NFL. Jonathan Baldwin (Hail 2 Pitt!) played three. Nelson Agholor is still getting cardio on the football field at times, now for Baltimore, but he's been a huge first-round disappointment.

A Year 2 score of 81.6 isn't a death sentence, per se, but when a wide receiver sees this big of a dip, it's close to one.

Johnston ended his rookie season with a 0.88 yards per route run rate. Of the wide receivers in the Year 2 Model with a sub-1.0 rookie-season yards per route run rate and a ZAP score between 85 and 95, just two were able to have a season in either Year 2 or Year 3 with 13 or more PPR points per game. Those two were DJ Chark, who's mostly disappeared ever since, and Davante Adams, who ended up being one of the biggest post-rookie season outliers in the history of the sport. The majority of these players – 68% of them, to be exact – were unable to get to 10 or more PPR points per game as second- or third-year wide receivers.

That's just one (predictive) data point, yes. There are plenty of others that paint a terrible picture for Johnston. He saw a target on fewer than 14% of his routes run last year. Only five other rookie wide receivers with 50 or more targets since 2011 were that bad at getting looks. His target share per game, despite playing in an offense that needed weapons throughout the season, was under 11%.

The list goes on and on.

It would be pretty surprising if Johnston turns things around, especially now that he's going to be playing with a new coach in what's expected to be a more run-centric offense. I know it seems early to say that, but we have plenty of evidence suggesting that turnarounds from a player like this are rare.

You don't, however, need to trade him away for anything. The market, in most cases, is already accounting for this. I just wouldn't blame you for trying.

MARVIN MIMS

80.3

Y2 Score

WR

Denver Broncos



79.0

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

7.5

Journey Comps: Randall Cobb ▪ Denzel Mims ▪ KJ Hamler

It's easy to fall victim to anchoring bias in fantasy football. When something interesting goes down early in the season, that something becomes ingrained into our minds. We remember it. It's anchored. And we often assume it continues throughout the duration of the season.

Marvin Mims started the 2023 season off hot. Kind of. He was so, so efficient with his touches – he was one of the league-leaders in yards per route run for the first chunk of the season – but the volume wasn't matching. The Broncos just refused to give him more work in the offense, giving touches to players like Brandon Johnson instead.

If we take off our Marvin Mims blinders...maybe the Broncos were right?

We knew we were working with small sample sizes, but Mims regressed across the final three-quarters of the season. His ending yards per route run rate was a fairly ordinary 1.54. That's not a bad number, but when you combine it with a 7.4% target share per game average, it's not nearly enough to think Mims is a star.

Denver used Mims in a similar way that he was used in college: down the field. As an Oklahoma Sooner, Mims had average depth of targets of 17.0, 17.6, and 15.4. Totally absurd numbers. As a rookie for the Broncos, his aDOT was 15.2. That's an 85th percentile mark among rookie wideouts since 2011.

We just didn't see enough Mims in 2023 to say he's definitively good or bad. We know that usage is indicative of future success, and Mims wasn't able to hit strong numbers on the volume front. That matters. Since 2011, of the hundreds of wideouts in the Year 2 Model database who failed to get past an 8% target share per game rate as rookies, only 14 were able to score 10 or more PPR points per game in either Year 2 or Year 3. Randall Cobb is by far the best player in that group. The rest have been pretty replaceable assets in fantasy football.

Fortunately, Mims should see opportunity in 2024 with Jerry Jeudy getting traded to Cleveland. In early March, Sean Payton mentioned that Mims played a redundant role to Jeudy in the Denver offense, so we should see him as a starter this year.

It just seems reasonable to not expect high-end production. Getting WR2 output is in Mims' range of outcomes, but anything more would kind of make him an outlier.

JALIN HYATT

80.2

Y2 Score

WR

New York Giants



88.9

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

7.4

Journey Comps: Rueben Randle ▪ Ryan Broyles ▪ Stephen Hill

Both the Z-Prospect Model and the ZAP Model are Jalin Hyatt fans. He had nearly a 90 ZAP score in spite of third-round draft capital, driven by a Fred Biletnikoff Award-winning season in 2022.

Hyatt did have some concerning pieces to his analytical prospect profile. During that wild and productive 2022 campaign, he lined up in the slot on 87% of his snaps. As someone who profiled more as a field-stretching perimeter receiver in the NFL, there were questions as to how that would translate.

The answer thus far: Not well. Hyatt was in the slot on just 11.7% of his routes run as a rookie – that's Wan'Dale Robinson's role for New York – and he captured just an 8.3% target share. His yards per route run couldn't reach 1.00, a figure that most first-year wide receivers get to.

Hyatt did have a positive catch rate over expected, per Next Gen Stats, and he ended the year with an absurd 20.7 average depth of target. If we're being honest, it's hard to ask a lot from a player when he's being used in a fairly one-dimensional way within an offense that had bad quarterback play.

That does mean that we should be wary of the Giants using Hyatt in a higher-volume capacity, though. He's not a proven outside receiver, and they've got plenty of options in the slot. The only way I'd be optimistic is if we get word that his role is going to change.

JONATHAN MINGO

80.0

Y2 Score

WR

Carolina Panthers



82.0

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

7.1

Journey Comps: Dede Westbrook ▪ Bryan Edwards ▪ Taywan Taylor

The ZAP Model database has over 400 wide receivers in it who failed to reach a 0.80 yards per route run rate during their rookie seasons. Many of those wideouts were undrafted and didn't get a lot of run as first-year players, but among that group, only four were able to score 12 or more PPR points per game in either Year 2 or Year 3. Those four were Cecil Shorts, Allen Hurns, Willie Snead, and Nelson Agholor, players who didn't amount to much from a fantasy perspective in the NFL.

Jonathan Mingo, ladies and gentlemen, had a 0.78 yards per route run in 2023.

Woof.

The odds that Mingo ends up being a reliable contributor for us in pretend pigskin are slim. He was bottom five in the NFL in catch rate over expected, per Next Gen Stats, and he scored just 5.7 PPR points per game.

The market seems to have corrected for Mingo, as his dynasty startup average draft position is much lower than it was a year ago. Because the Panthers are going through so much change this offseason, you could argue that trading Mingo away right now just isn't worth it. He's ranked as the WR60. You can't get much for him. Why not just ride it out, see if Bryce Young takes a massive Year 2 leap with Dave Canales, and cross your fingers for WR3 or WR4 production from Mingo?

That's what I'd likely do, even though we shouldn't expect much from Mingo moving forward. You'd be lucky to get WR4 numbers based on history.

TRE TUCKER

77.8

Y2 Score

WR

Las Vegas Raiders



63.4

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

6.6

Journey Comps: Quintez Cephus ▪ Kelvin Harmon ▪ Marquez Valdes-Scantling

Tre Tucker's Year 2 score, to be quite honest, is surprising. He came into the league with a 63.4 ZAP score and an awfully poor Draft Capital Delta, and he only scored 4.8 PPR points per game as a rookie.

Why does his Year 2 score look...competent?

Tucker finished 2023 with a yards per route run of 1.48. That's pretty ordinary for a first-year wideout, but for a receiver with such a poor ZAP score, it's actually not a bad number.

Do I believe Tucker is going to be a fantasy wideout you can lean on? No, I don't. He had only a 7.3% target share per game average for the Raiders last year, and his Journey Comparables aren't very inspiring. If we had someone in there who was a long-term winner, maybe we could throw a fifth-round pick out there for Tucker. But there aren't many successful wide receivers who've seen his marks.

If he's on your dynasty league's waiver wire, then, sure, throw that dart. Maybe he can turn into a true vertical threat for the Raiders after hitting a 19.2 average depth of target in 2023. His Year 2 score definitely tells us that he should at least be rostered.

Just don't expect him to be anything more than a bye week fill-in.

TREY PALMER

77.0

Y2 Score

WR

Tampa Bay Buccaneers



52.7

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

6.3

Journey Comps: Mack Hollins ▪ JJ Nelson ▪ Travis Benjamin

The Year 2 Model doesn't like Trey Palmer as much as I do.

Remember, it's fine to inject some subjectivity into this process.

Palmer's lower-than-anticipated Year 2 score comes down to the fact that he played with Chris Godwin and Mike Evans last year. When that's the case, it's going to be hard to post efficient numbers.

And his numbers definitely weren't efficient. His 12.4% target share per game rate wasn't all that bad, but a 0.84 yards per route run average isn't going to cut it. Neither is getting a target on 15% of his routes run.

As you read with Jonathan Mingo, players with that low of a yards per route run rate almost always fail to become consistent producers in fantasy football. The difference between Mingo and Palmer is that Palmer actually played alongside legit competition.

But that competition might not change.

Mike Evans is staying in Tampa given the new contract he recently received. There's a chance the Bucs cut Chris Godwin – there's an out for them this offseason – but that's not close to a lock. If the two of them are back, then Palmer is stuck in a similar spot as he was in 2023.

Strictly from a numbers standpoint, we're not looking at a wide receiver who's probably anything more than a depth piece without an injury in his offense. You could consider going after him in best ball – that's different – but as a reliable option? He'll need Godwin out in order to get there.

CEDRIC TILLMAN

73.0

Y2 Score

WR

Cleveland Browns



79.9

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

5.1

Journey Comps: JJ Arcega-Whiteside ▪ Brian Quick ▪ Josh Boyce

Yards per route run has been referenced about 500 times so far in this guide. Because it's predictive. It matters. It's an indicator for future success.

Cedric Tillman, among all 158 rookie wide receivers since 2011 to hit 40 first-year targets, had the worst – the 158th – yards per route run rate.

We can keep this pretty short: Tillman is going to need to be a big anomaly to work out in fantasy football. Not only is the yards per route run grouping him in a low-probability bucket, but players with Year 2 scores between 65 and 75 have yet to give fantasy managers a season of 16 or more PPR points per game in either Year 2 or Year 3. Only DJ Chark scored more than 12 points in one of those seasons.

Elijah Moore and Amari Cooper are likely to be around in 2024, and Cleveland just added Jerry Jeudy to the mix. Things are not looking good for Tillman, a player some draft analysts really loved last offseason.

AT PERRY

72.8

Y2 Score

WR

New Orleans Saints



40.9

ZAP Score

Expected Max PPR PPG Season:

5.1

Journey Comps: Jeremy Kerley ▪ Rishard Matthews ▪ Cody Core

We can't say AT Perry didn't have opportunity in 2023. Michael Thomas was his usual banged-up self, Chris Olave missed a game, and Rashid Shaheed missed a couple, too. Perry turned in just one top-30 performance, and it came in Week 18 when he caught all three of his targets for 53 yards and a pair of scores.

Perry had an OK Breakout Score in the ZAP Model, but after getting selected 195th overall last year, we had to temper expectations. And hopefully you did just that. He finished his rookie campaign with a below-average 1.18 yards per route run rate, barely surpassing 6 PPR points per game.

On the plus side of things, only six wide receivers had a better catch rate over expected than Perry last year. He also led the NFL, according to Next Gen Stats, in passer rating when targeted. That's not all that meaningful on the forecasting side of things, but it's still noteworthy.

Perry is probably going to be a role player in fantasy football. You can keep him on your bench, but we shouldn't imagine a world where he's an every-week starter. That just doesn't happen for players with a 72.8 Year 2 score very often at all.

Closing

This has been cool. For real. A lot of work goes into this thing each year, and reading messages of excitement about the guide is awesome. It sincerely puts a smile on my face.

And I hope this monstrosity put a smile on yours.

There's no guarantee that my analysis will spot this year's Isiah Pacheco or Tank Dell. I can't promise a flawless rookie draft for you.

But I *can* tell you that **this process is very real**. We've now beat the fantasy football market with two prospect guides, and I'm ready for a threepeat.

If you're reading something like this, you've got, without a doubt, a little bit of nerd in you. (Probably a lot of nerd, if we're being honest.) It's been a pleasure to be a total geek with you.

Here's to another year of rookie draft values.



Rankings

Rookie Rankings

Single-QB Top-48					Superflex Top-48				
	Player	Pos	Pos	Tier		Player	Pos	Pos	Tier
1	Marvin Harrison	WR	1	1	1	Caleb Williams	QB	1	1
2	Malik Nabers	WR	2	2	2	Marvin Harrison	WR	1	1
3	Rome Odunze	WR	3	3	3	Malik Nabers	WR	2	2
4	Xavier Worthy	WR	4	4	4	Jayden Daniels	QB	2	2
5	Brian Thomas	WR	5	4	5	Drake Maye	QB	3	3
6	Brock Bowers	TE	1	4	6	JJ McCarthy	QB	4	3
7	Jonathon Brooks	RB	1	4	7	Rome Odunze	WR	3	3
8	Caleb Williams	QB	1	5	8	Xavier Worthy	WR	4	4
9	Jayden Daniels	QB	2	5	9	Brian Thomas	WR	5	4
10	Ricky Pearsall	WR	6	6	10	Bo Nix	QB	5	4
11	Ladd McConkey	WR	7	6	11	Brock Bowers	TE	1	4
12	Keon Coleman	WR	8	6	12	Jonathon Brooks	RB	1	4
13	Trey Benson	RB	2	6	13	Michael Penix	QB	6	5
14	Drake Maye	QB	3	7	14	Ricky Pearsall	WR	6	5
15	JJ McCarthy	QB	4	7	15	Ladd McConkey	WR	7	5
16	Ja'Lynn Polk	WR	9	7	16	Keon Coleman	WR	8	5
17	Xavier Legette	WR	10	7	17	Trey Benson	RB	2	5
18	Adonai Mitchell	WR	11	7	18	Ja'Lynn Polk	WR	9	6
19	Jermaine Burton	WR	12	8	19	Xavier Legette	WR	10	6
20	MarShawn Lloyd	RB	3	8	20	Adonai Mitchell	WR	11	6
21	Jaylen Wright	RB	4	8	21	Jermaine Burton	WR	12	7
22	Troy Franklin	WR	13	8	22	MarShawn Lloyd	RB	3	7
23	Roman Wilson	WR	14	8	23	Jaylen Wright	RB	4	7
24	Bo Nix	QB	5	9	24	Troy Franklin	WR	13	7
25	Ben Sinnott	TE	2	9	25	Roman Wilson	WR	14	8
26	Malachi Corley	WR	15	9	26	Ben Sinnott	TE	2	8
27	Javon Baker	WR	16	9	27	Malachi Corley	WR	15	8
28	Blake Corum	RB	5	9	28	Javon Baker	WR	16	8
29	Kimani Vidal	RB	6	10	29	Blake Corum	RB	5	8
30	Malik Washington	WR	17	10	30	Kimani Vidal	RB	6	9
31	Jalen McMillan	WR	18	10	31	Malik Washington	WR	17	9
32	Michael Penix	QB	6	10	32	Spencer Rattler	QB	7	9
33	Ray Davis	RB	7	10	33	Jalen McMillan	WR	18	9
34	Jacob Cowing	WR	19	10	34	Ray Davis	RB	7	9
35	Ainias Smith	WR	20	11	35	Jacob Cowing	WR	19	9
36	Tyrone Tracy	RB	8	11	36	Ainias Smith	WR	20	10
37	Ja'Tavion Sanders	TE	3	11	37	Tyrone Tracy	RB	8	10
38	Rasheen Ali	RB	9	11	38	Ja'Tavion Sanders	TE	3	10
39	Devontez Walker	WR	21	11	39	Rasheen Ali	RB	9	10
40	Theo Johnson	TE	4	11	40	Devontez Walker	WR	21	10
41	Luke McCaffrey	WR	22	11	41	Theo Johnson	TE	4	10
42	Dylan Laube	RB	10	11	42	Luke McCaffrey	WR	22	10
43	Erick All	TE	5	12	43	Dylan Laube	RB	10	10
44	Braelon Allen	RB	11	12	44	Erick All	TE	5	11
45	Isaac Guerendo	RB	12	12	45	Braelon Allen	RB	11	11
46	Jaheim Bell	TE	6	12	46	Isaac Guerendo	RB	12	11
47	Audric Esteime	RB	13	12	47	Jaheim Bell	TE	6	11
48	Will Shipley	RB	14	12	48	Audric Esteime	RB	13	11

ZAP Model Rankings

Running Back			Wide Receiver			Tight End		
	Player	ZAP		Player	ZAP		Player	ZAP
1	Jonathon Brooks	93.8	1	Malik Nabers	99.5	1	Brock Bowers	99.3
2	Trey Benson	84.1	2	Marvin Harrison	99.3	2	Ben Sinnott	83.9
3	Blake Corum	79.1	3	Rome Odunze	96.0	3	Tip Reiman	81.8
4	MarShawn Lloyd	74.6	4	Xavier Worthy	95.6	4	Theo Johnson	73.4
5	Braelon Allen	72.3	5	Brian Thomas	94.5	5	Jaheim Bell	68.5
6	Jaylen Wright	70.7	6	Ricky Pearsall	89.7	6	Ja'Tavion Sanders	67.8
7	Isaiah Davis	70.0	7	Ladd McConkey	87.5	7	Erick All	63.6
8	Ray Davis	69.8	8	Ja'Lynn Polk	86.5	8	Cade Stover	51.7
9	Will Shipley	67.8	9	Keon Coleman	86.4	9	AJ Barner	50.3
10	Isaac Guerendo	66.4	10	Xavier Legette	86.2	10	Jared Wiley	44.1
11	Dylan Laube	63.9	11	Adonai Mitchell	84.0	11	Tanner McLachlan	20.3
12	Rasheen Ali	62.5	12	Troy Franklin	77.7	12	Devin Culp	6.3
13	Kimani Vidal	59.8	13	Jermaine Burton	76.9			
14	Audric Esteime	58.7	14	Roman Wilson	75.7			
15	Jase McClellan	58.2	15	Jalen McMillan	74.6			
16	Keilan Robinson	54.4	16	Malachi Corley	71.8			
17	Tyrone Tracy	51.7	17	Luke McCaffrey	69.5			
18	Bucky Irving	51.0	18	Javon Baker	67.6			
19	Frank Gore	49.8	19	Jacob Cowing	65.5			
20	Jaden Shirden	41.4	20	Devontez Walker	65.3			
21	George Holani	39.6	21	Ainias Smith	64.1			
22	Michael Wiley	33.1	22	Jha'Quan Jackson	53.4			
23	Daijun Edwards	22.2	23	Malik Washington	51.5			
24	Cody Schrader	17.9	24	Jamari Thrash	49.3			
25	Miyan Williams	15.8	25	Anthony Gould	49.2			

Rookie Rankings Notes

- Marvin Harrison is now in a tier above Malik Nabers because of his Year 1 safety. Nabers is just as good of a player, but Harrison projects better for 2024 in the Arizona offense, and that's enough to separate the two. Make no mistake: Nabers is still elite.
- Many may consider these rankings low on Brock Bowers, but Xavier Worthy and Brian Thomas got the capital and found great landing spots. I have some concerns about the Raiders using Bowers properly — he was sort of a luxury pick on a rebuilding team, and that makes me naturally question them. They've also got Michael Mayer there along with no real quarterback plan. He's still in the same tier as those wideouts, but I prefer the wide receivers in a vacuum. Sam LaPorta is coming off the best tight end rookie season of all time and he still isn't reaching the first round of superflex drafts. Tight end is just devalued.
- Yes, Drake Maye versus JJ McCarthy is a very tough decision. McCarthy has a better projection for me in Year 1, if that helps.
- Knowing what to do with Michael Penix is impossible because I'm not sure Atlanta knows what they want to do with him. He's one of those "feel out your draft" kind of players.
- The Pearsall/McConkey/Coleman tier is quite difficult to decipher. A move by the 49ers makes Pearsall the clear winner there. Without a move, and he could have a rougher first year. I just used the model to decide, in the end.
- A big debate folks are probably going to have is Ja'Lynn Polk versus Adonai Mitchell. The model sees Polk as the better prospect, and as Mitchell's write-up says, Indianapolis is kind of an overrated wide receiver destination. They're in the same tier, but give me Polk.
- The running back class didn't get ideal landing spots. Blake Corum took a huge hit by going to LA, so he was subjectively bumped down in the rookie rankings. Would anyone be surprised if Kimani Vidal had a better rookie campaign? Corum's in a tier above Vidal because of

talent and prospect score, but Vidal is an underrated back. Don't sleep on him.

- The model is low on Malachi Corley, so I'm relatively low on Malachi Corley. Of course the Jets could force feed him the ball in ways that'll maximize his strengths — almost like what the Chiefs did with Rashee Rice last year — but I don't trust that offensive staff. I also don't think Corley is as good as Rice was as a prospect. Huge variance to his profile.
- You can probably figure out why players are ranked where they're ranked based on their write-ups. That's what they're for, after all. There are a lot of players — Jaylen Wright, MarShawn Lloyd, Jacob Cowing — who may end up being more stashes than huge Year 1 winners. Keep that in mind as you draft.